

Fly Steffen's *Three Sisters*

Pre-Production Dramaturgy

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(artwork by Lucy Campbell)

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Adaptations

The Three Sisters by David Mamet

This faithful adaptation is what you might expect from Mamet in its language.

Orchards

Dramaturg Anne Cattaneo commissioned seven playwrights to adapt Chekhov's short stories including David Mamet, Wendy Wasserstein, Maria Irene Fornes, Spalding Gray, John Guare, Michael Weller and Samm-Art Williams

Brace Up Wooster Group

This deconstructed, Brechtian adaptation makes the audience very aware of the company's act of adaptation. Challenging and funny, this adaptation freely plays with characterization but maintains large chunks of Chekhov's language.

We Are Three Sisters Blake Morrison

The three sisters are the three Bronte sisters. Some scholarship suggests Chekhov based his original on the Bronte sisters. In this adaptation, the women are more activated because they have a clear idea of what they want out of life, their Moscow is writing.

Hong Kong Three Sisters

I saw a production of **this** in Edinburgh this past August. The play, entirely in Cantonese, was heavily based in movement— initially. Somewhere in Act II, the actor playing Masha disappears and the actors are left to entertain the audience until someone finds her. Each actor presents a short performance about their life in Hong Kong. The play wraps up quickly with an abbreviated Act IV. The show uses *Three Sisters* as an excuse to tell the audience about Hong Kong culture. Eventually, the audience, especially an audience who knows the story, stops listening for plot details and is more focused on the blurring lines between actor/character.

Three Sisters by Tracy Letts

The Fourth Sister by Janusz Glowacki

The Break of Day Timberlake Wertenbaker

Chekhov's Three Sisters by Sarah Ruhl

(This is a list in progress, I'm trying to be aware of all the directions this play can take and how writer's push its limits.)

THE LADY WITH THE DOG

I

It was said that a new person had appeared on the sea-front: a lady with a little dog. Dmitri Dmitritch Gurov, who had by then been a fortnight at Yalta,* and so was fairly at home there, had begun to take an interest in new arrivals. Sitting in Verney's pavilion, he saw, walking on the sea-front, a fair-haired young lady of medium height, wearing a *béret*; a white Pomeranian dog was running behind her.

And afterwards he met her in the public gardens and in the square several times a day. She was walking alone, always wearing the same *béret*, and always with the same white dog; no one knew who she was, and everyone called her simply "the lady with the dog."

"If she is here alone without a husband or friends, it wouldn't be amiss to make her acquaintance," Gurov reflected.

He was under forty, but he had a daughter already twelve years old, and two sons at school. He had been married young, when he was a student in his second year, and by now his wife seemed half as old again as he. She was a tall, erect woman with dark eyebrows, staid and dignified, and, as she said of herself, intellectual. She read a great deal, used phonetic spelling, called her husband, not Dmitri, but Dimitri, and he secretly considered her unintelligent, narrow, inelegant, was afraid of her, and did not like to be at home. He had begun being unfaithful to her long ago—had been unfaithful to her often, and, probably on that account, almost always spoke ill of women, and when they were talked about in his presence, used to call them "the lower race."

It seemed to him that he had been so schooled by bitter experience that he might call them what he liked, and yet he could not get

*Resort town in Crimea, set amid orchards and vineyards.

on for two days together without "the lower race." In the society of men he was bored and not himself, with them he was cold and uncommunicative; but when he was in the company of women he felt free, and knew what to say to them and how to behave; and he was at ease with them even when he was silent. In his appearance, in his character, in his whole nature, there was something attractive and elusive which allured women and disposed them in his favour; he knew that, and some force seemed to draw him, too, to them.

Experience often repeated, truly bitter experience, had taught him long ago that with decent people, especially Moscow people—always slow to move and irresolute—every intimacy, which at first so agreeably diversifies life and appears a light and charming adventure, inevitably grows into a regular problem of extreme intricacy, and in the long run the situation becomes unbearable. But at every fresh meeting with an interesting woman this experience seemed to slip out of his memory, and he was eager for life, and everything seemed simple and amusing.

One evening he was dining in the gardens, and the lady in the *béret* came up slowly to take the next table. Her expression, her gait, her dress, and the way she did her hair told him that she was a lady, that she was married, that she was in Yalta for the first time and alone, and that she was dull there. . . . The stories told of the immorality in such places as Yalta are to a great extent untrue; he despised them, and knew that such stories were for the most part made up by persons who would themselves have been glad to sin if they had been able; but when the lady sat down at the next table three paces from him, he remembered these tales of easy conquests, of trips to the mountains, and the tempting thought of a swift, fleeting love affair, a romance with an unknown woman, whose name he did not know, suddenly took possession of him.

He beckoned coaxingly to the Pomeranian, and when the dog came up to him he shook his finger at it. The Pomeranian growled, Gurov shook his finger at it again.

The lady looked at him and at once dropped her eyes.

"He doesn't bite," she said, and blushed.

"May I give him a bone?" he asked; and when she nodded he asked courteously, "Have you been long in Yalta?"

"Five days."

"And I have already dragged out a fortnight here."

There was a brief silence.

"Time goes fast, and yet it is so dull here!" she said, not looking at him.

"That's only the fashion to say it is dull here. A provincial will live in Belyov* or Zhidra† and not be dull, and when he comes here it's 'Oh, the dullness! Oh, the dust!' One would think he came from Grenada."

She laughed. Then both continued eating in silence, like strangers, but after dinner they walked side by side; and there sprang up between them the light jesting conversation of people who are free and satisfied, to whom it does not matter where they go or what they talk about. They walked and talked of the strange light on the sea: the water was of a soft warm lilac hue, and there was a golden streak from the moon upon it. They talked of how sultry it was after a hot day. Gurov told her that he came from Moscow, that he had taken his degree in Arts, but had a post in a bank; that he had trained as an opera-singer, but had given it up, that he owned two houses in Moscow. . . . And from her he learnt that she had grown up in Petersburg, but had lived in S—— since her marriage two years before, that she was staying another month in Yalta, and that her husband, who needed a holiday too, might perhaps come and fetch her. She was not sure whether her husband had a post in a Crown Department or under the Provincial Council—and was amused by her own ignorance. And Gurov learnt, too, that she was called Anna Sergeyevna.

Afterwards he thought about her in his room at the hotel—thought she would certainly meet him next day; it would be sure to happen. As he got into bed he thought how lately she had been a girl at school, doing lessons like his own daughter; he recalled the diffidence, the angularity, that was still manifest in her laugh and her manner of talking with a stranger. This must have been the first time in her life she had been alone in surroundings in which she was followed, looked at, and spoken to merely from a secret motive

*Town some 150 miles from Moscow.

†Town some 200 miles from Moscow.

which she could hardly fail to guess. He recalled her slender, delicate neck, her lovely grey eyes.

"There's something pathetic about her, anyway," he thought, and fell asleep.

II

A week had passed since they had made acquaintance. It was a holiday. It was sultry indoors, while in the street the wind whirled the dust round and round, and blew people's hats off. It was a thirsty day, and Gurov often went into the pavilion, and pressed Anna Sergeyevna to have syrup and water or an ice. One did not know what to do with oneself.

In the evening when the wind had dropped a little, they went out on to the groyne to see the steamer come in. There were a great many people walking about the harbour; they had gathered to welcome someone, bringing bouquets. And two peculiarities of a well-dressed Yalta crowd were very conspicuous: the elderly ladies were dressed like young ones, and there were great numbers of generals.

Owing to the roughness of the sea, the steamer arrived late, after the sun had set, and it was a long time turning about before it reached the groyne. Anna Sergeyevna looked through her lorgnette at the steamer and the passengers as though looking for acquaintances, and when she turned to Gurov her eyes were shining. She talked a great deal and asked disconnected questions, forgetting next moment what she had asked; then she dropped her lorgnette in the crush.

The festive crowd began to disperse; it was too dark to see people's faces. The wind had completely dropped, but Gurov and Anna Sergeyevna still stood as though waiting to see someone else come from the steamer. Anna Sergeyevna was silent now, and sniffed the flowers without looking at Gurov.

"The weather is better this evening," he said. "Where shall we go now? Shall we drive somewhere?"

She made no answer.

Then he looked at her intently, and all at once put his arm round her and kissed her on the lips, and breathed in the moisture and the fragrance of the flowers; and he immediately looked round him, anxiously wondering whether anyone had seen them.

"Let us go to your hotel," he said softly. And both walked quickly.

The room was close and smelt of the scent she had bought at the Japanese shop. Gurov looked at her and thought: "What different people one meets in the world!" From the past he preserved memories of careless, good-natured women, who loved cheerfully and were grateful to him for the happiness he gave them, however brief it might be; and of women like his wife who loved without any genuine feeling, with superfluous phrases, affectedly, hysterically, with an expression that suggested that it was not love nor passion, but something more significant; and of two or three others, very beautiful, cold women, on whose faces he had caught a glimpse of a rapacious expression—an obstinate desire to snatch from life more than it could give, and these were capricious, unreflecting, domineering, unintelligent women not in their first youth, and when Gurov grew cold to them their beauty excited his hatred, and the lace on their linen seemed to him like scales.

But in this case there was still the diffidence, the angularity of inexperienced youth, an awkward feeling; and there was a sense of consternation as though someone had suddenly knocked at the door. The attitude of Anna Sergeyevna—"the lady with the dog"—to what had happened was somehow peculiar, very grave, as though it were her fall—so it seemed, and it was strange and inappropriate. Her face drooped and faded, and on both sides of it her long hair hung down mournfully; she mused in a dejected attitude like "the woman who was a sinner" in an old-fashioned picture.

"It's wrong," she said. "You will be the first to despise me now."

There was a water-melon on the table. Gurov cut himself a slice and began eating it without haste. There followed at least half an hour of silence.

Anna Sergeyevna was touching; there was about her the purity of a good, simple woman who had seen little of life. The solitary candle burning on the table threw a faint light on her face, yet it was clear that she was very unhappy.

"How could I despise you?" asked Gurov. "You don't know what you are saying."

"God forgive me," she said, and her eyes filled with tears. "It's awful."

"You seem to feel you need to be forgiven."

"Forgiven? No. I am a bad, low woman; I despise myself and don't attempt to justify myself. It's not my husband but myself I have deceived. And not only just now; I have been deceiving myself for a long time. My husband may be a good, honest man, but he is a flunkey! I don't know what he does there, what his work is, but I know he is a flunkey! I was twenty when I was married to him. I have been tormented by curiosity; I wanted something better. 'There must be a different sort of life,' I said to myself. I wanted to live! To live, to live! . . . I was fired by curiosity . . . you don't understand it, but, I swear to God, I could not control myself; something happened to me: I could not be restrained. I told my husband I was ill, and came here. . . . And here I have been walking about as though I were dazed, like a mad creature; . . . and now I have become a vulgar, contemptible woman whom anyone may despise."

Gurov felt bored already, listening to her. He was irritated by the naïve tone, by this remorse, so unexpected and inopportune; but for the tears in her eyes, he might have thought she was jesting or playing a part.

"I don't understand," he said softly. "What is it you want?"

She hid her face on his breast and pressed close to him.

"Believe me, believe me, I beseech you . . ." she said. "I love a pure, honest life, and sin is loathsome to me. I don't know what I am doing. Simple people say: 'The Evil One has beguiled me.' And I may say of myself now that the Evil One has beguiled me."

"Hush, hush! . . ." he muttered.

He looked at her fixed, scared eyes, kissed her, talked softly and affectionately, and by degrees she was comforted, and her gaiety returned; they both began laughing.

Afterwards when they went out there was not a soul on the seafront. The town with its cypresses had quite a deathlike air, but the sea still broke noisily on the shore; a single barge was rocking on the waves, and the lantern was blinking sleepily on it.

They found a cab and drove to Oreanda.*

"I found out your surname in the hall just now: it was written on

*Beautiful spot on the Crimean coast near Yalta.

the board—Von Diderits," said Gurov. "Is your husband a German?"

"No; I believe his grandfather was a German, but he is an Orthodox Russian himself."

At Oreanda they sat on a seat not far from the church, looked down at the sea, and were silent. Yalta was hardly visible through the morning mist; white clouds stood motionless on the mountain-tops. The leaves did not stir on the trees, grasshoppers chirruped, and the monotonous hollow sound of the sea, rising up from below, spoke of the peace, of the eternal sleep awaiting us. So it must have sounded when there was no Yalta, no Oreanda here; so it sounds now, and it will sound as indifferently and monotonously when we are all no more. And in this constancy, in this complete indifference to the life and death of each of us, there lies hid, perhaps, a pledge of our eternal salvation, of the unceasing movement of life upon earth, of unceasing progress towards perfection. Sitting beside a young woman who in the dawn seemed so lovely, soothed and spell-bound in these magical surroundings—the sea, mountains, clouds, the open sky—Gurov thought how in reality everything is beautiful in this world when one reflects: everything except what we think or do ourselves when we forget our human dignity and the higher aims of our existence.

A man walked up to them—probably a keeper—looked at them and walked away. And this detail seemed mysterious and beautiful, too. They saw a steamer come from Theodosia,* with its lights out in the glow of dawn.

"There is dew on the grass," said Anna Sergeyevna, after a silence.

"Yes. It's time to go home."

They went back to the town.

Then they met every day at twelve o'clock on the sea-front, lunched and dined together, went for walks, admired the sea. She complained that she slept badly, that her heart throbbed violently; asked the same questions, troubled now by jealousy and now by the fear that he did not respect her sufficiently. And often in the square

*Resort on the Crimean coast.

or gardens, when there was no one near them, he suddenly drew her to him and kissed her passionately. Complete idleness, these kisses in broad daylight while he looked round in dread of someone's seeing them, the heat, the smell of the sea, and the continual passing to and fro before him of idle, well-dressed, well-fed people, made a new man of him; he told Anna Sergeyevna how beautiful she was, how fascinating. He was impatiently passionate, he would not move a step away from her, while she was often pensive and continually urged him to confess that he did not respect her, did not love her in the least, and thought of her as nothing but a common woman. Rather late almost every evening they drove somewhere out of town, to Oreanda or to the waterfall; and the expedition was always a success, the scenery invariably impressed them as grand and beautiful.

They were expecting her husband to come, but a letter came from him, saying that there was something wrong with his eyes, and he entreated his wife to come home as quickly as possible. Anna Sergeyevna made haste to go.

"It's a good thing I am going away," she said to Gurov. "It's the finger of destiny!"

She went by coach and he went with her. They were driving the whole day. When she had got into a compartment of the express, and when the second bell had rung, she said:

"Let me look at you once more . . . look at you once again. That's right."

She did not shed tears, but was so sad that she seemed ill, and her face was quivering.

"I shall remember you . . . think of you," she said. "God be with you; be happy. Don't remember evil against me. We are parting for ever—it must be so, for we ought never to have met. Well, God be with you."

The train moved off rapidly, its lights soon vanished from sight, and a minute later there was no sound of it, as though everything had conspired together to end as quickly as possible that sweet delirium, that madness. Left alone on the platform, and gazing into the dark distance, Gurov listened to the chirrup of the grasshoppers and the hum of the telegraph wires, feeling as though he had only just waked up. And he thought, musing, that there had been an-

other episode or adventure in his life, and it, too, was at an end, and nothing was left of it but a memory. . . . He was moved, sad, and conscious of a slight remorse. This young woman whom he would never meet again had not been happy with him; he was genuinely warm and affectionate with her, but yet in his manner, his tone, and his caresses there had been a shade of light irony, the coarse condescension of a happy man who was, besides, almost twice her age. All the time she had called him kind, exceptional, lofty; obviously he had seemed to her different from what he really was, so he had unintentionally deceived her. . . .

Here at the station was already a scent of autumn; it was a cold evening.

"It's time for me to go north," thought Gurov as he left the platform. "High time!"

III

At home in Moscow everything was in its winter routine; the stoves were heated, and in the morning it was still dark when the children were having breakfast and getting ready for school, and the nurse would light the lamp for a short time. The frosts had begun already. When the first snow has fallen, on the first day of sledge-driving it is pleasant to see the white earth, the white roofs, to draw soft, delicious breath, and the season brings back the days of one's youth. The old limes and birches, white with hoar-frost, have a good-natured expression; they are nearer to one's heart than cypresses and palms, and near them one doesn't want to be thinking of the sea and the mountains.

Gurov was Moscow born; he arrived in Moscow on a fine frosty day, and when he put on his fur coat and warm gloves, and walked along Petrovka, and when on Saturday evening he heard the ringing of the bells, his recent trip and the places he had seen lost all charm for him. Little by little he became absorbed in Moscow life, greedily read three newspapers a day, and declared he did not read the Moscow papers on principle! He already felt a longing to go to restaurants, clubs, dinner-parties, anniversary celebrations, and he felt flattered at entertaining distinguished lawyers and artists, and at

playing cards with a professor at the doctors' club. He could already eat a whole plateful of salt fish and cabbage. . . .

In another month, he fancied, the image of Anna Sergeyevna would be shrouded in a mist in his memory, and only from time to time would visit him in his dreams with a touching smile as others did. But more than a month passed, real winter had come, and everything was still clear in his memory as though he had parted with Anna Sergeyevna only the day before. And his memories glowed more and more vividly. When in the evening stillness he heard from his study the voices of his children, preparing their lessons, or when he listened to a song or the organ at the restaurant, or the storm howled in the chimney, suddenly everything would rise up in his memory: what had happened on the groyne, and the early morning with the mist on the mountains, and the steamer coming from Theodosia, and the kisses. He would pace a long time about his room, remembering it all and smiling; then his memories passed into dreams, and in his fancy the past was mingled with what was to come. Anna Sergeyevna did not visit him in dreams, but followed him about everywhere like a shadow and haunted him. When he shut his eyes he saw her as though she were living before him, and she seemed to him lovelier, younger, tenderer than she was; and he imagined himself finer than he had been in Yalta. In the evenings she peeped out at him from the bookcase, from the fireplace, from the corner—he heard her breathing, the caressing rustle of her dress. In the street he watched the women, looking for someone like her.

He was tormented by an intense desire to confide his memories to someone. But in his home it was impossible to talk of his love, and he had no one outside; he could not talk to his tenants nor to anyone at the bank. And what had he to talk of? Had he been in love, then? Had there been anything beautiful, poetical, or edifying or simply interesting in his relations with Anna Sergeyevna? And there was nothing for him but to talk vaguely of love, of woman, and no one guessed what it meant; only his wife twitched her black eyebrows, and said: "The part of a ladykiller does not suit you at all, Dimitri."

One evening, coming out of the doctors' club with an official with whom he had been playing cards, he could not resist saying:

"If only you knew what a fascinating woman I made the acquaintance of in Yalta!"

The official got into his sledge and was driving away, but turned suddenly and shouted:

"Dmitri Dmitritch!"

"What?"

"You were right this evening: the sturgeon was a bit too strong!"

These words, so ordinary, for some reason moved Gurov to indignation, and struck him as degrading and unclean. What savage manners, what people! What senseless nights, what uninteresting, uneventful days! The rage for card-playing, the gluttony, the drunkenness, the continual talk always about the same thing. Useless pursuits and conversations always about the same things absorb the better part of one's time, the better part of one's strength, and in the end there is left a life grovelling and curtailed, worthless and trivial, and there is no escaping or getting away from it—just as though one were in a madhouse or a prison.

Gurov did not sleep all night, and was filled with indignation. And he had a headache all next day. And the next night he slept badly; he sat up in bed, thinking, or paced up and down his room. He was sick of his children, sick of the bank; he had no desire to go anywhere or to talk of anything.

In the holidays in December he prepared for a journey, and told his wife he was going to Petersburg to do something in the interests of a young friend—and he set off for S—. What for? He did not very well know himself. He wanted to see Anna Sergeyevna and to talk with her—to arrange a meeting, if possible.

He reached S— in the morning, and took the best room at the hotel, in which the floor was covered with grey army cloth, and on the table was an inkstand, grey with dust and adorned with a figure on horseback, with its hat in its hand and its head broken off. The hotel porter gave him the necessary information; Von Diderits lived in a house of his own in Old Gontcharny Street—it was not far from the hotel: he was rich and lived in good style, and had his own horses; everyone in the town knew him. The porter pronounced the name "Dridirits."

Gurov went without haste to Old Gontcharny Street and found

the house. Just opposite the house stretched a long grey fence adorned with nails.

"One would run away from a fence like that," thought Gurov, looking from the fence to the windows of the house and back again.

He considered: to-day was a holiday, and the husband would probably be at home. And in any case it would be tactless to go into the house and upset her. If he were to send her a note it might fall into her husband's hands, and then it might ruin everything. The best thing was to trust to chance. And he kept walking up and down the street by the fence, waiting for the chance. He saw a beggar go in at the gate and dogs fly at him; then an hour later he heard a piano, and the sounds were faint and indistinct. Probably it was Anna Sergeyevna playing. The front door suddenly opened, and an old woman came out, followed by the familiar white Pomeranian. Gurov was on the point of calling to the dog, but his heart began beating violently, and in his excitement he could not remember the dog's name.

He walked up and down, and loathed the grey fence more and more, and by now he thought irritably that Anna Sergeyevna had forgotten him, and was perhaps already amusing herself with someone else, and that that was very natural in a young woman who had nothing to look at from morning till night but that confounded fence. He went back to his hotel room and sat for a long while on the sofa, not knowing what to do, then he had dinner and a long nap.

"How stupid and worrying it is!" he thought when he woke and looked at the dark windows: it was already evening. "Here I've had a good sleep for some reason. What shall I do in the night?"

He sat on the bed, which was covered by a cheap grey blanket, such as one sees in hospitals, and he taunted himself in his vexation:

"So much for the lady with the dog . . . so much for the adventure. . . . You're in a nice fix. . . ."

That morning at the station a poster in large letters had caught his eyes. "The Geisha"* was to be performed for the first time. He thought of this and went to the theatre.

*Operetta from London by Sidney Jones.

"It's quite possible she may go to the first performance," he thought.

The theatre was full. As in all provincial theatres, there was a fog above the chandelier, the gallery was noisy and restless; in the front row the local dandies were standing up before the beginning of the performance, with their hands behind them; in the Governor's box the Governor's daughter, wearing a boa, was sitting in the front seat, while the Governor himself lurked modestly behind the curtain with only his hands visible; the orchestra was a long time tuning up; the stage curtain swayed. All the time the audience were coming in and taking their seats Gurov looked at them eagerly.

Anna Sergeyevna, too, came in. She sat down in the third row, and when Gurov looked at her his heart contracted, and he understood clearly that for him there was in the whole world no creature so near, so precious, and so important to him; she, this little woman, in no way remarkable, lost in a provincial crowd, with a vulgar lorgnette in her hand, filled his whole life now, was his sorrow and his joy, the one happiness that he now desired for himself, and to the sounds of the inferior orchestra, of the wretched provincial violins, he thought how lovely she was. He thought and dreamed.

A young man with small side-whiskers, tall and stooping, came in with Anna Sergeyevna and sat down beside her; he bent his head at every step and seemed to be continually bowing. Most likely this was the husband whom at Yalta, in a rush of bitter feeling, she had called a flunkey. And there really was in his long figure, his side-whiskers, and the small bald patch on his head, something of the flunkey's obsequiousness; his smile was sugary, and in his button-hole there was some badge of distinction like the number on a waiter.

During the first interval the husband went away to smoke; she remained alone in her stall. Gurov, who was sitting in the stalls, too, went up to her and said in a trembling voice, with a forced smile:

"Good evening."

She glanced at him and turned pale, then glanced again with horror, unable to believe her eyes, and tightly gripped the fan and the lorgnette in her hands, evidently struggling with herself not to faint. Both were silent. She was sitting, he was standing, frightened by her confusion and not venturing to sit down beside her. The vi-

olins and the flute began tuning up. He felt suddenly frightened; it seemed as though all the people in the boxes were looking at them. She got up and went quickly to the door; he followed her, and both walked senselessly along passages, and up and down stairs, and figures in legal, scholastic, and civil service uniforms, all wearing badges, flitted before their eyes. They caught glimpses of ladies, of fur coats hanging on pegs; the draughts blew on them, bringing a smell of stale tobacco. And Gurov, whose heart was beating violently, thought:

"Oh, heavens! Why are these people here and this orchestra! . . ."

And at that instant he recalled how when he had seen Anna Sergeyevna off at the station he had thought that everything was over and they would never meet again. But how far they were still from the end!

On the narrow, gloomy staircase over which was written "To the Amphitheatre," she stopped.

"How you have frightened me!" she said, breathing hard, still pale and overwhelmed. "Oh, how you have frightened me! I am half dead. Why have you come? Why?"

"But do understand, Anna, do understand . . ." he said hastily in a low voice. "I entreat you to understand. . . ."

She looked at him with dread, with entreaty, with love; she looked at him intently, to keep his features more distinctly in her memory.

"I am so unhappy," she went on, not heeding him. "I have thought of nothing but you all the time; I live only in the thought of you. And I wanted to forget, to forget you; but why, oh why, have you come?"

On the landing above them two schoolboys were smoking and looking down, but that was nothing to Gurov; he drew Anna Sergeyevna to him, and began kissing her face, her cheeks, and her hands.

"What are you doing, what are you doing!" she cried in horror, pushing him away. "We are mad. Go away to-day; go away at once. . . . I beseech you by all that is sacred, I implore you. . . . There are people coming this way!"

Someone was coming up the stairs.

"You must go away," Anna Sergeyevna went on in a whisper. "Do

you hear, Dmitri Dmitritch? I will come and see you in Moscow. I have never been happy; I am miserable now, and I never, never shall be happy, never! Don't make me suffer still more! I swear I'll come to Moscow. But now let us part. My precious, good, dear one, we must part!"

She pressed his hand and began rapidly going downstairs, looking round at him, and from her eyes he could see that she really was unhappy. Gurov stood for a little while, listened, then, when all sound had died away, he found his coat and left the theatre.

IV

And Anna Sergeyevna began coming to see him in Moscow. Once in two or three months she left S——, telling her husband that she was going to consult a doctor about an internal complaint—and her husband believed her, and did not believe her. In Moscow she stayed at the Slaviansky Bazaar hotel,* and at once sent a man in a red cap to Gurov. Gurov went to see her, and no one in Moscow knew of it.

Once he was going to see her in this way on a winter morning (the messenger had come the evening before when he was out). With him walked his daughter, whom he wanted to take to school: it was on the way. Snow was falling in big wet flakes.

"It's three degrees above freezing-point, and yet it is snowing," said Gurov to his daughter. "The thaw is only on the surface of the earth; there is quite a different temperature at a greater height in the atmosphere."

"And why are there no thunderstorms in the winter, father?"

He explained that, too. He talked, thinking all the while that he was going to see *her*, and no living soul knew of it, and probably never would know. He had two lives: one, open, seen and known by all who cared to know, full of relative truth and of relative falsehood, exactly like the lives of his friends and acquaintances; and another life running its course in secret. And through some strange, perhaps accidental, conjunction of circumstances, everything that was essen-

*Large hotel in Moscow where Chekhov himself sometimes stayed.

tial, of interest and of value to him, everything in which he was sincere and did not deceive himself, everything that made the kernel of his life, was hidden from other people; and all that was false in him, the sheath in which he hid himself to conceal the truth—such, for instance, as his work in the bank, his discussions at the club, his “lower race,” his presence with his wife at anniversary festivities—all that was open. And he judged of others by himself, not believing in what he saw, and always believing that every man had his real, most interesting life under the cover of secrecy and under the cover of night. All personal life rested on secrecy, and possibly it was partly on that account that civilized man was so nervously anxious that personal privacy should be respected.

After leaving his daughter at school, Gurov went on to the Slaviansky Bazaar. He took off his fur coat below, went upstairs, and softly knocked at the door. Anna Sergeyevna, wearing his favourite grey dress, exhausted by the journey and the suspense, had been expecting him since the evening before. She was pale; she looked at him, and did not smile, and he had hardly come in when she fell on his breast. Their kiss was slow and prolonged, as though they had not met for two years.

“Well, how are you getting on there?” he asked. “What news?”

“Wait; I’ll tell you directly. . . . I can’t talk.”

She could not speak; she was crying. She turned away from him, and pressed her handkerchief to her eyes.

“Let her have her cry out. I’ll sit down and wait,” he thought, and he sat down in an arm-chair.

Then he rang and asked for tea to be brought him, and while he drank his tea she remained standing at the window with her back to him. She was crying from emotion, from the miserable consciousness that their life was so hard for them; they could only meet in secret, hiding themselves from people, like thieves! Was not their life shattered?

“Come, do stop!” he said.

It was evident to him that this love of theirs would not soon be over, that he could not see the end of it. Anna Sergeyevna grew more and more attached to him. She adored him, and it was unthinkable to say to her that it was bound to have an end some day; besides, she would not have believed it!

He went up to her and took her by the shoulders to say something affectionate and cheering, and at that moment he saw himself in the looking-glass.

His hair was already beginning to turn grey. And it seemed strange to him that he had grown so much older, so much plainer during the last few years. The shoulders on which his hands rested were warm and quivering. He felt compassion for this life, still so warm and lovely, but probably already not far from beginning to fade and wither like his own. Why did she love him so much? He always seemed to women different from what he was, and they loved in him not himself, but the man created by their imagination, whom they had been eagerly seeking all their lives; and afterwards, when they noticed their mistake, they loved him all the same. And not one of them had been happy with him. Time passed, he had made their acquaintance, got on with them, parted, but he had never once loved; it was anything you like, but not love.

And only now when his head was grey he had fallen properly, really in love—for the first time in his life.

Anna Sergeyevna and he loved each other like people very close and akin, like husband and wife, like tender friends; it seemed to them that fate itself had meant them for one another, and they could not understand why he had a wife and she a husband; and it was as though they were a pair of birds of passage, caught and forced to live in different cages. They forgave each other for what they were ashamed of in their past, they forgave everything in the present, and felt that this love of theirs had changed them both.

In moments of depression in the past he had comforted himself with any arguments that came into his mind, but now he no longer cared for arguments; he felt profound compassion, he wanted to be sincere and tender. . . .

“Don’t cry, my darling,” he said. “You’ve had your cry; that’s enough. . . . Let us talk now, let us think of some plan.”

Then they spent a long while taking counsel together, talked of how to avoid the necessity for secrecy, for deception, for living in different towns and not seeing each other for long at a time. How could they be free from this intolerable bondage?

"How? How?" he asked, clutching his head. "How?"

And it seemed as though in a little while the solution would be found, and then a new and splendid life would begin; and it was clear to both of them that they had still a long, long way to go, and that the most complicated and difficult part of it was only just beginning.

INE

ine so that only the belfry
cotton factories could be
railway-station. When vis-
re told:

"That's the village where the deacon ate all the caviare at the funeral."

It had happened at the dinner at the funeral of Kostukov that the old deacon saw among the savouries some large-grained caviare and began eating it greedily; people nudged him, tugged at his arm, but he seemed petrified with enjoyment: felt nothing, and only went on eating. He ate up all the caviare, and there were four pounds in the jar. And years had passed since then, the deacon had long been dead, but the caviare was still remembered. Whether life was so poor here or people had not been clever enough to notice anything but that unimportant incident that had occurred ten years before, anyway the people had nothing else to tell about the village Ukleevo.

The village was never free from fever, and there was boggy mud there even in the summer, especially under the fences over which hung old willow-trees that gave deep shade. Here there was always a smell from the factory refuse and the acetic acid which was used in the finishing of the cotton print.

The three cotton factories and the tanyard were not in the village itself but a little way off. They were small factories, and not more than four hundred workmen were employed in all of them. The tanyard often made the water in the little river stink; the refuse contaminated the meadows, the peasants' cattle suffered from Siberian plague, and orders were given that the factory should be closed. It was considered to be closed, but went on working in secret with the connivance of the local police officer and the district doctor, who was paid ten roubles a month by the owner. In the whole village

At the beginning of this paper I define deconstruction as a reading strategy that carefully follows both the meanings and the suspensions and displacements of meaning in a text, while humanism was a strategy to stop reading when the text stops saying what it ought to have said. What the deconstructive reading of Hawthorne and Andersen has shown, however, is that no matter how rigorously a deconstructor might follow the letter of the text, the text will end up showing the reading process as a *resistance* to the letter. The deconstructor thus comes face to face with her own humanism. This is small comfort, of course, since the text has shown humanism to consist in the blindness of self-projection. But then, in the final analysis, it is perhaps precisely as an apprenticeship in the repeated and inescapable oscillation between humanism and deconstruction that literature works its most rigorous and inexhaustible seductions.

Notes

- 1 Reprinted from *Writing and Reading Differently*, eds. G. Douglas Atkins and Michael L. Johnson (Lawrence: University Press of Kansas, 1985), 140–48.
- 2 This is not meant to imply that nothing should be read outside the text at hand, or that a text is unconnected to any discourse outside itself. The “inside” of the text is no more a “given” than the “outside,” and what is inside the text is not necessarily accessible to the reader without philological, historical, biographical, etc., research. But it does imply that history, philology, biography, the “spirit of the age,” and the “material conditions of production” are not less problematic – or less textual and interpretively constructed – than the literary text they would come to explain. Training in reading must also be training in evaluating the relevance and authority of external resources as well as internal ones.
- 3 Paul de Man, *Allegories of Reading* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1979), 17.
- 4 See Derrida, “Plato’s Pharmacy,” in *Dissemination* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1981).
- 5 In the opening essay of de Man.

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EF’s visit to a small planet: Some questions to ask a play¹

Elinor Fuchs

The following walk through dramatic structure is a teaching tool. For the past several years I have used it at the Yale School of Drama as an entry to Reading Theater, a critical writing course for students in the M.F.A. Dramaturgy program.

The questions below are in part designed to forestall the immediate (and crippling) leap to character and normative psychology that underwrites much dramatic criticism. Aside from that corrective bias, the approach offered here is not a “system” intended to replace other approaches to play analysis; I often use it together with Aristotle’s unparalleled insight into plot structure. Rather, it could be thought of as a template for the critical imagination.

In a fine article on *Hedda Gabler*, Philip E. Larson described the nature of “a genuine performance criticism.” If criticism “is unwilling to rest content with the evaluation of ephemera,” he wrote, “[it] must attempt to describe a potential object, one that neither the dramatist, the critics, nor the reader has ever seen, or will see.”² These questions are intended to light up some of the dark matter in dramatic worlds, to illuminate the potentialities Larson points to. No matter what answers come, the very act of questioning makes an essential contribution to the enterprise of criticism.

Elinor Fuchs

We must make the assumption that in the world of the play there are no accidents. Nothing occurs “by chance,” not even chance. In that case, nothing in the play is without significance. Correspondingly, the play asks us to focus upon it a total awareness, to bring our attention and curiosity without the censorship of selective interpretation, “good taste,” or “correct form.” Before making judgments, we must ask questions. This is the deepest meaning of the idea, often-repeated but little understood, that the study of art shows us how to live.

The world of the play: first things first

A play is not a flat work of literature, not a description in poetry of another world, but is in itself another world passing before you in time and space. Language

is only one part of this world. Those who think too exclusively in terms of language find it hard to read plays. When you "see" this other world, when you experience its space-time dynamics, its architectonics, then you can figure out the role of language in it.

If too tight a focus on language makes it hard to read plays, too tight a focus on character creates the opposite problem: it makes the reading too easy. To look at dramatic structures narrowly in terms of characters risks unproblematically collapsing this strange world into our own world. The stage world never obeys the same rules as ours, because in its world, nothing else is possible besides what is there: no one else lives there; no other geography is available; no alternative actions can be taken.

To see this entire world, do this literally: mold the play into a medium-sized ball, set it before you in the middle distance, and squint your eyes. Make the ball small enough that you can see the entire planet, not so small that you lose detail, and not so large that detail overwhelms the whole.

Before you is the "world of the play." Still squinting, ask about the space. What is space like on this planet? Interior or exterior, built or natural? Is space here confined or wide open? Do you see a long passage with many "stations"? Do you see a landscape of valleys and mountains? Sea and land? Are we on an island? In a cave? In a desert or a jungle? On a country road?

Now ask about the time. How does time behave on this planet? Does "time stand still"? Is time frantic and staccato on this planet? Is it leisurely, easy-going time? How is time marked on this planet? By clock? By the sun? By the sound of footsteps? What kind of time are we in? Cyclical time? Eternal time? Linear time? What kind of line? One day? One lifetime?

Ask about the climate on this planet. Do we have storms? Eclipses of the sun and moon? Do we have extreme heat? Paralyzing cold? Is the environment on this planet lush and abundant, sere and life-denying, airless and suffocating? What is the seasonal "feel" of this world? Autumnal? Wintry?

What is the mood on this planet? Jolly? Serious? Sad? Ironic? Sepulchral? The mood is not just a question of plot (comedies are "happy," etc.), "tone" also contributes to mood. What is the tone of this planet? Delicate or coarse? Cerebral or passionate? Restrained or violent? How are mood and tone created on this planet? Through music? Light, sound, color, shape? What shapes? Curves? Angles?

Remember, you can't just decide the planet is wintry or dark because you think it would look more interesting in snow or smog, at least not yet. Make sure you're alert to what's there; there should be actual evidence on the planet for what you report.

You're not done. In most dramatic worlds there are hidden, or at least unseen, spaces. Ask questions about them as well. What are their characteristics of space, time, tone, and mood? How do they relate to the represented world, the world you can see?

Finally, while you're looking at this planet, listen to its "music." Every dramatic world will have, or suggest, characteristic sounds – of mourning, celebration, children's patter, incantation. It will alternate sounds of human and landscape, or sound and silence. Listen for the pattern of the sound.

The social world of the play: a closer look

You are still not ready to examine the beings who inhabit this world. Before you inquire into their individual traits and motives, there are other things you need to know.

Keep squinting at the planet. Is this a public world, or private? What are its class rules? Aristocratic? Popular? Mixed?

In what kinds of patterns do the figures on this planet arrange themselves? Do you see groups in action, isolated individuals, both? Is there a single central figure, surrounded by a group? Are figures matched off in conflicting pairs? Are you seeing (and feeling) the tension of interlocking triangles?

How do figures appear on this planet? Are they inward or two-dimensional? Subtle? Exaggerated? Are they like puppets? Like clowns? Like you? (Are you sure?)

How do figures dress on this planet? In rags, in gowns, in cardboard cutouts? Like us? (Are you sure?)

How do figures interact? By fighting? Reasoned discussion?

Who or what has power, or indeed agency, on this planet? Humans? Animals? Things? The landscape? How is it achieved? Over whom is it exercised? To what ends is it exercised?

What are the language habits on this planet? Verse or prose, dialogue or monologue, certainly. But also, what kinds of language predominate – of thoughts or of feelings? And what kinds of feelings? Is language colorful or flat, clipped or flowing, metaphorical or logical? Exuberant or deliberate? And what about silences?

What changes?

You have gotten a feel for this world. Now look at it dynamically, because it moves in time. Within the "rules" of its operation, nothing stays the same. What changes in this world?

Look at the first image. Now look at the last. Then locate some striking image near the center of the play (the empty box in Kyd's *The Spanish Tragedy* is a good example). To give an account of destiny on this planet range over these three markers. Why was it essential to pass through the gate of the central image to get from the first to the last?

What changes in the landscape of this world? Does it move from inside to outside? From valleys to mountains? From town to wilderness?

What changes in time? Does time move from dusk to night? Night to dawn? Morning to midnight? Through four seasons of a year? Through the stages of a human life? Or the stages of eternal life, from Creation to Last Judgment?

What changes in language? In tone, mood, dress?

All of the changes you discover will of course contribute to and reflect on character, but each trajectory should be seen as a signifying system on its own.

What changes in the action? Have we moved from confusion to wedding (the basic plot of romantic comedy)? From threat to peaceful celebration (the basic plot of [traditional] tragicomedy)? From threat to disaster (the basic plot of tragedy)? From

suffering to rebirth (the plot of the Passion play)? From threat to dual outcome, suffering for evil persons and vindication for good (the basic plot of melodrama)?

What doesn't change? Is there a stable or fixed point in this world? An absolute reality? God? The grave?

Squint one last time. Putting together space, time, the natural world, and the social world: elements that change and those that don't, you are discovering the "myth." Plays are full of archetypal places – castles, gardens, forests, roads, islands, green worlds, dream worlds, storms, night scenes, and on and on. If the play starts in a palace, goes on to a moonlit forest, and returns to the palace the next day or night (which is it? Day or night?), what does that progression tell you? How is the final palace scene conditioned by the night journey into the forest? Is the world of the play at the end of the play a transformed world? Or is it the same world returned to "normal," with minor adjustments? Worlds stand or fall on your answer.

Don't forget yourself

Seeking what changes, don't forget to ask what changes in you, the imaginer of worlds. Ask, what has this world demanded of me? Does it ask me for pity and fear? Does it ask me to reason? To physically participate in the action on the stage? Does it ask me to interact with other spectators? To leave the theatre and take political action? To search my ethical being to the core? Maybe this world means only to entertain me, why not? But how does it make this intention known?

Theatrical mirrors

Important as these internal systems are, dramatic worlds don't just speak to and within themselves; they also speak to each other. How many performances are signaling to you from inside this world? How many echoes of other dramatic worlds do they suggest? How do these additional layers of theatricality comment on what you have already discovered?

The character fits the pattern

Only now are you really ready to examine the figures who inhabit this world. Every assumption you make about a character must reflect the conditions of its world, including the way psychology functions in that world. You can arrive at the most interesting version of any question about character by first exploring the features of her theatrical planet. Characters mean only as they inhabit, enact, fulfill, engage a succession of sites, actions, and objects under a specific set of conditions. They are constituents of a complex artistic pattern. Find the pattern first!

Warning: Don't permit yourself to construct a pattern that omits "singularities," puzzling events, objects, figures, or scenes that "do not fit." Remember, there is nothing in the world of a play by accident. The puzzles may hold the key. Assume

that the dramatic world is entirely conscious, determinate, limited. Give an account of that world that attempts to consider the role of every element in that world – visual, aural, temporal, tonal, figural. Become curious as each element is revealed as a player in the play. Be someone who is aroused to meaning.

Of course you can construct meaning in this world in many different ways. Construct it in the most inclusive way you can. There will still be more to see.

Notes

1 Reprinted from *Theater* 34.2 (2004): 5–9.

2 Philip E. Larson, "French Farce Conventions and the Mythic Story Pattern in *Hedda Gabler*: A Performance Criticism," in Daniel Haakonsen, ed., *Contemporary Approaches to Ibsen*, Vol. 5: *Reports from the Fifth International Ibsen Seminar*, Munich 1983 (Oslo: Universitetsforlaget AS, 1983/4), 202.

CHEKHOV: SHORTER, *faster*, *Funnier* AND UNCUT

A translator susses out the true Chekhov—with some surprising results

By Tom Donaghy

In the Novodevichy Cemetery, on the outskirts of Moscow, the legendary director Konstantin Stanislavsky lies entombed under an enormous marble gravestone. The marker is etched with the slightly abstracted image of a seagull, the icon of the Moscow Art Theatre, where Anton Chekhov's play *The Seagull* premiered, and where, not so arguably, modern drama was refined in the wake of Ibsen and launched into the world.

A few yards away, the gravestone of Chekhov himself can be found. It is, compared to Stanislavsky's, demure. Perhaps four feet tall, it is a white obelisk, hewn from unpolished marble and capped with a bronze gable. On it, the playwright's name is spelled out in Cyrillic lettering, slanting in the triangled cursive that was the style of the then flourishing Art Nouveau movement. Chekhov's wife—Olga Knipper, who would perform in his masterwork, *The Cherry Orchard*, for some 40 years (photo records show her becoming stout and severe as the decades pass)—is buried at his side.

On July 15, Chekhov will have been dead for a century and a year. He breathed his last in a ritzy spa in Badenweiler, Germany, 1,500 or so miles from his grocery-store beginnings, after drinking a glass of champagne and sighing, "It's a long time since I drank champagne." His body was returned to Moscow, and since then his legend has grown there and everywhere. A portraitist by nature, originally writing humorous sketches and stories for newspapers in St. Petersburg, Chekhov was revered in his lifetime for four complex and cherished plays before tuberculosis and its ravages exiled him to the sea-side resort of Yalta. It was a Chekhovian end to 44 years of labor, love, ennui and empathy.

His legacy is certain. His plays, however, remain open to interpretation. He himself notoriously insisted that *The Seagull* and *The Cherry Orchard*

were "gay, lighthearted, comedies," but this was ignored by Stanislavsky, who directed the plays, according to Chekhov, as "weepy." The two men were often at loggerheads as a result. The premiere production of *The Cherry Orchard*, rehearsing in Moscow while the playwright withered in Yalta, gave Chekhov his final chance to decry what he saw as Stanislavsky's enduring misinterpretation of his work. As his strength evanesced, he roused himself, fired up his pen and dashed off acid-tinged missives that warned Stanislavsky against employing his familiar, cloying theatrical tricks. These usually involved the offstage sounds of dogs barking, birds singing and frogs croaking. Early in their collaboration, an exasperated Chekhov even exclaimed, "I shall write a new play and the first words will be, 'It's wonderful, this calm! No birds, no dogs, no cuckoos, no owls, no nightingales, no clocks, no sleigh bells, no crickets.'"

But Stanislavsky ignored the directives, and Chekhov, when finally taken to Moscow to attend opening night, was more or less disgusted by what he saw onstage. "Stanislavsky has ruined my play," he wrote Olga. "Oh well, I don't suppose anything can be done about it."

He supposed right. And in the 100 years that followed, something intractable began to take hold. By ignoring the playwright's intentions, Stanislavsky seems to have established a tradition for how Chekhov's plays

would be directed—and often misdirected—to this day. They have been remade and deconstructed. They have been springboards for directorial theories, from Eva Le Gallienne's to Joshua Logan's to Andrei Serban's to Peter Brook's. A recent production of *The Cherry Orchard*, directed by Eimuntas Nekrosius of Lithuania, clocked in at six hours. New York City's Wooster Group refracted *Three Sisters* through live video feed. The plays have been set in decrepit theatres, Northern Ireland, the Gul-



This month's special section on indigenous theatre from around the world, titled *Cultures in Peril*, is a compelling, thought-provoking, sometimes stark reminder of things we know about the theatre but seldom step back to contemplate.

For example: The fascinating symbolic parallel, suggested (in Leslee Asch's cover story, page 24) by Basil Jones of Handspring Puppet Company of South Africa, between the eponymous 16-foot-high giraffe in the production *Tall Horse* and the "gifts" that have flowed out of Africa during the past century to enrich the world—Cubism, jazz, modern dance, even Modernism itself, in Jones's view—reinforces what we know about theatre as a humanizing bridge between nations, and between the past and the future. Playwright Lynn Nottage's heartrending accounts of "theatre of necessity" in Uganda (page 26) remind us of the elemental nature of performance; the courageous efforts of Mayan women in Chiapas, Mexico, (page 28) underscore the art form's enduring potential as a tool of political transformation.

For me, the most potent theme running through the collection is the irreducible significance of the actor—the importance of the body of the performer as a site of cultural knowledge, and as an instrument of its preservation and transmission. As Susan Leigh Foster points out in her 1995 study *Choreographing History*, the ability of the actor to communicate signs, complex ideas and history through gesture, performance, dance and sexuality puts the body on an equal footing with, or in an even more powerful position than, the book or the archive. Because no written record exists of many of the stories being told in these indigenous performances, the actor's body becomes paramount: not merely the conduit of a narrative but a literal incarnation of it—and a living link to theatre's ancient origins in ritual and magic.

The international focus carries over into other parts of the issue: In addition to *American Theatre's* annual directory of international summer theatre festivals (page 37), Joan Channick's editorial (page 4) advocates a greater role for artists in U.S. diplomatic policy; Melanie Joseph is inspired by the energy and rigor of a progressive gathering in Brazil (page 54); and French director Ariane Mnouchkine extols the art of theatre in two languages on the occasion of World Theatre Day (page 59).

At a time when the U.S. seems politically alienated from many parts of the world and culturally suspect in others, theatre can be an indispensable reminder that we are not alone. —*Jim O'Quinn*

CONTRIBUTORS



Playwright **Tom Donaghy's** first encounter with translating and adapting Chekhov—for a production of *The Cherry Orchard* that opens May 25 at New York City's Atlantic Theater Company—prompted a trenchant, sometimes irreverent essay (page 20) on the Russian dramatist's theatrical prose and dramatic intentions. He was particularly struck, Donaghy writes, by "the twin strains of brutality and hilarity" that run through Chekhov's final play.



Performer and scholar **Ellen Fisher** began her research in Sri Lanka 30 years ago, as a young dancer studying the upcountry Kandyan dance. "I recently returned to document the authentic rituals of this island culture through writing and filming," she says. "Seeing the rituals and their effect on the people has reinforced my belief that art can both entertain and heal through the transformative powers of the performer." She shares her experiences on page 34.

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lah Islands—you name it. They have often bored audiences to tears, and sometimes they have been as full of bells and whistles as a Ringling Brothers dressing room. They have played like Strindberg at his gloomiest and Neil Simon at his schtickiest. No doubt somewhere on this earth the curtain is about to rise on a shadow puppet version of *Uncle Vanya*.

What of the text, though, untethered to directorial interpretation? What does it say to us on its own? Even more important, how does it say it?

Lately, I've been reading a literal translation of *The Cherry Orchard* for an adaptation I'm creating for Atlantic Theater Company's current season. The work is by Ronald Meyer, director of the M.A. program in Russian literary translation at Columbia University. It is a verbatim translation from the original Russian text to American English—as close to reading Chekhov's original script as any non-Russian-reading reader can get. What's more, it is eye-poppingly different from any "Chekhov" I've ever read in the 20 years that I've been familiar with his plays.

What is striking at first about the translation is the text's sui generis nature. It is its own



"Stanislavsky has ruined my play," Chekhov wrote Olga. "Oh well, I don't suppose anything can be done about it."

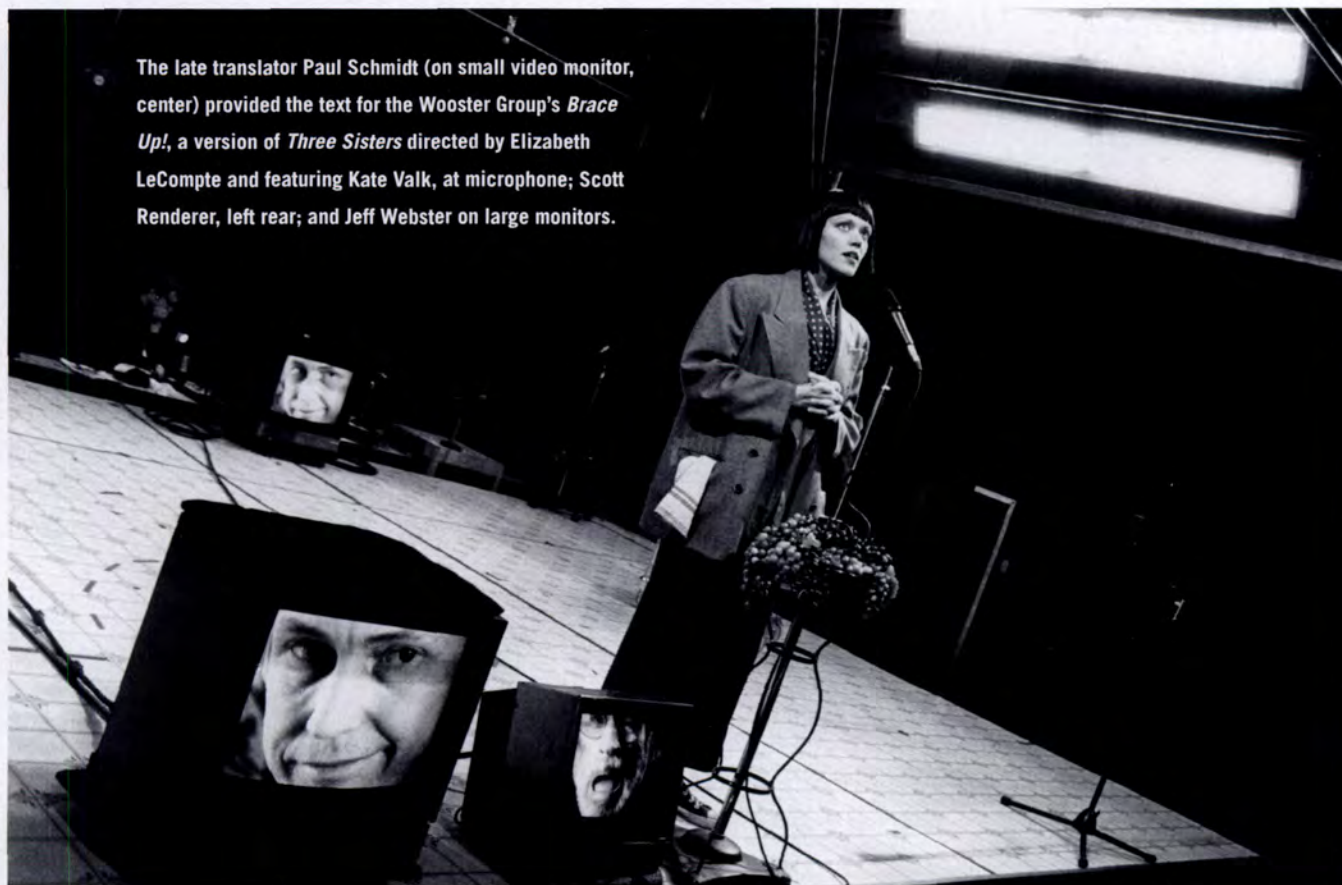
thing—exotic and resistant to seeming like anything else, adaptable to no other settings. Its integrity is utterly sound; to transpose its characters to a different time or place seems unnecessary and slightly cuckoo. And yet, of course, Chekhov's plays—more than any other playwright's save for Shakespeare's—seem to suffer a kind of mania for interpretation.

The other striking thing about the translation, which is apparent from the first page, is its twin strains of brutality and hilarity. The play possesses both, with very little transition between the two. The characters and their emotions, are, as Australians say, "all over the shop." At a moment in time when drama seems to need to explain, spell out, comfort and offer lessons, Chekhov's final play stands in gorgeous resistance to these tasks. It jerks you through the air; yet there is no net below. It does not comfort; on the contrary, it agitates—but at the most fundamental and emotional level. This is upsetting, but also exhilarating and, yes, very funny. You are unprepared as a reader—and even though you think you might be familiar with the play, you have no idea where you are being taken.

And you are, no question, being taken. For something that seems on the face of it plot-

continued on page 62

The late translator Paul Schmidt (on small video monitor, center) provided the text for the Wooster Group's *Brace Up!*, a version of *Three Sisters* directed by Elizabeth LeCompte and featuring Kate Valk, at microphone; Scott Renderer, left rear; and Jeff Webster on large monitors.



Chekhov: Shorter, Faster, Funnier and Uncut *continued from page 21*

less, nonlinear and willfully static, there courses underneath this play a vitality that is antic and not entirely kind. The play wants to toss you about. Similar to the vertiginous feeling you get as you try to grab hold of Virginia Woolf's sentences, with their incautious swoops, Chekhov's play can fling you somewhere, and you arrive before you even realize you've been flung. And then you are off again. At the end of the play, when axes are heard taking great chunks out of the cherry trees, the reader is breathless, shaken and suspicious of the ground beneath. But giggly—giddy even. People behave ridiculously; this is life.

THEN WHY IS IT WE DON'T ALWAYS feel this when seeing a production of these plays? I have a hunch the problem begins with adaptations.

Adaptations happen. But how? One

of two ways, really. They can be generated from a literal translation of the original text (what I'm doing): the translator one person, the adaptor another. Or, in rare cases, such as when a playwright speaks Russian, the translator and adaptor can be one and the same. This is the case with the elegant adaptations of the scholar and theatre artist Paul Schmidt.

There are, however, a whole lot of dunderheaded adaptations of Chekhov's plays, such as the one I—and many others—first read in college by the artistically named Constance Garnett. The fault with these adaptations seems to be embellishment: straightening out the kinked way Chekhov's scenes proceed; having the characters make more "sense" by smoothing over what seem to be their abrupt reversals of mood; theatricalizing the plays, akin to what Stanislavsky did in his productions, in

order to foster a kind of naturalism that the plays do not really possess on the page. Often adaptations want to make the characters merely tragic, or worse, loveable.

In Janet Malcolm's *Reading Chekhov*, she observes that when you utter the name "Chekhov" in Russia, no less than in our own country, people "arrange their features as if a baby deer had come into the room." This fawning reference surrounding Chekhov's reputation has transferred itself to the adaptations and productions of his plays, resulting in a kind of pretty veneer that has built up over them in the course of the last century. But this gauzy, huggable overlay is not warranted. It would have outraged the famously unsentimental playwright, who spent many years hacking due to the blood in his lungs.

There are also adaptations that politicize the plays, by tilting them toward a prescient and specific awareness of the Russian revolution to come. But Chekhov was not concerned with politics. On the subject of political action his plays are, if anything, about people's inability to actually engage in it. Chekhov is not like his friend, the revolutionary Maxim Gorky. Chekhov wrote about people and their inability to organize their own world, not about people who were able—or even truly interested in—reorganizing the larger one.

All of these interpretations have the ability to distort adaptations and wrench Chekhov's plays from their very simple conveyance of life as it is actually lived—even today. People go about talking and making love and hoping and having tea, and all the while things are being simply, effortlessly lost.

The most striking thing about the literal translation I am basing my adaptation on, however, is its remarkable brevity. It is 73 pages. As many of us know, a playscript is usually nearer 120 pages, signaling—the rule is a minute a page—a two-hour play. A 73-page play starting at 8 p.m. would then come down about 9:13 p.m. This begs an important question: Who among

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us has ever seen a Chekhov play and made it to dinner by 9:45?

WHEN I ASKED MEYER WHAT HE may have cut to make the play so short, he said, "Nothing. You're getting it word-for-word from the original Chekhov text." Why then have we endured three-to-four-hour versions of *The Cherry Orchard*? Chekhov himself said the last act should run 12 minutes—he even wrote it this way because the characters are running for the train.

And as I read the translation for the first time, I saw exactly why the play shouldn't be long: Its brevity is precisely what creates the 3-D nature of its power. It is fast because it is dire. One wants it to slow down for the sad parts, and it does, but then it lifts again with velocity because it is inexorably moving toward its end—an end, by the way, that has shades of both light and dark. Before seeing the literal translation, I only ever remembered the tragedy of the characters losing their cherry orchard, but Meyer's translation suggests there is, for the characters, just as much relief as grief.

Indeed, one gets the feeling that Lyubov Ranevskaya, the owner of the orchard, will be able to finally axe this Russian part of her life, lived near the river where her only son drowned, to return to Paris where she can continue to cheerfully—as they say today—reinvent herself. When she's asked when she'll return to visit, she evades the question. Leonid Gaev, her brother, remarks that everyone seems much more content now that the orchard is sold. Her daughter, Anya, is made positively buoyant by what we have come to think of as a crippling loss. A new life without the worries of a big estate sounds just peachy to her. There are only three characters who seem to be truly put out: Varya, but she is heading to a new job in town; Charlotta, the governess, who as a former circus performer has been itinerant her whole life anyway; and the ancient servant and former serf, Firs, who wants nothing more than to die, and then promptly does—

it seems so anyway—as the lights come down. What is so "weepy" about this?

In the end, perhaps, any adaptation should adhere to the only dictum I was able to glean from Anatoly Smelian-sky, an associate director at the Moscow Art Theatre and head of the Moscow Art Theatre School. I met Smelian-sky, an elfin man full of charm and seriousness—considered by many to be the world's foremost authority on Chekhov—in his offices on Kamergersky Lane, several floors above the stage on which Chekhov's plays were first presented. When I asked him how long my adaptation should be—or how many minutes he thought the

play should run—he gave me a level look. "The play works long, and it works short," he said in his thick Muscovite accent. "Yes, but—" I said. "Listen to me," he said, cutting me off. "If it takes four hours, fine. If it takes 90 minutes, that's fine too. The important thing is that your audience understand the story you think Chekhov wanted to tell."

"Aha," I thought—and set about my work. **AT**

Tom Donaghy's adaptation of The Cherry Orchard opens May 25 at New York City's Atlantic Theater Company.

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Bears

A BRIEF HISTORY



Bernd Brunner

Translated from the German by Lori Lantz

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Introduction

What might the first encounter between human and bear have been like? Perhaps a prehistoric hunter watched from his hiding place as a bear stood up on its hind legs. What other animal had he ever seen stand erect? Other than bears, only a few types of rodents and—oddly enough—owls stand upright as humans do. Our ancient observer was probably also amazed by how dexterously the bear could reach for fruit with its forepaws. He could have noticed how the bear's paws differ from his own hands: since the bear has no thumbs, each paw's five "fingers" possesses equal importance. Despite its large nose, the bear's face, with his eyes aligned in a nearly frontal plane, would also have seemed familiar. Since its feet seem almost humanlike as well, the hunter would have realized which animal had produced the tracks he had seen earlier in the forest. And he may have drawn the comparison between the bear's long claws and his own fingernails. Once he had killed and skinned the animal and had seen how slim and light-colored its body was under its fur, the hunter would certainly have recognized how much the bear resembled him.

As early humans became more familiar with bears, they may have realized that the animals

Norwegian Bear,
by Etienne
Geoffroy Saint-
Hilaire (1824).



ate the same things they did: whether the herbs and berries that they plucked, the roots that they dug from the ground, the gophers and other small animals that they hunted, or the fish that they caught. A bear may even have guided them to sources of honey. On occasion, humans and bears also surely came into conflict over their choice of caves. Over time, ancient people began to perceive bears in two ways: as intimately related to them, but also as serious competitors. In the long run, humans were the victors, even though they possessed only primitive weapons and their opponents were considerably stronger. They pushed their way farther and farther into the bears' territory and drove the shy animals out, felling entire forests to clear the land for planting.

In both Eurasia and North America, the bear occupied a prominent and unique place in early cultures and had a special relationship to humans. Wherever people and bears lived in proximity, humans displayed the same ambivalent behavior: although the bears were driven out, hunted, and killed, their relative resemblance to humans



and their enormous strength commanded our respect. This paradox formed the cornerstone of *Bear Ceremonialism in the Northern Hemisphere*, a study published by American cultural anthropologist Irving Hallowell in 1926. Although the festivals celebrated by both Eurasian peoples and many Native American tribes varied from region to region, Hallowell found that they shared the same basic impetus: the bear was honored as the lord of the forest or the son of the supreme ruler, whose calling it was to uphold justice. Groups that were widely separated geographically, Hal-

Early bear
hunt in
Germania.

lowell claimed, shared the belief that a bear killed in the hunt would enter a new life.

Even the similarity of the euphemisms used in various cultures to refer to bears—referring to the word “bear” itself was often thought to be tempting fate and was therefore taboo—demonstrates that the animal occupied a comparable role in all of them. According to Holloway, the bear was called “cousin” by the Abenaki, Tsimshian, and Tahltan Indians; “grandfather” by the Penobscot; and “four-legged human” or “chief’s son” by the Plains Cree. The Siberian Kets endowed him with noble names such as “fur father,” “old claw man,” or “beautiful animal.” The Samoyeds, also from Siberia, called him “old father,” while the Estonians named him “broad-foot,” and the Carpathian Huzuls referred to him as “little uncle” or “great hairy one.” Finally, the Laplanders dubbed the bear “the old man with the fur garment,” while their Swedish neighbors used the names “old man,” “gold feet,” or “twelve men’s strength.” If these aliases sound romantic to us today, we need to keep in mind that they reflected a completely different relation to the animal kingdom, one in which the bear represented the single large animal that resembled, and competed with, humans. The existence of apes, let alone their close genetic relationship with us, was unknown in the Northern Hemisphere.

THIS BOOK EXAMINES the shared history of humans and bears. This history is composed of

many stories—some of them recorded, some of them lost, and some of them told and retold so many times that boundaries between fact and fiction have become blurred, making it difficult or impossible to untangle the two. The relations between humans and bears throughout history are complex because they play out within the poles of attraction and repulsion, combining these seemingly irreconcilable opposites in almost every possible way. In other words, our interactions with bears are laden with mixed feelings: our forebears venerated, killed, caressed, tortured, nurtured, ate, respected, and despised them. In some instances, these paradoxical attitudes can even be found within the framework of a single culture. In comparatively recent times, humans have also begun to scrutinize bears closely out of scientific interest. It may often seem that this rational outlook has completely replaced our forefathers’ more emotional or even spiritual views of bears. A return to older worldviews may not be possible or even desirable, but, if we look more closely, we will see that bears continue to exert a powerful and seemingly inexplicable fascination for us.

Writing about bears, however, is a dangerous business. The existence of so many pleasurable accounts of bears can easily blind us to the importance of those that are less so. And it can seem as though everybody is reading over your shoulder: teddy bear lovers, biologists, hunters, poachers, animal-rights advocates, and others, all of whom—in one way or another—have a stake in

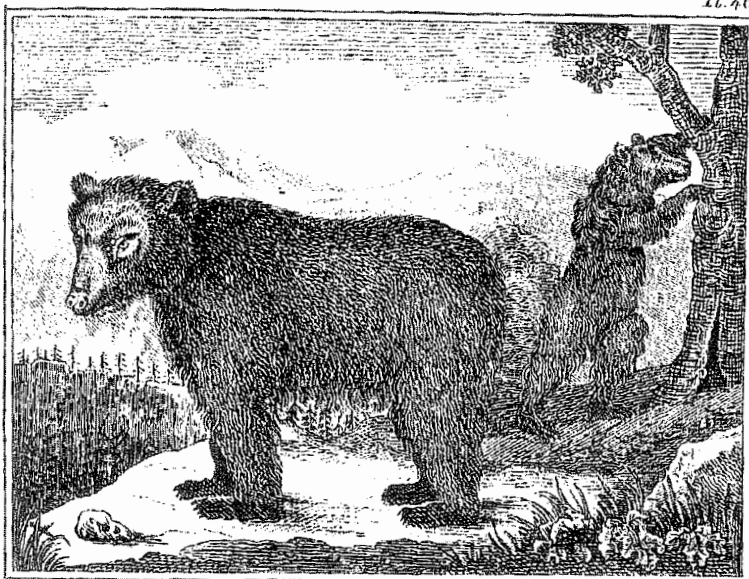
bears and bring their own perspective and history to the subject. Rather than try to single out the "correct" perspective on bears, I trace these interwoven strands by focusing where cultural and natural history intersect. I will tell some of the stories of humans and bears and explore certain key topics and questions. A number of the examples I provide along the way are drawn from outside the borders of the English-speaking world. While the saga of bears in America plays an important role in this book, the tangled histories of bears in places like Russia or Japan are equally fascinating and deserve our attention. At the same time, the complexity of the subject means that no book about bears can hope to be comprehensive. However, I want to provide a sense of the scope of these remarkable animals—the many varieties and their habitats and behaviors summarized by the misleadingly simple term "bear."

Despite their diversity and illustrious history, the state of bears today is sobering. These once abundant animals are now largely confined to areas with little or no human civilization. Is it possible for humans and bears to share the same space at all? Why is it so hard for us to imagine these extraordinary creatures clearly without caricatures immediately filling our minds? Do we really know what bears are like, what they feel? Do bears deserve their reputation as particularly dangerous predators? And, if so, who is actually preying on whom these days?

Bears are strong, intelligent, and fascinating

animals whose ways deserve respect. Examining our dealings with bears throughout history will improve our understanding of our relationship to them today. What other animal occupies as much space in the human imagination as the bear? Bears are present in our entertainment and advertising, in our art and literature, in our folk wisdom and popular sayings. Although bears have disappeared from vast stretches of the earth, they continue to populate our personal and collective dreams.

Tracking the Paths of Bears



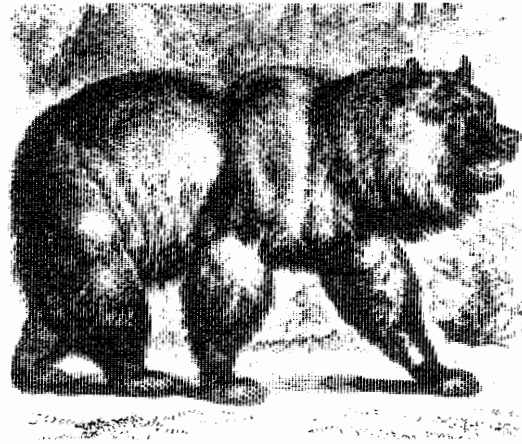
Most scientists today recognize eight species of bears worldwide. The brown bear (*Ursus arctos*) is identifiable by its furry coat of blond, brown, or even black hair—sometimes with silver tips—and by a large hump of muscle above its shoulders. It is the most widely distributed bear in the Northern Hemisphere. The polar bear (*Ursus maritimus*) lives in and around the Arctic and has white or cream-colored fur and a thick layer of blubber to protect it from the cold. The much smaller American black bear (*Ursus americanus*), or baribal, is the most common bear species in North America. In contrast, the spectacled bear (*Tremarctos ornatus*) lives only in the Andes tropical basin. Its name derives from the distinctive light markings across its face. These light patterns can also appear on the animal's chest, making the spectacled bear only one of several types of bears with distinctive markings there. The Asian black bear (*Ursus thibetanus*), which can be found along a line that stretches from Iran to Japan, sports a large, white crescent. The sloth bear (*Melursus ursinus*), which inhabits southern Asia, has long fur and a white, V-shaped mark. Thanks to long, curved claws and a specially shaped mouth that enables it to eat insects, the sloth bear was indeed first mistakenly identified

When classification was simple: brown bear and white bear.

as a giant sloth. The sun bear (*Helarctos malayanus*), with its short, sleek fur and a yellow marking in the shape of a horseshoe, is the smallest member of the bear family and lives in the tropical rainforests of Southeast Asia. Finally, the great panda (*Ailuropoda melanoleuca*), a native of central and southern China, has a distinctive black-and-white coat. He is most different from all other modern bear species.

ALL BEARS LIVING TODAY have descended from a common ancestor known as *Ursavus*, or “dawn bear.” This animal, which lived about twenty million years ago, was about the size of a small terrier. Even at this early point in evolutionary history, however, *Ursavus* had a jaw already markedly different from that of a dog. Over time, groups of this early bear species split off and wandered into different habitats, where they adapted to new and better environments and to available sources of food. Each group underwent its own course of evolution.

One of the earliest to evolve from one of these groups—about ten million years ago—was the giant panda, while another group ultimately produced the spectacled bear (which arrived in South America long before the brown and black bear). Several million years later, during the Pliocene, a bear known as *Ursus minimus* first appeared. Before this ancestral bear further evolved into *Ursus etruscus*, additional groups split off and ultimately became the American black bear, the Asian black bear, the sloth bear, and the sun bear.



Grizzly bear.

Ursus etruscus, however, which lived about one and a half million years ago, was the progenitor of both the cave bear and other bears that would become the brown bear and the polar bear. This bear migrated from Europe deep into Asia. The mighty cave bear, an ursine giant that shared the earth with early humans, disappeared only about ten to twenty thousand years ago. Polar bears, in turn, are considered to be the youngest bears of all. Scientists long believed that brown and polar bears evolved at widely different times, but genetic analysis has since demonstrated that the two are close relatives: between two and three hundred thousand years ago, the first polar bears evolved from North American brown bears.

ALTHOUGH TO US THE concept of “bear” seems self-explanatory, the search to identify exactly what it is that makes a bear part of a particular group (and what distinguishes each one from the

The Bear's Personality

As we have seen, it has been the bear's fate to serve as a yardstick for humans. Giovanni Battista della Porta (1535–1615), an Italian naturalist and one of the first scientists in the modern sense, classified various human types according to the animals they supposedly resembled. For him, the bear embodied a whole series of negative characteristics: both the "coarse, uncultivated" person, with his large head and protruding mouth, and the "wrathful" person, with his deeply hollowed nostrils and thick beard, possess bearlike traits in his scheme. The "worst possible human character of all" was, for della Porta, the thoroughly bestial, "godforsaken idiot." This personality is revealed by dark eyes, a large belly, and a mouth that is "so long and wide . . . that the face seems split in two." Such an individual resembles the "ferocious bear," whom della Porta condemned as stupid, scheming, dangerous, treacherous, and, as if this were not enough, "wilder than all other animals," thus uniting lack of intelligence with cruelty and coarseness in one unlikable package.

Brown bear and corresponding images of a human with bear traits (eighteenth century).

Edward Topsell, who was most interested in the bear's physical characteristics, also made a few comments about the animal's psychology. He stated that "a Beare is of a most venerous and



lustful disposition." Topsell characterized bears of the "Helvetian alpine region" to be "full of courage," but added the qualification that "they will not willingly fight with a man." However, Topsell didn't seem to have considered the ways in which comparisons with bears might shed light on the mental makeup of humans.

ANIMAL PSYCHOLOGY, in turn, already existed as a marginalized branch of the sciences by the middle of the eighteenth century, but it didn't reach its height in the popular press until the nineteenth century. The discipline employed categorizations that were easy to grasp and thus appealed to many people. Its practitioners granted animals a measure of consciousness, along with emotions and the basis of an ego, and were interested above all in the question of whether or not specific behaviors were inborn or learned, and if animals were capable of remembering. This perspective was in sharp contrast to the ideas of René Descartes, who believed that animals were soulless automatons.

Jacques Henri Bernardin de Saint-Pierre (1737-1814) championed the view—which in his day enjoyed serious scientific consideration—that lions, through loving human care, could be transformed into gentle, vegetarian creatures. Saint-Pierre went so far as to claim that every animal is tame by nature and becomes wild only as a result of negative experiences. He even argued for a new kind of zoo in which kindly treatment and

friendship between humans and animals would render the cruelties of confinement unnecessary.

Swiss science author Peter Scheitlin (1779-1848), one of the forerunners of the animal-rights movement, viewed the bear, which he considered to be a "most remarkable animal," as a thoroughly intelligent and good-natured creature, which when tamed can precisely distinguish among the three types of humans it encounters: its master (owner), benefactor (keeper), and superior (trainer). According to Scheitlin, bears know that they must make long detours through the forests and mountains to evade pursuers, and they have such a good sense of direction that they always find their way home. "'Angry as a mother bear robbed of her young' is a common saying," he reported. "Their love is uncommonly intense." Elsewhere in his book, Scheitlin claimed that the bear's skill in hunting, its dietary preferences, and its footprint all betray an affinity to human beings. Waxing truly euphoric, he even rhapsodized that a bear, out of principle, will touch nothing that is dead and likewise harms

no innocent beings. "He is known to have approached young girls hunting for strawberries and stolen the fruit right from their baskets, and then went on his way—we can almost dare to say—laughing," he wrote. "At the very least, he was surely laughing in his heart."



bears laughing

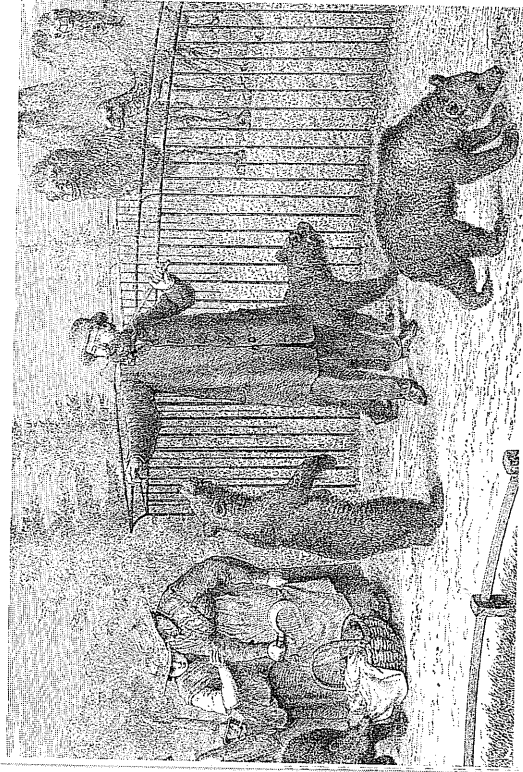
While Scheitlin's bear is almost insufferably lovable, a newcomer to the scientific world—the grizzly—was making a far different impression. "The African Lion, or the Tiger of Bengal, are not more terrible or fierce. He is the enemy of man, and literally thirsts for human blood. So far from shunning, he seldom fails to attack; and even to hunt him," wrote H. M. Brackenridge in 1814. Of course, this nightmarish characterization posed a serious obstacle to any deeper study of the bear's true characteristics.

Much later, in the 1880s, Theodore Roosevelt went west and devoted considerable attention to the grizzly, which he dubbed "Old Ephraim" during various hunting trips. He came to consider the bear "the King of game beasts of temperate North America" and "the mighty lord of the wilderness . . . the most dangerous to the hunter." He took the animal's name as a reference to its character and not to its grizzled gray fur—"in the same sense as horrible, exactly as we speak of a 'grisly spectre,'—and not *grizzly*"; but perhaps the latter way of spelling it is too well established to be now changed." Despite this sweeping generalization, Roosevelt also claimed that bears differ in temperament just as people do: "There are savage and cowardly bears, just as there are big and little ones; and sometimes these variations are very marked among bears of the same districts."

An avid hunter, he believed that the animals had developed an awareness of the violent intentions of the humans they encountered. "Nowadays these great bears are undoubtedly much

better aware of the death-dealing power of men," he reasoned, "and, as a consequence, are much less fierce than was the case with their forefathers, who so unhesitatingly attacked the early Western travellers and explorers." But Roosevelt went far beyond asserting that individual bears can learn—he attributed to the animals a remarkable ability to hand down knowledge to their descendants. "Constant contact with rifle-carrying hunters, for a period extending over many generations of bear-life, has taught the grizzly by bitter experience that man is his undoubted overlord," he wrote, "and this knowledge has become an hereditary characteristic." But lest the relative cowardliness of the modern grizzly throw doubt on his own hunting heroics, Roosevelt added that a wounded or cornered animal "will attack his foes with a headlong, reckless fury that renders him one of the most dangerous of the wild beasts."

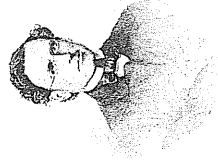
Alongside the "proud lion," the "impish sparrow," and the "industrious ant," Alfred Brehm (1829–1884), the celebrated German "father of the animals," also studied the behavior and character of the bear. This son of a minister and ornithologist, who grew up among thousands of stuffed birds and who actually wanted to be an architect, accompanied Baron John von Müller on a five-year African expedition. Brehm and von Müller traveled through Egypt and the Sudan, where they barely escaped starvation, fought wild animals, and encountered angry natives who mistook them for slave traders. After the ex-



Alfred Brehm in
Hamburg's
Zoological
Garden.

pedition, Brehm lived in Jena, where his student quarters resembled a zoo: with him resided a monkey, parrots, and a mongoose. His entirely negative portrayal of the bear is all the more astounding given his reputation as an unqualified animal lover who fought to save many species of wild animals and birds.

Brehm condemned the bear as thoroughly "unlikable" and a "dull-witted and spiritless fellow." One of his early articles further labeled the bear as "the notorious overlord of the animal kingdom" and an "unintentionally laughable fellow" who "does not deserve the respect he enjoys." He concluded that "the damage caused by bears is roughly balanced out by their usefulness to us" and lists a "first-class pelt" and "meat, bones and intestines" as examples of the bear's gifts to mankind.



Friedrich von
Tschudi.

In contrast to Brehm, Swiss hunter and naturalist Friedrich von Tschudi (1820–1886) emphasized the bear's "comfortable humor" as well as its "jocular, amiable nature." For Tschudi, the bear had "a direct, open character free of cunning and deceit." The bear is far from harmless, however: "What the fox obtains with his wits and the eagle with his swiftness, the bear pursues with undisguised force." This view was echoed by A. Krementz, who based his assessment on his own observations while hunting in Russia rather than on the reports of unreliable witnesses. "He has an enormous love of comfort," Krementz wrote, "and his attacks betray a certain candor, directness, and courtliness that has nothing in common with the cowardly murderousness of the wolf or the deceptive cunning of the lynx."

If we turn back to Brehm, we seem to be reading about an entirely different animal. "Any cat or dog is more able-witted," he insisted. "His seeming good nature is due from his lack of hunting skill, and the jovial impression he makes is imparted primarily by his form. The cat is courageous and the dog clever; the bear is stupid, coarse and rude." At another point he wrote, "The bear's every act betrays a weak, low and uneducable spirit." He even criticized the bear for avoiding "close association with civilized man" and claimed that "the wolf most definitely occupies a higher position and must be acknowledged as the nobler animal. . . . We can at best compare the bear to the swine: like him, the bear finds anything that is enjoyable to be acceptable."

Brahm further asserted that bears can never be trusted. He considered the animals worthy at best of a place behind bars at the zoo or at the side of a traveling animal trainer.

Zoology professor Gustav Jäger was of the opinion that the bear presented a "kaleidoscopic" figure like few other animals—and he did not intend this characterization as a compliment. Like the lion and the tiger, the bear can bring down the largest of mammals, yet it poaches the fields "like any mere ruminating beast." It steals from orchards and vineyards "like a monkey," eats berries from the stem "like a blackbird," climbs after pinecones "like a squirrel," plunders beehives and anthills "like a woodpecker," digs for maggots and worms "like a pig," and, finally, fishes and crabs "like an otter." In Jäger's view, the bear's personality is as complex as its tastes in food. "On the one hand," he wrote, "the bear is a fearsome combatant—equipped, as our forefathers claimed, with the strength of twelve men—who coolly challenges men and often overpowers them." "On the other, though," he continued, the bear is "a cowardly fellow, who lets himself be driven from the fields by a girl or an old woman wielding a basin or a hoe, and who plays the fool for children at the fair, who is led around, dancing like a monkey, or sits in the cage of a zoo saying 'pretty please' like a poodle." In his indignation, Jäger completely overlooked the fact that it was humans who forced the bear into the position of laughingstock.

Ludwig Heck, a director of the Berlin Zoo who

lost the tips of the first two fingers on his left hand to a bear, understood why the public loved bears "as much as they did monkeys," yet did not share this fascination himself. According to Heck, the bear "serves as a caricature of mankind, as our own distorted reflection." Such moments of recognition occur, Heck claimed, "when he stands on his hind legs and toddles around like a portly old man in his underwear, when he sits on his backside and 'lays his hands in his lap,' or when he, with astounding dexterity, gestures with his front paws, which resemble human hands in thick gloves and which are capable of the same rotational movement that makes our own hands the ready tools of our minds." As supposed proof of the bear's inferior character, Heck cited the so-called Drama in the Polar Bear Cage incident, in which a polar bear in the Cologne zoo had killed "his" female. The event was trumpeted in the newspapers of the day as a "wife murder." The fact that male bears in the wild live with females for only short periods, and thus—unlike lions and tigers, for example—are not "natural born husbands," was of course not as widely reported.

Karl Oberländer, who traveled through northern Russia just after the turn of the twentieth century, argued vehemently against naturalists who "assumed that the bear's shape indicated coarseness and clumsiness." It is wrong, Oberländer argued, "to judge a wild species across the board based on single individuals and isolated observations" and to attribute stupidity, cowardice, laziness

ness, gentleness, or directness to bears in particular, since members of this species above all demonstrate "a rare diversity of character."

The tendency to describe the bear in terms of other animals reached its peak in 1911 when the naturalist Theodor Zell wrote, "When he stands upright, the bear resembles a gigantic man, while on all fours he looks more like an enormous pig. . . . Like lions, tigers, jaguars, and the like he has little endurance for running, and like these cats he has two weapons: his bite and his claws." But Zell warned against hastily concluding that bears and cats share a close kinship. The bear lacks the "flexibility of the cat" but possesses greater strength. According to Zell, bears actually have much more in common with dogs—both species have nonretractable claws and rely on their noses above all other sense organs. Zell even labeled the bear an "olfactory animal," a trait evidenced by its highly developed snout, and claimed that the animal's sense of sight is correspondingly underdeveloped. "When we compare the flashing, clear, large eye of the lion with a bear's uncertain little pig's eye, we immediately realize that these predators must belong to completely distinct classes, based on the difference in their fundamental senses." For Zell, the polar bear's long neck and narrow head, in turn, reveal the animal to be "an enormous winter weasel."

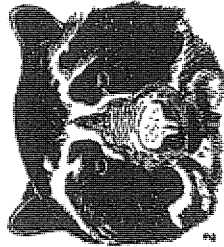
American biologist Enos A. Mills (1870–1922) championed the view that the grizzlies were smarter than horses, dogs, and even coyotes be-

cause they can process their experiences in particularly intelligent ways. Unlike his many German colleagues, who could observe bears only on the grounds of the zoological garden, Mills could relate a number of impressive cases of grizzlies in the wild who eluded hunters and trappers for years or even decades. One such bear was the famous "Old Mose," an "outlaw grizzly" whose habit of killing horses and cows earned him a bounty of a thousand dollars on his head. Despite the avid pursuit such a fortune inspired, this remarkable animal managed to survive thirty-five years in a territory just seventy-five miles across. This extraordinary intelligence seemed to have filled Mills with respect. "The grizzly is so dignified and so strangely human-like that I have felt degraded every time I have seen him pursued with dogs," he wrote. "A few times I have outwitted him; more often he has outwitted me. We have occasionally met unexpectedly; sometimes each stared without alarm, and at other times each fled in an opposite direction. Sometimes the grizzly is guided by instinct, but more often his actions are triumphantly directed by reason."

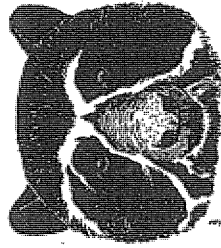
Is there a reliable way to describe the character of bears beyond the fact that they are often unpredictable? While the foregoing catalogue of contradictions may not reveal much about bears themselves, it surely demonstrates the extent to which humans have been moved to project human characteristics—both positive and negative—onto them. We have seen bears as good-natured, lazy, and even stupid, and at other times



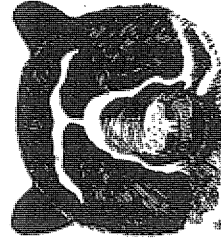
Kopf 1
♂, etwa 4jährig, Zoo Berlin-W.;
aus Nord-Peru eingeführt



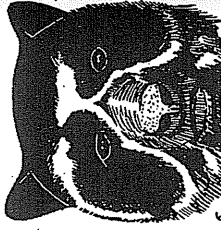
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Berlin-Friedrichsfelde;
aus Peru eingeführt



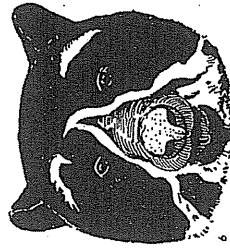
Kopf 3
♂, etwa 2jährig, Zoo Dresden;
aus Nord-Peru eingeführt



Kopf 4
♀, 11jährig, Zoo Basel;
im Zoo B. Aires geb.,
Eltern aus Ecuador



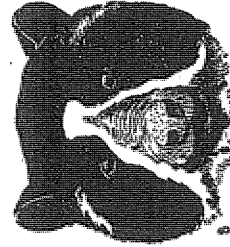
Kopf 5
♂, 2 1/2jährig, Zoo Berlin-W.;
im Zoo Berlin geboren 1960



Kopf 6
♀, etwa 8-12jährig
Zoo Berlin-W.;
Herkunft unbekannt



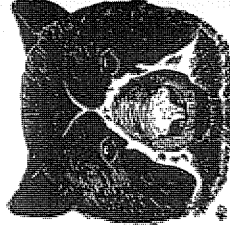
Kopf 7
♀, 5jährig, Zoo Basel;
im Zoo B. Aires geboren,
Eltern aus Ecuador?



Kopf 8
♂, etwa 2jährig, Zoo Dresden;
aus Nord-Peru eingeführt



Kopf 9
♀, 11jährig, Zoo Basel;
im Zoo B. Aires geb.,
Eltern aus Ecuador



Kopf 10
♀, etwa 8-12jährig, Tierpark
Berlin-Friedrichsfelde;
Herkunft unbekannt

Abb. 7. Überblick über die Verschiedenartigkeit der Gesichtszeichnung bei Brillenbären (schematisiert dargestellt). — Zeichnung: Dr. S. KÄRMEL (1958) und Dr. H. H. KORTI (1960)

as wrathful, deceitful, and unpredictable. The same animals that are labeled as cautious and suspicious are also painted as sly and cunning, wise and fearless, clever, brilliant, powerful, beautiful, and even majestic. We may assume that our ability to bestow such labels is a sign of our superiority over animals. Whether this is true or not, however, one thing at least seems to be clear: no matter how much it may look like one, a bear is not a man in fur.

Unlike other bear species, individual spectacled bears can be identified by the patterns on their faces.

Sounds, Senses, Signals

Aristotle distinguished between animals that make vocal noises and those that do not, while those animals gifted with voices may or may not be able to express articulated sounds. Without a doubt, the bear counts as an animal gifted with a voice. But what sounds, besides roaring, belong to the bear's repertoire? And to what extent are we capable of understanding its vocalizations?

"When he is angry, he gnashes his teeth, snorts and roars violently. At other times his voice is a low hum," wrote naturalist and Church of England clergyman William Bingley in 1805. Hunter Georg Franz Dietrich aus dem Winckell expressed a similar opinion in 1822: "One generally hears bears emit a roaring sound only when they are angry, but at times it can also indicate a certain well-being. In the first case, the roar is usually accompanied by an audible gnashing of the teeth." And, in an uncharacteristically terse comment in an otherwise detailed description from 1847, Anton Benedikt Reichenbach wrote that the bear's "face, hearing, and sense of touch are all refined. His voice is a low, hollow roar."

Voice

Various kinds of bears (1868).

These passages illustrate the difficulty in de-



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1. 2. 3. Gemeiner brauner Landbär. 4. Nordamerikanischer schwarzer Bär. Baribal. 5. Malayischer oder Kragenbär. 6. Spielende Bären. 7. Dachs. 8. Eisbär eine Robbe od. Seehund verzehrend. 9. Waschbär od. Sch.

scribing the sounds made by bears. Can the voices of animals be captured in words at all? In 1886, zoologist Philipp Leopold Martin tried to record animal sounds using musical notation. However, he could not assume that travelers had the necessary training to describe what they heard correctly. For this reason, Martin decided that a more practical solution was to compare animal sounds with known voices and to record additional criteria such as the animal's age and sex, its mood, and the point of time the observation was made (such as "during the mating period"). In 1891, his colleague Carl Grevé spoke out for a greater appreciation of "the modulated humming songs of the bear licking its paws." "So little attention is paid to the various tones emitted by the mammals, just because they are raw and, by our standards, not beautiful," Grevé complained, "while the 'song' of birds has lured many a researcher to depict their *sounds* with notes."

An attempt to develop a formal theory of animal sounds did not occur until the 1930s, at which time Karl Max Schneider, the director of the Leipzig Zoo, wrote, "It seems to me that vocal utterance—to the extent its form is not predetermined by instinct, such as some bird songs or other sound systems serving a social function (the roaring of lion or hyenas, the whinnying of horses, etc.)—is one of the most interpretable forms of animal expression. Most such sounds are even produced by organs similar to those of

man. In the many graduations of their inflection, in their flexibility and correlation to changing circumstances, they are among, in my opinion, the most vital characteristics of the animal capable of producing them."

The object of his study was the baby polar bear Nanok, born in December 1931. Among Nanok's first vocal utterances recorded by Schneider were crying "in various intonations" as well as a humming or singing during nursing that he had already heard from brown bear cubs. The crying, he further specified, was like a drawn-out bleating that sounded like *ah* underlaid with *r*, and was sometimes mixed with squeaks. He also identified a "moaning," similar to the sound of a frog, which he felt expressed mild dissatisfaction. According to Schneider, this noise could—according to the situation—sink or rise "and thus display a certain melodic movement." Sometimes the "moaning" could also develop into a "squealing" like that made by young pigs. His young charge also produced hunting sounds, and Schneider determined that such "suckling, voiced 'm' sounds coming rhythmically every one to one and a half seconds" were "beautiful music for the zookeeper, for then he knows that the newborns are nursing."

At the age of ten and a half weeks, Nanok could produce "speech-like sounds that unmistakably expressed discontentment." Four weeks later, these sounds had evolved into a kind of

roaring, and after a few more months Nanok's voice exhibited an even greater change: for the first time, he conveyed his irritation with "a sinking sigh that terminated in a long, low roar . . . he had been upset during the day and ran constantly back and forth, wouldn't eat, and was afraid to go into the sleep cage because a new companion—a young brown bear—was present."

When Nanok appeared to want something badly, he would make his wishes clear with "whines, grunts, or sighs." These discordant grunting calls would begin at a high pitch and then sink in waves, as if the animal were begging. This performance was often followed by a high but faint whine. In adult animals, Schneider reported, this sound could mount to a "breathy sigh of *ao* that resembled a foghorn."

If Schneider reprimanded his charge during these bouts of begging, Nanok would get louder and louder until, his mouth wide open, he emitted scratchy cries of *a(r)* that remained at the same pitch but grew more intense, as though he were insisting. These cries could turn into a bleating that lasted for hours, which in turn darkened a few months later in the direction of an *o* sound, taking on a hollow quality. Likewise, the whining, which Schneider's colleagues also referred to as "howling," could become a defiant "excretion."

In addition to these "primary types of calls," Schneider documented two other methods of vocal communication: Nanok would snort and

he would "pop" his lips. These sounds, neither of which was produced directly in the larynx, often alternated. If Schneider moved his hand in Nanok's direction, the bear would immediately begin to snort loudly, push out his upper lip like a trunk, and let out a deep roar. According to Schneider, "This snorting is produced as an investigation through scent intensifies. When bears encounter a new object, they place their noses on it like a vacuum cleaner, breath in deeply, and then exhale sharply and audibly." Among adult bears, this blowing through the nose could even become a "rumbling."

Polar bears snort loudly when something surprises them. This snorting can seem threatening and resemble "an agitated reproach or other form of insult," as Schneider explained. Nanok was four months old when Schneider first heard him produce "lip-popping" sounds "as an accompaniment to almost every stimulus. . . . It occurs when the breath is blown forcefully into the cheeks rather than the nose, whereby the mouth half-opens with a light pop as if from a small explosion. This seems to be a behavior unique to the large bears." He further recorded how the bears converse in this way during mating season. The female in particular has a tendency to pop her lips, a sound that to Schneider suggested "the effusion of unsatisfied longing." However fascinating we may find this catalogue of "call forms," we must remember that we can understand the true feel-



ings and emotions of bears only approximately, if at all.

IF BEARS ARE SUCH VOCAL artists, can they imitate the sounds of their prey? Attracting elks by imitating their deep mating calls and then attacking them is a trick "of which one can hardly hold the moody, ungainly fellow capable," the hunter Kremenz wrote, although "experienced rangers have solemnly sworn this many times." He also recorded having such an experience himself during an elk hunt: "No further than 60 to 70 steps away from the deer hidden in the bushes, I suddenly heard a peculiar sound faintly resembling an elk's mating call from the thick brush to my left. However, the pitch and lack of clarity of this sound immediately awakened my suspicions while, as it repeated several times, inspiring both uneasiness and hope in the deer. Then—as the sound of breaking wood made clear—the figure from which the sounds seemed to emanate rushed forward in the deer's direction, emerged suddenly with a great deal of noise, and let out a mighty roar."

Today's wildlife experts cannot confirm that bears engage in such behavior. Biologist David Graber, who works in the Sequoia and Kings Canyon National Parks, even considers the vocal abilities of brown and black bears to be "quite limited, as befits a non-social animal." He distinguishes among five types of bear sounds. These include a "roar," produced when a bear is fighting

another bear, or when a trained bear is coerced into some action. Black bears in particular tend to utter a "moan" or "sigh" when they are frustrated or unhappy. With a very deep, swallowing sound originating far back in the throat, a mother bear tells her cubs to slip away quietly from danger, but if she clicks her teeth the cubs know to climb a tree or otherwise flee as quickly as possible. Finally, bears make popping and blowing sounds with their mouths to frighten off people or other animals.

Naturalist and hunter Benjamin Kilham, who lives in the woodlands of New Hampshire, has taught and nurtured orphaned black bear cubs for many years and has developed a wider list of sounds, each one of which he associates with particular emotions and states of mind. His practices of intimately observing bears have sparked controversy, because he breaks with the common orthodoxy to minimize human contact.

BEARS—WHICH HAVE A great culinary interest in honey and bee larvae—react immediately to the humming of bees. They have even been known to confuse the vibration of telephone lines with bee sounds. Brown bears have destroyed a number of telephone poles in Siberia in their search for beehives they thought they heard at the tops of the poles. Smells also play a significant role in the lives of bears, as they are able to send olfactory messages to other members of the bear population. Odors from urine, feces, and body scent



Climbing after a
honeycomb.

Marking
territory

can identify an individual, divulge its sex or age, or indicate whether it is sexually receptive. Males use their urine to advertise their presence during the mating season to attract females and to warn other males.

Bears can also communicate with each other by marking trees with their scent. This is usually done by standing on their back legs and rubbing the back, shoulders, and especially the back of the head on a tree, telephone pole, or other object. They may bite and claw the trees, too. Any bear that passes a marked tree is almost certain to stop and smell it and perhaps add its own scent. Favorite marking places are often human-made signposts, many of which are shorter than the bears. There continue to be several competing theories regarding the significance of these markings. Ernest Seton-Thompson was among the first to voice the opinion that bears exhibit such behavior in an attempt to mark their territory. Enos Mills contradicted this view by stating that the meaning of these marked trees was purely informational, indicating a deer crossing or watering hole.

Unlike female bears, whose cubs remain with them for two to three years, male bears spend most of their lives alone. As the bear's mating period rarely lasts longer than two weeks, bears are truly—despite the incongruence of the name—lone “wolves.” Furthermore, they undertake journeys that vary in length from weeks to months. Their keen senses, however, guarantee that they

are aware of the presence of others of their kind, even though, unlike humans and many other mammals, they do not seek proximity to them. The scratch marks and scents they leave seem to satisfy their need to communicate with one another.

New Hampshire naturalist Benjamin Kilham has developed his own model of bear behavior. Despite the generally accepted view of bears as nonsocial animals, he has come to see them as animals who have developed complex marking systems and means of cooperating even with unrelated individuals to signal the presence of food. Even when there are fights over scarce food resources he sees principles of “fairness” in play, because in these cases harm, if inflicted, is not fatal and is usually limited at worst to severe wounds. In addition, Kilham sees bears and humans sharing basically the same drives and motives, and he favors the view of a converging evolution of different species who, by way of their existence at the same place and time, develop similar properties. For him, this explains—despite vast differences in terms of DNA—the strong ties between humans and bears.

Bears seem to like to travel in the footsteps of other bears: Russian bear researcher Aleksandr Fyodorovich Middendorf (1815–1894) discovered a chain of such imprints made from thousands of paw prints that stretched over hundreds of miles. The path created the impression that a dense population must be present even in the most re-



mote forest areas. William Bingley documented a similar phenomenon in the American wilderness. He cited a report from someone named Düpratz, who once followed such a path for some time in the mistaken belief that it must have been created by human travelers, despite the fact that he was a good two hundred miles from any settlement. When he finally inspected the path more closely, however, he realized that the footprints were shorter than a human foot and that he could make out the imprint of a claw at the end of every toe. Unfortunately, Bingley does not tell us what Düpratz's thoughts were at this moment of realization. Did he pause to consider the weight of his discovery—or simply take to his heels in the opposite direction?

GIVEN BEARS' ACUTE senses, it is interesting to consider how the presence of humans might influence bears' behavior. A group of scientists from different European countries has recently investigated patterns of brown bear activity in the Dinaric mountains of Slovenia and Croatia, an area where bears are hunted between the fall and spring according to a quota system. By comparing the behavior of younger and older bears, the researchers found out that the latter have become predominantly nocturnal and very shy. Since almost all human activities, such as hunting, are conducted during the day, this behavioral shift is probably a response to the human activity. North American studies have also shown that

where humans are scarce or do not act aggressively, bears are largely diurnal or even give up nocturnal habits they may have previously acquired.

Bears as Pets

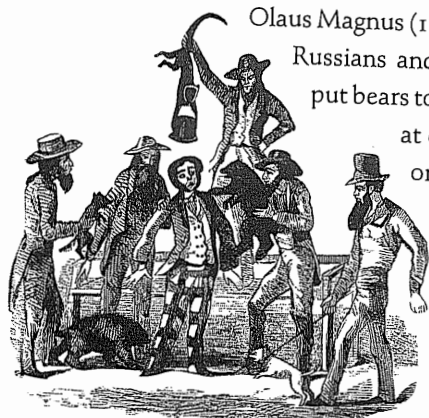
Bears have never been domesticated—or have they? An issue of *Harper's New Monthly* from 1856 includes an illustration of a mother with two babies and two bear cubs. These are genuine, living bears, frolicking in a crib with a child. What should we make of this picture? Upon reflection, this seemingly pleasant domestic idyll reveals a cruel reality, since the cubs obviously did not simply happen upon this family scene. In fact, it was once popular to take in bear cubs whose mothers had been killed in the hunt. People in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries seemed to have enjoyed the company of these amusing, fur-covered, wild "little people," who could serve as droll counterparts to their own children. This resemblance to our own young surely explains at least part of the bear's fascination for us.

That bears sometimes take on the role of "best friend"—or that this relationship may be taken to disturbing lengths—is not a development confined to America nor to recent centuries. One of the earliest pieces of evidence is a brief account by Roman philosopher Seneca (ca. 4 B.C.–65 A.D.), who told of bears that lived with humans and allowed themselves to be petted. In his *History of the Northern Peoples*, the Swedish prelate

Bear cubs in the nursery.



THE NURSERY.



BY HARRIS AND THE BROTHERS—CALIFORNIA

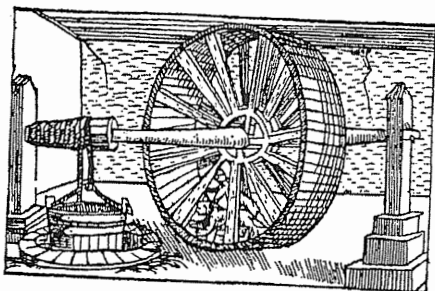
Bear, dog, and
monkey as
talismans in the
Wild West.

Olaus Magnus (1490–1558) even reported that Russians and Lithuanians knew how to put bears to work: Magnus claimed that at court bears were used alone or in groups to turn wheels that pumped water from deep springs, and that, standing upright, they hauled sacks of goods and loads of wood. Bears, he further asserted, were often placed as guards before the doors of the homes of rulers

to ensure that no dangerous animals entered the premises. While adult bears are thus portrayed as threatening, Magnus considered cubs to be “wonderful, harmless playmates for children.”

Physician and world traveler Engelbert Kaempfer (1651–1716) observed that bears in Persia were smaller than those in Europe and were easy to tame. He described two bears that walked about unattended in the city of Isfahan, claiming that the duo would bother people who

were eating lunch until they managed to get something for themselves. Because the animals belonged to the king, however, no one was willing to drive them away.



Bears powering a
waterwheel.

According to scientist Georg Wilhelm Steller (1709–1746), the world’s gentlest ursine inhabitant was the black bear of Kamchatka, a volcanic peninsula in northeastern Siberia, which is located across the Pacific Ocean from Alaska. On his Great Northern Expedition of 1733 to 1743, which he recounted in a book of the same name, Steller witnessed the Kamchatka bears running “in herds” and entering residents’ houses. But this description, however remarkable, does not indicate that these bears actually lived together with humans.

Every traveler to this part of the world during this time seems to have contributed new information—some credible, some not—about mysterious contacts between humans and bears. Sometimes, as in the case of Swedish geographer Philip Johan von Strahlenberg (1676–1747), these accounts amounted to little more than hearsay. Strahlenberg acknowledged reports of people at the mouth of the Amur River in eastern Siberia “who tame bears and use them as we do horses.” And in the middle of the seventeenth century Polish author Adam Kamiński-Dłuzzyk ascribed similar talents to the Gilyaks, claiming that “they ride bears which they direct just as we direct horses, but they trim the animals’ claws, remove their teeth, feed them in stalls like oxen and even eat them.” The likelihood that this story is probably a mere fiction is attested to by a similar story of the Gilyaks themselves. One of their legends, an account of twin brothers who brought their

bear cubs along whenever they went hunting on their skis, contains the recurring motif of reining bears, like huskies, to a sled. Once they grew larger, the story relates, the cubs were set to work pulling a sled themselves. Why did Western travelers never report witnessing such ursine talents directly?

The descriptions from the pen of J. A. Alexejenko seem more credible. In the early 1960s, the Leningrad cultural anthropologist wrote about the Kets, one of the smallest ethnic groups in western Siberia. For the Ket people, a bear was a sort of hairy wild man who was covered in fur in the same places that humans covered themselves with clothes. If they encountered a bear in the woods they would try to persuade him to do them no harm. "Go away, old man, I haven't done anything," is the bear-pacifying formula Alexejenko cited from a popular Ket story. He further claimed that childless couples were especially likely to raise bear cubs, living and eating with their foster "children" in one tent and even giving them real beds in which to sleep. According to Alexejenko, the owners talked with their bear charges, hung copper earrings in their ears and necklaces—a larger one each year—around their necks, and put bracelets around their paws. The neighbors were also happy to care for such "bear children." As they grew older, the bears were taken along on the hunt since their ability to smell the proximity of their wild relatives was a great help to their masters. Once they reached the age of three, Alexejenko wrote, the now-

adult bears were set free in the taiga, still wearing their jewelry to show that they were not to be hunted.

A report by natural history writer Anton Benedikt Reichenbach showed that bears fed by humans in the Ural Mountains sometimes adopted not only the local preference for bread and potatoes but the bad habits of their benefactors as well. Reichenbach, writing in the mid-nineteenth century, recounted the story of a bear that wandered freely through the village and was "a lover of brandy." It apparently spent most of its time in the tavern, where visitors enjoyed getting the animal drunk.

The Ainu, in turn, are reputed to have had a particularly intimate relationship with bears: in fact, an old tradition even says that this group of people are descended from them. The Ainu inhabit the island of Hokkaido in the far north of Japan as well as Russia's (formerly Japanese) Kurilen archipelago and Sakhalin peninsula. For them, bears were disguised mountain spirits who entered our world to supply mankind with fur and meat. Their bear hunts ended with a festival to return the bear's soul so that he could intercede with the spirits for mercy and the people's future well-being. In addition to hunting the animals, the Ainu also captured cubs and kept them until adulthood in cages made from tree trunks. One aspect of the Ainu's dealings with bears, however, has tended either to disturb folklorists or to be dismissed by them: in Ainu traditional society the women were responsible for raising the bears

they captured. Ainu women, who sported beard-like tattoos around their lips and on their cheeks, cared for the animals with great patience and also frequently nursed them—a practice that was not at all “secret,” despite German religious historian Johann Jacob Bachofen’s claim to the contrary in 1863. Although he apparently believed that this behavior should be kept under wraps, Bachofen had a great deal of sympathy for the Ainu women. “These bear lovers are not some sort of coarse, wild tribe,” he assured his readers. “To the contrary, they distinguish themselves from the women of neighboring peoples through their morality, their tendency to gentle kindness, and their sense of honor.”

The Ainu are not the only women said to have nursed bear cubs. Samuel Heame, who from 1769 to 1772 traveled from Hudson Bay

across the American Northwest to the Arctic Ocean, reported that “it is common for the Southern Indians to tame and domesticate the young [bear] cubs; and they are frequently taken so young that they cannot eat. On those occasions the Indians oblige their wives who

have milk in their breasts to suckle them.”

Women nursing animals is, from an anthropological point of view, not at all unusual: the women of some indigenous South American peoples, for example, are known to breastfeed small monkeys, a practice that is attributed to the



Ainu woman
nursing a bear
cub.



A captive bear
drinking from a
large bottle held
by an Ainu
tribeswoman.

fact that the monkeys play a vital role in their societies—in fact, some of them even have quasi-human status. Similarly, bear cubs taken into the homes of various peoples of the Northern Hemisphere were considered members of the family and playmates for the children—at least until the cubs began to bite. Some households even went so far as to remove the bears’ fangs and file their claws, which would buy the families a little more time with the bears.

In 1868, writer Julius Zähler, in a book on zoological gardens, recommended that those who keep bear cubs observe certain rules: “Even when

such a fellow is oh-so-tame and your good friend, he must never be allowed to lick you, for he will lick so long that the skin will begin to bleed, and once he has tasted blood he would rather have meat with it instead of keeping his best friend."

No matter how appealing the thought of raising cubs might be, the practice certainly did not make the bears' later adult lives easy. The passionate hunter A. Krementz, a careful observer of bears in Russia, was clearly familiar with this problem. In his study of bears, one of the few German books of the nineteenth century dealing exclusively with this animal, Krementz described the difficulties of persuading bears that their company was no longer appreciated. "Three six-month-old bears who had just been put out in a sack," he wrote, "found their way home through over three miles of swamp and water and expressed their happiness at arriving early the next morning by shattering the windows and, roaring with contentment, making their way to their old, familiar bed." He reported a similar story from a "professor" at the so-called Bear University in Smorgon, a town between Vilna and Minsk. The animals there were trained to do all kinds of tricks—dancing in couples, pushing baby carriages, and so on—before they underwent a "final examination" in front of a committee and were sold throughout the world. The bear trainer reported that one of his "black students," which he had presented as a gift, returned "from a place eight hours distant" in order to "complete his studies in the fine art of dance."

Swedish physician and writer Axel Munthe related another story of a supposed "house-bear." A woman in Norway, Munthe claimed, had raised a young bear that had been found in the forest. Even as an adult, the bear remained tame, would play with dogs and children, and was tied up only when the woman would visit her sister. One day the bear came running up to her as she walked through the woods on one of her visits. "He's gotten loose," the women thought, "and even lost his collar." Annoyed, she yelled at him to go home and threatened him with the umbrella she was carrying. When the bear hesitated, the woman became even angrier and hit him on the nose with her umbrella so hard that it broke in her hand. The bear ran off in the direction from which it had come. When she returned in the evening and saw the bear squatting dejectedly before the cottage, she began to reprimand it again, but the cook insisted that he had remained quietly tied up all day.

It is unlikely that bears are actually emotionally attached to their owners. Most likely they just want to be fed from a familiar hand—after all, bears raised by humans know nothing about searching for food in the wild. Such bears probably associate the scent of their caretakers with food their whole lives.

These accounts not only demonstrate that people and bear cubs have had astoundingly close relationships, they also reveal the limits of this intimacy. In 1857, for example, German professor Johann H. Blasius wrote that "bear cubs are

limits
of
intimacy

easily tamed. They remain quite harmless until they are grown and become entirely used to their environment. Once they reach the age of four, however, they acquire a grimmer character, and these friendly relationships are usually destroyed by a violent outburst of the bear's true nature." For the Ainu and Gilyaks, taking leave of the bear occurred in the form of a bloody ritual. In societies in which bears were not so bound up with religious beliefs, they were simply put out or killed.

As far as we can judge from the few existing written records, the inhabitants of eastern Siberia seem to have come closest to domesticating bears. German cultural anthropologist Leo Frobenius

A bear cub and its "parents."



nius (1873–1938), who studied (among other subjects) African cults centered on the big cats, somewhat oddly referred to the bear-taming practices of the Gilyaks in his cultural history of Africa. Thanks to the skillful handling of the Gilyaks, he wrote, the bears among them "were as good as on their way to becoming pets." According to Frobenius, the fact that "the occasional taming of bears" did not become routine was due less to the bear's unsociable nature than to the animal's inability to breed in captivity. "And so," he concluded, "the summit of what could conceivably be achieved by this method remains out of reach, and the transformation suffices only to create a playmate for gypsies at the fair."

Once animals are truly domesticated, certain behavioral traits manifest themselves in their genes. Captive and seemingly "tame" bears have never undergone this transformation. For evolutionary biologist and historian Jared Diamond, the European brown bear's "nasty disposition" explains why this animal is "perhaps the most unlikely pet": "People have been killed by pigs, horses, camels, and cattle," he wrote. "Nevertheless, some large animals are more incurably dangerous than are others. Tendencies to kill humans have disqualified many otherwise seemingly ideal candidates for domestication." One obvious example of such a recalcitrant "ideal candidate" is the grizzly bear, which

Never more than a dream: bears as beasts of burden.



would be an excellent animal to raise for meat—if it would only behave in captivity. Of course, the very fact that brown bears eat meat, at least to a certain degree, would make them more challenging to keep than, let us say, sheep.

What sort of animals would live among us today had our ancestors managed to tame bears in the same way they did wolves? This is a fascinating question, but one that must remain forever unanswered.

NO ACCOUNT OF ATTEMPTS to domesticate bears would be complete without mentioning certain practices in Southeast Asia involving sun or Malay bears, animals just half the size of their American black bear cousins. In the wild, these bears inhabit the dense jungles from Indonesia in the south to the border of China and India in the north, but until recently they were still to be found at markets in places like the suburbs of Bangkok. These captive bears are doomed to live out a miserable existence in cages. No longer part of the gene pool, and cut off from the wilderness, they are essentially dead from an environmental perspective. Although killing animals violates the tenants of Buddhism, many of these bears end up in the kitchen, thanks to tourists who consider sampling bear meat—especially the paws—to be an essential aspect of their Asian vacations. Cases have even been reported of bears being dunked alive in boiling water like lobsters. During the subsequent feast, the livers are eaten raw, the blood drunk, and the meat grilled with sesame oil

and chilies. The gallbladder, which many people believe to be a remedy for almost every disease and disorder imaginable, commands a high price. A lively business in bears once existed in places as far away as China and South Korea, but a number of countries in the region are taking measures to combat these practices. While such news is certainly reassuring, who can truly control what happens behind closed doors when good money from “gourmets” beckons?



CHAPTER TEN

Face to Face

"Many of the eastern and western provinces are infested with them equally as much as with tigers," wrote Thomas Williamson, an official of the East India Company, as he described the Indian Bengals and the presence of bears there in the early nineteenth century. "To the east of the Ganges and Megna they are very numerous," he continued, "and on the western frontier, Rognautpore may be considered their principal station. In marching through that country I scarcely ever missed seeing one or more daily, without deviating from the main road."

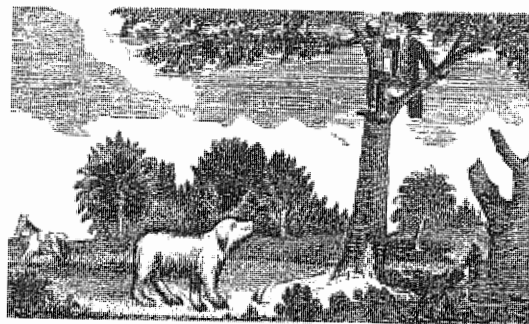
For many of us, simply seeing a bear at the side of the road would qualify as a memorable experience. But what would it be like to encounter one up close? The idea of coming face to face with such a powerful animal—or even testing our strength against it—holds a particular fascination for many commentators. In his book *Oriental Field Sports*, Williamson related the story of one such remarkable struggle: A gentleman was being carried to Mindapore in a *palankeen*, a carrier with a bamboo roof, when the bearers suddenly dropped their load and scattered in all directions. In short order, a half-grown bear climbed into the palankeen with the traveler, who had little choice but to fight the aggressive

Surprised by a
hunter (1854).

animal. The bearers, in the meantime, had found hiding places from which they could observe the goings-on. The Englishman and the Bengal bear were now embroiled in a regular brawl. Each time a combatant gained the upper hand, the spectators responded with applause or a hearty cry of "Wau! Wau!" If the man gained control of the fight, they added "Sawbash saheb," which, Williamson noted, means something like, "Well done, Master!" If the bear seemed to be winning, however, they would yell "sawbash bauloo," ("Well done, Mr. Bear!"). The fight raged back and forth for some time, until the gentleman, who was seriously injured, managed to strangle the bear with his hands.

Williamson then related that the bearers hurried over, congratulated the victor, and continued the journey. Upon reaching the next stop, however, they were arrested because they had not helped to drive the bear away and, as was typical in India during this period, were led to the marketplace to be punished. The spectators, Williamson tells us, cried "sawbash sahib" whenever the whip met its mark and "sawbash bauloo" when the negligent bearers managed to avoid a blow. Years later, the gentleman would still tell the story of his fight with the bear to anyone who asked why his face was disfigured.

At about the same time, on a distant continent a large delegation was making its way on a journey of discovery from the mouth of the Missouri River to the Pacific Ocean—the famous expedition of Lewis and Clark. No such trip through the



wilderness would be complete without a bear encounter, and one of their companions indeed reported that he ran into a "white bear" outside the camp one day. His horse was so frightened that it threw the man, who landed at the bear's feet. Since he was too close to the animal to shoot it, the intrepid explorer hit it over the head with his rifle. The bear was stunned for moment, giving the man the chance to escape up a nearby tree. After connecting with the bear's skull, however, the rifle was now jammed, and he was forced to wait on his uncomfortable perch for three hours until the animal moved on. Only then could the hapless adventurer climb back down, retrieve his horse, and ride back to the camp.

Even more densely populated Europe could serve as a stage for hair-raising bear encounters. In Switzerland, in Hilterfingen on Lake Thun, a strong man and a "grape-craving bear" encountered each other on a steep overhang in a vineyard. At least, this is the story as Carl Howard (1796–1869), a local pastor, related it: "The bear stood up, and the caretaker rushed toward it,

Finding refuge in a tree.

wrapped one arm around the bear's neck and the other around its body, and pressed his head against that of the bear. The combatants remained motionless for a while, until one or the other became impatient with standing in this awkward position. The two then began taking small steps from side to side in order to find firm ground and, like wrestlers, choose a propitious moment to throw their opponent. Suddenly, however, one of the two stumbled over the edge of the overhang, and their arms were wrapped so tightly around each other that they both fell. Still clinging to one another, they rolled abruptly over the railing onto the path below. Half stunned from their rolling fall, they finally let go, both delighted to emerge unscathed from this unexpected bout of acrobatics. The bear climbed back up the incline, while the man followed the path home. He arrived in a condition far from normal, with a look of terror on his face and a mighty shaking in his limbs."

When hunter A. Kremenz encountered a large brown bear deep in the Russian forest in the summer of 1872, he did not flee but instead intentionally drew nearer. "Master Bear," he reported, "was not the least bit disconcerted. He continued walking on serenely, stood for a while in the middle of the road, and then laid down and began contentedly rolling about in the sand. Suddenly, he got up again, shook the dust from his fur, gave me the once-over, let out a short roar, turned and went on his way, glancing now and then with disdain or mistrust in my direction." Kremenz concluded

that a bear will "never back down," claiming that "this is the guiding principle that defines its entire life and determines all its behavior."

Despite the vivid picture Kremenz painted of the disdainful bear, determining a bear's state of mind from its facial expression is close to impossible. Aside from reptiles and most types of birds, bears are among the least expressive of land animals. The bear's largely immobile face remains a mask to human observers, revealing little about the animal's mental state. Only movements of the bear's ears, eyes, and highly flexible nose offer clues to its mood—attentiveness, interest, or fear. Although the bear gnashes its teeth as a threat, like other predators do, it does not confront its opponent with the "crescendo of hissing" typical of the cat species, and its stump tail limits the vocabulary of gestures the bear can perform with this—for many other animals—expressive appendage. This relative lack of facial animation could be a reason why bears are often considered sly and devious—no matter what they are up to, their faces look composed. A noticeable change occurs only when the animal opens its mouth to yawn or roar, and it is rare for it to bare its teeth. Furthermore, individual animals of the same species can usually be distinguished only by their size or typical behavior.

According to popular belief, bears possess not only great strength but a distinctive fighting style. Many accounts claim that the bear can seize its human opponent in a proverbial "bear hug" and crush him to death. Swiss hunter and naturalist



Playful fight. Friedrich von Tschudi supplied one such account. He warned that bears can be dangerous if they are wounded, hungry, or suddenly awakened, or if their cubs are threatened. In such situations, Tschudi wrote, the bear "strides up to the enemy on its hind legs, wraps its arms around the foe, and tries to crush him." One hundred years later, in 1826, American naturalist John D. Godman described a man who was squeezed and almost suffocated in a fight with a bear. Should his readers find themselves in the same situation, Godman recommended, they should induce a spasm in the animal by pressing firmly with their fingers and thumb into the bear's neck at the point corresponding to the base of the tongue.

Surprisingly, bears that were taught the "humorous" art of boxing or wrestling with humans are not reported to have attempted squeezing their opponents. In any case, a mere blow from an angry bear's powerful paw would suffice to drive its claws into the body of its hapless foe.

After the "bear hug," one of the most enduring claims about bears is that they relentlessly pursue hunters who have shot them. Tschudi claimed that bears in the Carpathian mountains would follow hunters who had wounded them day and night, from forest to forest and from cliff to cliff, even swimming after them across streams. Furthermore, Tschudi wrote, the bears persisted for hours, searching caves, hiding places, and entire districts until they found and killed their attackers.

ON THE EVENING OF August 13, 1967, two young women were killed about ten miles apart by different grizzly bears in Montana's Glacier National Park. Not surprisingly, the incidents—the first deaths from grizzlies in any U.S. National Park since 1916—unleashed a torrent of press coverage. A call even went out to exterminate all the bears in the nation's parks. Both bears, it was determined, had habitually searched dumps and trash cans near camping spots for leftover food, and one would even eat from visitors' hands. As a result, the animals had apparently lost their fear of humans. In his account *The Night of the Grizzlies*, Jack Olsen calculated the probability of such a double attack as on the order of one in a trillion.

Not only did both attacks occur on the same day, but further investigation revealed that both victims were menstruating at the time they were killed. As a precaution, the authorities printed an informational brochure warning female visitors from hiking in areas where bears were present. A

number of American biologists then took up the question of whether grizzlies were attracted by menstrual blood and if this could have played a role in the attacks.

Subsequent investigation failed to produce any evidence that bears were interested in human menstrual blood. Further studies followed. In one experiment, polar bears were presented with sea lion meat and tampons soaked with either menstrual or normal blood. The result: the polar bears were interested in the meat and the used tampons, but not those containing nonmenstrual blood. As a next step, black, Kodiak, and grizzly bears were offered the same three items, but each of these bears spurned the tampons entirely. The scientists then ascribed the polar bears' reaction to the menstrual blood to difficulties in adequately feeding the bears during the test, but continued to argue against lifting the warning. Statistics, however, offer no evidence that human menstrual blood interests bears. Yellowstone National Park had more than sixty-two million visitors between 1980 and 2002, during which time only thirty-two bear attacks were documented, and in twenty-five of these cases the victims were men.

If menstruation is not a factor, does gender itself play a role in the bear's choice of human prey? In the past, some scientists, including Theodore Zell and Gustav Jäger, argued for the existence of a "crossover rule," claiming that male animals were more likely to attack women (the question of whether the reverse were true—that

is, whether female bears would tend to seek male victims—seems to have aroused less interest). Although this belief is reflected in the stories of many peoples, such as the Laplanders and the Buriates of Siberia, it remains unsubstantiated by scientific evidence.

If we were to rank worldwide locations where lethal conflicts between humans and various kinds of bears occur, the state of Madhya Pradesh in central India would be high on the list. Between 1989 and 1994, forty-eight people died there as a result of clashes with the shaggy, nocturnal, and relatively small sloth bear. No other animal in the region is the cause of so many injuries and deaths. Sloth bears in Sri Lanka show a similar penchant for violence, as the 1861 volume *Sketches of Natural History in Ceylon* attests. The sloth bear, Sir J. Emerson Tennent assured his readers, "evinces alarm on the approach of man or other animals and, unable to make a rapid retreat, his panic, rather than any vicious disposition, leads him to become an assailant in self-defence." The fact that the animal is simply afraid is cold comfort to the hapless individual under attack, however, since "so furious are his assaults under such circumstances that the Singhalese have a terror of his attack greater than that created by any other beast of the forest." The local inhabitants thus take the precaution of carrying a gun or "a light axe, called 'kodelly,' with which to strike them on the head," while "the bear, on the other hand, always aims at the face, and, if successful in prostrating his victim, usually com-



A sloth bear.

Shyamala Ratnayeke has surveyed close to three hundred of her countrymen who have encountered and, in some cases, been injured by sloth bears. Most of these people earn their living from hunting and from collecting honey in the forest, activities in which they can all too easily surprise a sleeping bear. Those surveyed considered the bears' behavior to be aggressive, and they sometimes resorted to killing animals that attacked or threatened them. However, in the majority of cases they refrained from taking such drastic action. "The majority of respondents, surprisingly, supported legal protection of bears," the biologist reported, "and I found few signs of systematic culling and elimination of sloth bears. In the Western world," she concluded, "this animal would long since have been exterminated."

STEPHEN HERRERO, A Canadian environmental scientist and a leading scientific authority in the study of bear attacks, has collected a great deal of

mences by assailing the eyes." The writer closes with a chilling pronouncement: "I have met numerous individuals on our journeys who exhibited frightful scars from such encounters, the white seams of their wounds contrasting hideously with the dark colour of the rest of their bodies."

Sloth bear attacks are in no way a thing of the past. In recent years, Sri Lankan wildlife expert

data for North America on this subject. He found that, between 1900 and 1980, at least forty-one people in North America were killed by bears. According to one of his more recent investigations, American black bears are known to have killed eleven people, and grizzly bears eight, during the first five years of the new millennium. Seven persons were killed by bears in 2005 alone. He relates the increase in fatal attacks to the fact that more and more people are active in bear habitats. Given that an estimated nine hundred thousand black bears live in North America, as opposed to only sixty thousand grizzlies, the latter clearly are much more dangerous to humans. His studies have also shown that most serious or fatal American black bear attacks are committed by male bears and are predatory in nature. In contrast, serious or fatal grizzly attacks are usually the work of females, apparently in defense of their young. Herrero believes that the different characteristics of attacks on humans by the two bear species correspond to differences in their evolutionary environments. In another study Herrero determined that polar bears have been known to have killed a human in Alaska only twice, a statistic that may simply reflect the fact that there aren't many polar bears there in the first place. Grizzlies, in turn, have been responsible for forty-five deaths in that state between 1900 and 2002—a figure that belies the popular belief that polar bears are the most dangerous bears of all.

Of course, many encounters or direct conflicts

Uikes!

between humans and bears go unreported or make only regional news. In 2005, the Minnesota Department of Natural Resources related that a fifty-year-old woman named Mary Munn encountered a black bear as she walked in the woods near her home, thirty miles south of Duluth. When the bear charged, Mary began to run but then stopped and turned to avoid being tackled from behind. The bear veered off but then charged again, and Mary responded by punching it repeatedly in the nose. Her dog managed to draw the bear away several times, but it always returned. At one point the bear clawed the woman's knee and she fell down. The bear bit her thigh and then clamped onto her armpit and began shaking her. Suddenly and inexplicably, however, the animal ran off, and Mary was able to walk home and call for help.

Although such reports can create the impression that bear attacks are a regular occurrence in small-town America, encountering a bear in the wild is no reason for panic. There are often no simple rules for acting under such circumstances, but the nature of a bear attack does depend on the species involved. Black bears (which rarely eat meat) are generally not aggressive, but inhabitants of North America are far more likely to encounter them than other kinds of bears. However, black bear attacks, while rare, do occur and are motivated by a predatory impulse; if a black bear is coming after you, it wants to kill and eat you. Author Nick Jans, who has a great deal of experience with bears, puts it like this: "Brown/

grizzlies are, far and away, the bears most likely to attack; black bears are almost always safe. Yet if a black bear does commit to an all-out assault, it's the ravening beast of nightmare." Herrero's findings also suggest that black bears are more likely to attack younger or smaller humans that appear more vulnerable. In any case, experts agree that if you are attacked by an aggressive black bear, you should fight back with all your might and with anything at hand—so Mary did the right thing by punching the bear in the nose. Trying to run is a mistake. Instead, you should do your best to drive the bear away—by shouting, throwing objects, or running toward it—before it really gets going.

The guidelines published by Denali National Park in Alaska for dealing with grizzly bears illustrate how differently animals of this species behave from their black bear cousins. According to the park's experts, the most serious mistake you can make with a grizzly is to encounter it by surprise, because it is precisely when they are startled that grizzlies find humans threatening and attack them. Since grizzlies can perceive human voices from a thousand feet away, they usually retreat long before a hiker draws near. Whistling, shouting, talking, or singing while hiking thus alerts them to your presence, even in areas where they might not see you otherwise or where the sound of running water can drown out your footsteps.

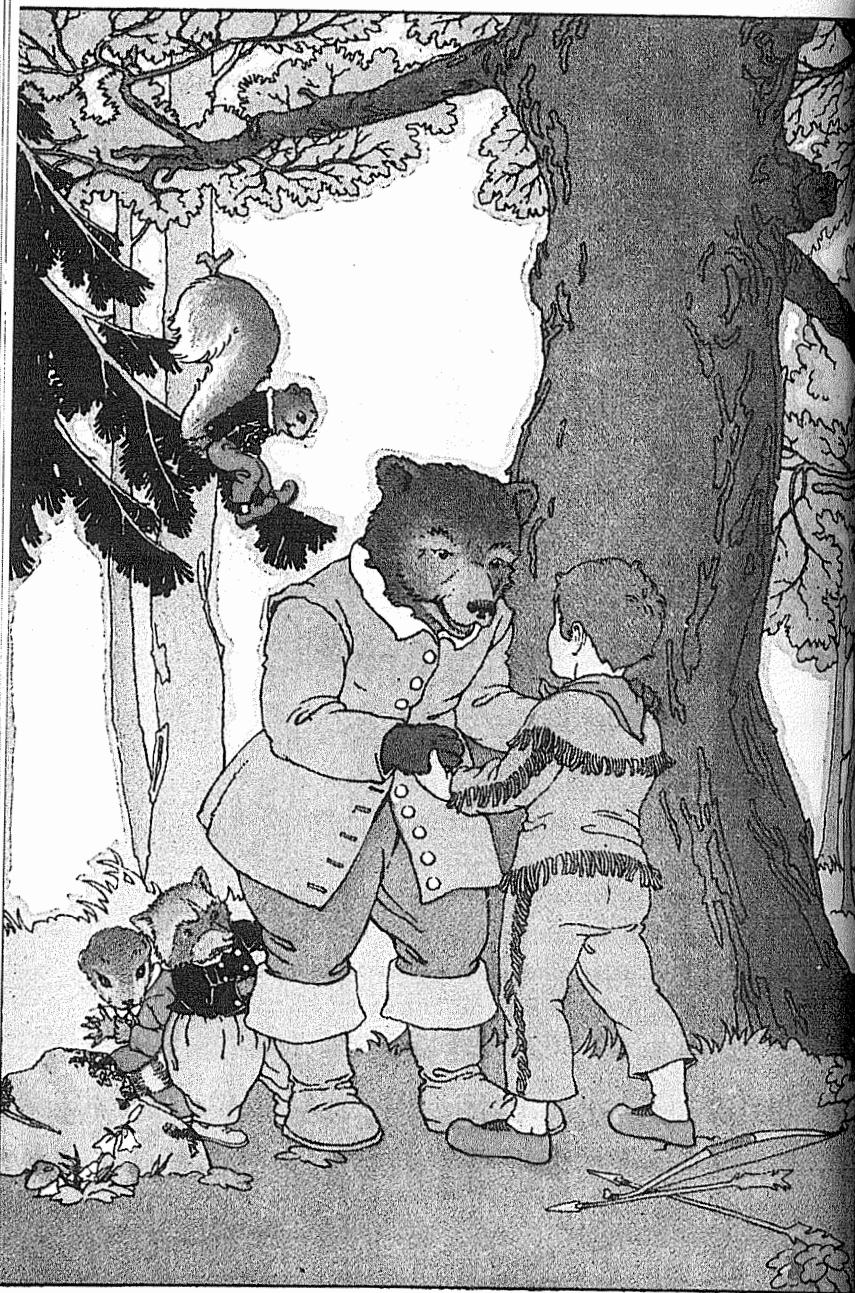
In the great majority of cases, the bears will go out of their way to avoid you. Dogs should be left

at home, since they can track grizzlies and provoke them to aggression. Foods with strong odors such as fish, cheese, or raw meat should be carried in airtight containers and hung overnight well above the ground in bear-proof containers.

You should stay at least fifty yards from any bears you do see, and twice that distance if cubs are present. If, despite these precautions, you find yourself face to face with a brown bear, the experts advise you to back up or make a wide detour. Do not draw nearer under any circumstances, no matter how tempting the opportunity seems—the photo of a lifetime could be the last one you take. Grizzly body language can provide valuable indications of the animal's mood. By standing up on its hind legs, the bear is not automatically demonstrating aggression—this posture is usually just a sign that the animal is interested in something. However, if it stands directly in front of you and roars or yawns, it is ready to attack, although its primary motive may be simply to defend its space. Resisting the impulse to flee is vital in this situation. Oddly enough, park rangers recommend lying face down on the ground with your arms around your neck and remaining still. This takes courage, but it is the best way to avoid a direct physical confrontation with a grizzly—a contest that humans are unlikely to win. If you think you are likely to need advice on this matter, you can consult the vast body of books on bear attacks and how to avoid them; this book is not the place for more detailed recommendations.

Before the thought of cowering face-down as a bear stands over you and sniffs your hair prompts you to cancel your Alaskan vacation, remember that you are unlikely ever to encounter a bear in the first place. Sensational reports of bear attacks may make for exciting reading, but they can easily create a false impression. For the most part, bears are far less interested in us than we are in them.





"WELCOME TO THE GREAT FOREST, LITTLE BROTHER."

Epilogue



Bears are in trouble today in much of the world for a number of reasons. There is no part of the bear's body that humans have not put to use in one way or another. In some cuisines, bear paws are a prized delicacy, and a list of medical uses that have been ascribed to the various other parts of the animal's body is long indeed. Many people still firmly believe that bear bile offers relief from almost any ailment imaginable. While the active ingredient—Urso-deoxycholic acid (UDCA), or, to those in the medical field, simply *urso*—can now be manufactured synthetically, genuine bear bile is still so sought after in extensive regions of Southeast Asia that an entire industry is built around the lucrative business of providing it. On bear farms, especially in Thailand, China, and Vietnam, Malay or "sun bears"—which are known for their habit of sitting in a way that resembles the Buddha—are kept in narrow cages and their gallbladders regularly "tapped" with shunts for bile. This practice is no doubt as painful as it is cruel.

Bears in the wild have it better, but they can't survive just anywhere. A bear habitat must provide a reliable food supply throughout the year

"Welcome to the great forest, little brother." From *The Billy Bang Book* (1928).

and enough privacy for the animals to remain undisturbed. Brown and black bears also need places where they can hibernate. In Europe only the mountain forests still meet the bears' needs—provided that hiking trails, rest areas, and the tendency of human visitors to intensively collect berries, pine cones, and nuts do not negatively affect the animals.

In North America, bears are often effectively cut off from one another by highways, spreading suburbs, industrial areas, and farms so that they might as well be living on separate islands. Geneticists fear that this isolation could inhibit the exchange of genetic information critical for their survival. As scientists now know, inbreeding results in not only noticeably similar markings, but also bone deformations and reduced fertility. But the genetic material of bears living in these compromised habitats can circulate only if the bears themselves can reach one another. The organization Y2Y—Yellowstone to Yukon—is trying to make this possible by building wildlife bridges and highway underpasses so that bears and other animals can travel from one preserve to another.

BEARS FACE NOT ONLY human encroachment into their habitats but also poaching and environmental pollution, which has become so pervasive that even the polar bears are affected by it. Yet the greatest threats to bears may be our own perceptions of them. What cultural filters distort how we see bears today? Are they teddies to love, endangered animals to save, or beasts to

fear? Many of the qualities earlier generations attributed to bears may seem unfounded and unfathomable to us, but our own prejudices and assumptions can rest on equally shaky ground.

There is hardly a "cute" or a "funny" role that bears have not played for us. Their images advertise every imaginable type of product and adorn the packaging of countless treats. The tendency to project human qualities onto bears is nearly universal, and it's not difficult to understand why. Its strength and at least occasionally upright stance almost inevitably encouraged human beings, at least in the Northern Hemisphere, to view the bear as our own wild alter ego. But this feeling of kinship is a double-edged sword. While our identification with bears can lead us to value them, it stands in the way of a true understanding of what bears are like. And what are they like? Despite the fact that we can now accurately track bears with technologically advanced equipment and can examine their DNA, we can't fully answer this question. One thing, however, is certain—bears are not much like us after all.

Our fascination with bears also makes it difficult for us to recognize that, no matter how familiar their glance and gait may seem, bears are not interested in people. But indifference on their part should not prevent us from feeling admiration, respectful curiosity, and concern for the bears that share our world. I would like to have faith in our ability to devise intelligent ways for humans and bears to coexist—although I hope this book has made it clear that we should also

keep a respectful distance from them. Since completely avoiding anthropomorphism may be impossible, perhaps we can think and speak of the bears as our distant relatives in the forest who have their own ways of doing things and simply prefer to keep to themselves. Let us not be disappointed—the bears cannot help it. We can avoid clashes between humans and bears only if we learn to stay out of their way. Anything else is the stuff of dreams!

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SOPHIE BOBBÉ (FRANCE), Ingmar Braun (Switzerland), Martha Dowsley (Canada), David Graber (USA), Stephen Herrero (USA), Michael Hofreiter (Germany), Catherine Knight (New Zea-

Marthaler Meets Chekhov: *The Three Sisters*, Volksbühne Premiere, Berlin, September 1997

Lydia Stryk

Nothing draws a crowd in this theatre and festival inundated city like a new Christoph Marthaler production. The crowd, noticeably young, and by now trained and tuned to Marthaler's language, awaits his work as a kind of sustenance. The forty-six-year-old Swiss-born Marthaler must continue in the way any guru must, because so many depend on his vision of the world continuing. Repeated, replayed, like mantras. Marthaler came into the world and created Marthaler's world. And there can no longer be a world without Marthaler. And of course, there are now Marthaler followers who produce Marthaler-esque works without, naturally, his maddeningly patient genius. There are the zombie-like Marthaler types repeating Marthaler-type actions and inaction. But the imitators produce only boredom without transport; irritation without release. And most seriously absent is a kind of loving empathy Marthaler shows the characters who people his world. The imitators are not Marthaler; but even Marthaler, who cannot escape being Marthaler, has now turned outside of his self-revolving world (no one really exits a Marthaler scenario) for inspiration. Perhaps recognizing the danger of self-parody (and giving a boost to the self-esteem of playwrights everywhere) Christoph Marthaler has begun to direct "legitimate" theatre plays—texts with dialogue and scenes and beginning, middles and ends. Last season saw his Hamburg production of Horváth's *Kasimir und Karoline*, and last week Chekhov's *The Three Sisters* opened at the Volksbühne am Rosa-Luxemburg-Platz—Marthaler's Berlin home.

Marthaler. Chekhov. The pairing is anticipated with an almost sensual delight. After all, Marthaler's stagings have often felt at best like holy parodies of Chekhov: unspoken Chekhov, where the sitting and the waiting and the boredom and the falling apart occupy the spaces between words, expanding and engulfing language.

Anna Viebrock, Marthaler's longtime collaborator, has created a single set inspired by her photographs of a Soviet-abandoned Polish country manor house. The photos which illustrate the evening's program (a compilation of texts on the subject of work by the likes of Marx and Richard

Sennett) describe a destroyed, spacious emptied world touched by remnants of both bourgeois elegance (decadence?) and socialistic realism—both now long abandoned. White and off-white dominate the tiled floors and walls. Threadbare Persian carpets cover worn wooden tables. And then, the dominating staircase with its steel banister—a thin and delicate floral motif—which becomes the stage for Marthaler's Chekhov: the set a replication of the multileveled staircase and empty landings and the hallway, shut off from any rooms or views. The four acts play out along the banisters on chairs lining the ground-level banister heading down, and in the orchestra pit where a Persian rug covers a large wooden table surrounded by odds and ends of chairs, both antique and decidedly Soviet. As in all Marthaler, vastness and distance are the essential playing field. And in the pit are, as well, a harmonium and a piano—instruments whose muted carnival and church-like tones will underscore the evening's storytelling. For there is a story this evening. The tale of three sisters, told by the antinarrative master, himself.

The three sisters themselves, as unlike as any three women might be, first appear marching down the stairs one behind the other in comic unison. Olga, early middle-aged, is a buxom, bleached blond, chronic (comic) complainer. Masha, here in her mid-to-late fifties, is old-fashioned and severe. Irena, appropriately aged, as if to throw us off our expectations for the unexpected completely, is fire-eyed, if grim, and perfectly ripe for standard Chekhov. Natasha, too, is appropriately young—a Turkish beauty (in Germany, the classic outsider), but it is her husband, Andrey, who is, though appropriately aged and absent-minded, the true point of intersection between Chekhov and Marthaler. For following on from Andrey all the other characters are classic Marthaler types who to varying degrees meet Chekhov's. And several of the most endearing characters—here playing Chekhov's parts—the old doctor, Ferapont, Anfisa, several of the soldiers, seem to step out in and out of any Marthaler production untouched. Vershinin is here an aging stiffened Sinatra-esque crooner. The hangers-on, people of the house, the soldiers, teachers, are all

varyingly buffoonish, pathetic, outfitted in ill-fitting suits (aging socialist bureaucrats come to mind) and mismatched articles. The women are oddly attired, in colors and styles that don't work. The men, several wearing thick-framed glasses, look decidedly unwashed. The younger men accent their oddity with behavioral tics.

This is how one critic describes Marthaler territory, "depression in broken-in house slippers" (*Depression in Pantoffeln*): a slow, mostly silent world of low-energied, plain and shabby oddballs in old slippers and clompy worn-out dress shoes. They shuffle, they stumble, they drop things. They hang, they slump, they sit up straight—staring out or down (in this case, down into the stairwell over the banister into a place we cannot see). Occasionally in a spurt of energy, they gesticulate, they run, they sing (often quite beautifully) when they have lines to say, as in Chekhov, they'll march or stride into place, speaking their lines nose to nose or else they'll stay put, addressing each other across vast distances, sometimes looking at each other, most often, not. Rarely, they'll make physical contact: oddly pairing up to dance a slow clumsy waltz or a bizarre tango, lightly tapping out emotion on another's back, sniffing each others' fingers in a long sequence at the Chekhovian proverbial dinner table. Occasionally, they speak in garbled unison, though only once in this production. The lines here are actually quite clear. Their speech is articulated monotone or shouted outbursts and rarely—but when, then noticeably—with passion.

And it is a repressed but present passion that I think the Berlin critics miss in their disappointed appraisal of Marthaler's Chekhov. The lines are Chekhov's, that no one can deny. But is this Chekhov or Marthaler or both? And does it matter? These are the questions critics inevitably bring to the production. For one critic, Marthaler's signature approach is a brutal reduction of Chekhov's tragic-comic figures in the service of Marthaler. Where is the hope, asked this dismayed critic, the emphasis, the enthusiasms, of Chekhov's now one-hundred year old characters? Used up, is Marthaler's answer, the critic argues. Replaced by a cool diagnosis of the scene.

For a second critic, Marthaler's failure stems from a fatal problem of dialects. Having de-psychologized Chekhov's characters, says the critic, Marthaler has nothing to work against. And this undialectical field, thus, begins and ends in a soft

boredom. Any enlightenment that comes late in a successful Marthaler staging is absent, each act a repetition without development. The soviet modernization of the country manor house signifying, for this critic, Marthaler's staging of the play. Whatever emotional and psychological tension that held Chekhov's world together replaced by the failed hindsight of modern socialism. A third critic echoes the frustration of the others—decrying the absence of hope, vitality and the spiritual presence of the future which is ever-present in Chekhov's plays.

Having seen and admired—even delighted in—Marthaler's *Three Sisters*, and then reading these critiques, the question that comes to my mind is what would a perfect realization of a Chekhov play look like? Can any production find that exact combination of absurdity and psychological reality that is viewed by most as essential? True, Marthaler's Chekhov is never sad. There is one brilliant tragic moment when Masha has taken leave of Vershinin. She does an absurd song and dance without emotional expression but somehow hugely expressive of her pain. Whereas the classic tear-producing moment of the old Doctor's halfhearted suicide attempt is here more comically endearing than tragic. The oversize drunken old man, wobbling with one leg over the banister approaches slapstick—Marthaler style, of course—slowly and heavily.

For me, this *Three Sisters* brought into pure, even crystal relief, the absurd in Chekhov—often cloaked or muddled in psychologically driven productions. And this absurd clarity was not without a gradually evolving emotional realization of the characters, either. (Thanks to wonderfully controlled performances by Marthaler's heroic troupers.) I loved the way Marthaler merged into Chekhov: without haste (four hours long!), imperceptibly, with nothing forced. Dare I suggest that Chekhov, himself, might have approved? The absurd and alienating choreography of Marthaler shifting micro-cosmically into a sensitive internalization of Chekhov, real. How did this happen? Perhaps through the gentle infusion of the playwright's spirit into any world in which he lands? Whatever it was, Marthaler's people became Chekhov's.

Subverting the emotional and psychological excesses of drama, itself, Marthaler's *Three Sisters* puts forward the philosophical idea. The idea, not without compassion, on the contrary, that humanity situates itself in the absurd.

Chapter 1: The Foundations of the Game Plan

Play Development and the Search for Innovative Writing

Sherlock Holmes loves a good mystery. He enjoys the excitement and intrigue associated with challenging questions that take him and Watson into *terra incognita*. Holmes knows what he must uncover, and he has some sense of how he will discover the truth—through questions and investigation, and keen powers of observation. He doesn't accept every case because he prefers those without a typical set of clues. He looks for the problem that is extraordinary in its challenge and demands a unique if not innovative solution. The case that grabs his interest presents opportunities to wrestle with unknowns and feels akin to a challenging game. The intrigue Holmes seeks isn't rooted in the stuff of melodrama and soap opera, but the elusive thought piqued by provocative questions and unusual relationships. Even as he travels through virgin territory, he has a strategy in mind, one that is simultaneously fixed in its process and flexible in its execution and design.

"Strategy" can have a negative connotation when it's defined as a method to control others (or a situation) so that one person wins. However, when applied to the work of play development, "strategy" means that it is best to approach work with the playwright's needs and wants at the center, and to devise a way to shape the process that proves beneficial for the writer and the play.

Like Holmes, the active dramaturg has a process for approaching the development of new work that is both fixed and flexible. Open questions fuel an active process rooted in observations (gleaned from reflections) that respond to how the play realizes its critical elements. Just as Holmes encounters various witnesses and must distinguish between a genuine clue and a red herring, the active dramaturg must separate conversations that talk about solutions from those that present active options to pursue. To talk *about* a dramatic moment during the workshop is to explain the problem or add detail to embellish. During a workshop, such language presents a false sense of moving forward. To discuss a moment means exploring options that will activate and propel the play forward. Active dramaturgs work to cultivate discussions so that the active playwright has options when rewriting.

To best frame the play development investigation, the active dramaturg must remain flexible and rely on the active playwright's vision for the play, which will adjust either a little or a lot throughout the workshop.

Active playwrights create worlds. Characters live in worlds. The strongest plays have fully realized worlds inhabited by characters, be they fully or partially realized.

The most crucial aspect of the game for Holmes is challenge. Holmes defines challenge as a problem that presents an opportunity to stretch the mind while assisting others, which coincides well with the active dramaturg's idea of challenge. Similarly, Holmes defies each obstacle the challenges present by engaging more fully in the process of thinking, questioning, and applying strategy until he achieves success. In short, Holmes finds challenge fun.

Sadly, most shy away from this positive type of challenge because it is tough. That said, when challenge is simply an opposition for no rational reason, it is right to avoid it.

The Goal of a Workshop

To discuss success within the context of a play development workshop may seem misplaced because a workshop inherently means to engage in the act of doing, and most revere the development process for its ability to support constant discovery without necessarily fixed outcomes. Even so, identifying the hallmarks of a strong, successful workshop remains key in light of the numerous ersatz processes that result in no substantial change or revitalized artistic vision. In brief, an unsuccessful process looks like this: throughout the rehearsal, the room feels alive with welcoming, engaging conversations, and even a few rewrites appear, but the collaboration yields results that no one uses after the workshop.

Many mistakenly believe the goal of a workshop or the hallmark of a workshop's success includes achievements like completing an act or score, or writing the play's ending. The workshop's true endgame, however, is to find the play's heart or story by crafting an active sentence for the play, and to connect the moments, scenes, or dialogue to this sentence. A successful workshop means that the active writer leaves with a vision for the play, a plan for writing (or rewriting), The Sentence to focus the rewrites, a desire to embrace how it may morph, and an enthusiasm to continue discussing the play. Balancing or tuning the play's voice also signals a successful workshop. Every step of a strong game plan operates with these points in mind.

Balancing or tuning the play's voice signals a successful workshop.

The Sentence Defined

To facilitate a dynamic play development process, the active dramaturg leads the active writer through a process to discover The Sentence that best captures the play's action. Some might call The Sentence the play's thesis statement; to others, it is the play's journey, which is akin to a character's journey. Like the active statement that an actor crafts to identify a character's journey, The Sentence frames the play's action (story and plot) from the first moment to the last. The Sentence needn't revolve around one character, but it should articulate the story the play seeks to tell in a single thought, simply expressed. The Sentence articulates the story the play seeks to tell and addresses at least two of the play's major themes, which connect to the journeys of at least two-thirds of the play's characters (both major and minor).

The Sentence

- ♦ An active statement that articulates the play's action in a way that impacts at least two-thirds of the characters
- ♦ Helps shape the creative team's conversation
- ♦ Helps focus the creative team's conversation
- ♦ Helps focus the development process

The Sentence is active, straightforward, and often difficult to formulate. Why? Because a play depends on numerous details, character stories, and thematic ideas coming together. To express each of these ideas through a clear frame proves challenging because The Sentence strips everything away and identifies a central idea connecting each of the play's thematic lines or at least the play's major action. The Sentence activates and connects story and plot.

The Sentence also articulates the active idea that shapes every scene and a majority of the characters. As such, The Sentence serves as the touchstone for the entire development process, for it functions as either a metaphorical clothesline upon which all scenes and moments hang upon or a ladder where each character, moment, and scene exists as a rung. For these reasons, The Sentence resonates as more than the primary lesson or takeaway for the play. The Sentence serves as the play's crucial organizing principle.

How to Craft The Sentence

Hollywood regularly distills every film, especially action movies and thrillers, into simple trailer statements or sentences. These often imitated trailers begin with the phrase, "In a world where . . ." The second phrase introduces the character's (or characters') response to the setup. The third part presents the obstacle that the character faces and will inspire the film's main action. The Sentence embraces this

simple philosophy but encourages the writer to articulate the dramatic ideas in a creative, active, non-formulaic manner.

The Sentence of the Play #1

Hamlet

The play's sentence could be: **To right the wrongs committed against Elsinore and its people.** This sets up the play's opening: the night watch and the ghost's haunting suggest that things are not right in the state of Denmark and the town/castle of Elsinore. This sentence continues to frame the action through the play's end when Fortinbras enters to find all Hamlet's family and key supporters dead. The Fortinbras line is in a position to reclaim the land that, according to Fortinbras, belongs to his family and was wrongly taken. At the beginning, the audience believes that Hamlet will set out to right the injustice and the wrongs festering within the kingdom. Throughout the play's action, however, the story reveals that Old Hamlet brought about the air of evil and mistrust, and that Fortinbras, not Hamlet, spends the entire play focused on these political injustices as he traverses the Danish countryside; whereas Hamlet is focused on his family's betrayals.

The Sentence and Play Development

Using The Sentence throughout a play development process helps shape the conversations and work. The greatest difficulty for most is identifying the key sentence. For example, if a character's journey fails to connect to The Sentence, either The Sentence or the character's journey must change. Or, if a major theme lives outside The Sentence's focus, most likely The Sentence needs to change. In truth, The Sentence can and will evolve as the story moves into focus. This is fine. At some point the right Sentence will emerge. A changing sentence indicates a deeper understanding of the play—its themes, characters, and vision. The sole caveat: remember to adjust the elements of the story as The Sentence changes. This constant evolution will lead to specific changes rather than endless and general rewrites if the active writer, active dramaturg, and artistic team continue to focus on one thing: clarifying the story.

Collaborators flounder or encounter outright resistance (or a thinly veiled look of contempt) from the writer when critiques are based on their assumption of the play's goal or intention. These missteps make a successful collaboration difficult and stem from one crucial mistake: failing to ask the writer to describe the play's action succinctly. Asking for clarity of thought does not minimize the play's scope and importance; it simply asks the active playwright to participate in shaping the process by articulating the through-line for the dramatic work. Using The Sentence removes the need to employ overly guarded or obtuse language when discussing the play. Every open question posed, reflection obtained by using the critical

In general, The Sentence is simple and direct with few subordinate clauses or heavy grammar.

The Sentence of the Play #2

Hamlet

The play's sentence could be: **To navigate the challenge of placing family loyalty and needs before that of the State's.** This sets up the play's first challenge: managing the new relationship with Claudius, Hamlet's uncle-father. It also sets up the second challenge: the ghost's appearance and his directive. Laertes has a similar challenge from his send-off to his return after his father's murder. Fortinbras also takes up the family versus state mantle. How the women fare proves even more complex. It's possible that Gertrude must marry a Hamlet in order to remain Queen. Ophelia must grapple with state politics and dating a royal. When Hamlet, a royal, murders her father, an advisor, she must accept the state's decision to not prosecute Hamlet. Throughout the play's action, the world reveals that individuals lose a great deal of self-esteem and power (even mental stability) when subjugating one's self to the interests of the state. Even Fortinbras reflects on the impact sacrifice has and will have on him.

elements, or successful dramatic moment may be discussed in relation to how poorly or how well each supports The Sentence throughout the play.

The Sentence doesn't seek to reduce or minimize the story but to identify the action that drives the play forward and propels the characters through a journey comprised of tangential or central plot lines. A good play is concerned with more than one idea. Using The Sentence as a frame and a starting point for all subsequent questions, comments, and other creative choices makes it easy to see how various comments and observations impact or respond to the work. Often, identifying The Sentence can help reduce the play development conversation to mere minutes because everyone is on the same page. When ideas inspire new perceptions or a fresh take on an old insight, collaborators simply need to ask, "How does this point connect to The Sentence?" or "Should The Sentence itself change?"

Clarifying The Sentence

Many mistakenly believe The Sentence states what the play is about or the topics the play covers. It does not. The Sentence pinpoints key moments of action and gravitates toward active storytelling. Second, The Sentence is concise. A play may embrace many ideas, but focusing on what a play is about often leads to generalities and a long unwieldy sentence. Focusing on what the play is about can lead to general conversations about states of being (such as happiness), or general themes (like bullies are bad). Only when dealing with a play with multiple subplots (think Shakespeare) might The Sentence expand to two or three sentences, though with a little effort even these multi-act plays may be summarized with a strong, single sentence.

Charting the evolution of The Sentence and how it impacts the active dramaturg and any conversations the active dramaturg and active playwright have with various members of the artistic team may help demonstrate The Sentence's effectiveness.

Consider a fictitious work that features barnyard animals vying for power and freedom and contending with their world's boundaries—a fence, a river, and a road.

The Sentence first begins as:

This play explores what it's like when considering options.

This sentence indicates what the play's themes might be, but states nothing explicitly. Quite simply, this sentence expresses what the play is *about*, which is why it comes across as vague and fails to help the play appear unique (at its root, any play deals with options). The questions this sentence provokes are many. For example: Is the play presenting life and death options for the barnyard animals? Or, what are the farmer's options regarding keeping or selling the farm? Is the play following the animals as they consider a way to rebel to save their lives or rebel to solve the humans' problems? Without a good Sentence, the options are too varied and it's difficult for a director, dramaturg, actor, or designer to begin shaping a specific world that realizes the playwright's work. However, posing open questions that illuminate the writer's ideas and aid in developing the play will ultimately help the writer create more specificity and dynamism within the work. If the active dramaturg crafts open questions that bring out more detail and eventually define this Sentence's "options," The Sentence and the play will begin to evolve. When the conversation with the writer includes too many closed or vague questions two things could happen. One, the writer becomes overwhelmed by the number of times the word "options" is repeated and realizes the entire piece or sentence needs to change in some way; or two, the active writer thinks of numerous literal answers rather than the solutions the play needs. In either case, the development process begins to involve options or character journeys that are unintended and not in line with the writer's vision.

The play development that accompanies an overly vague Sentence may see a number of rewrites as various ideas are explored. Great scenes could be fashioned, but the overall story would remain bloated and perhaps heavy on exposition. Forward progress won't be made because the roadmap for the play and what the writer wants to see in action remains as fuzzy by the end as it was in the beginning.

Unless . . .

The Sentence morphs into:

This play explores what it's like when a chicken considers options.

If the writer considers some of the questions posed by the dramaturg or other lead members of the creative team and uses them to identify a central character, or set of characters, and their wants, The Sentence will evolve into something more specific and active. Suddenly, The Sentence helps the play begin to take on a personality and reveals the play's possible voice (or quirkiness) by identifying a central figure. By grounding The Sentence in a central character, the way the "options" will be considered will change, for a chicken thinks one way and a pig, another. True, it would be nice to know what the options are, but the possibilities are winnowing. This version of The Sentence tells us that the options concern the chicken only. The rest of the barnyard animals figure into the story, but less so, and each animal may respond in ways that echo or challenge the chicken, creating possibilities for tension and conflict.

Certainly adding a specific character helps, but the vagueness of the options still remains. The writer runs the risk of losing the ability to lead the play development process and discover the answers best suited to the play. However, because the writer has now identified a central figure through whom much of the action flows, and other characters for the chicken to interact with or respond to, the play can begin to develop a singular focus even though it runs the risk of hitting one note and losing its focus early.

Unless . . .

The Sentence morphs into:

This play explores what it's like when a chicken considers crossing the road.

Suddenly the chicken has a clearly defined obstacle: crossing the road. There's a risk that this idea could result in a great comic skit and not an interesting play. However, if the active writer, active dramaturg, and creative team begin to explore the various obstacles and benefits of breaching this particular boundary something interesting might evolve. What's more, it's now possible for other characters to consider this central idea—the chicken crossing the road—and their responses to the chicken's dilemma can slowly (or quickly) take the play in other directions. Also, the phrase "what it's like when a *chicken*" makes it clear that what the chicken does, sees, or hopes for will be placed in contrast to other characters; the play is not looking at what's unique to chickens. A variety of perspectives and insights, if followed, guarantee a multifaceted play.

Even so, there is still the possibility that the play will remain cerebral and concerned solely with philosophical ruminations, rather than with pursuits that lend themselves well to dramatic action.

Unless . . .

The Sentence becomes:

This play follows the journey (life) of a chicken unable to cross the road.

Suddenly the play's story is clear and full of action, dilemma, tension, and breadth. When the active playwright presents this active sentence, it is clear how the active dramaturg and other members of the creative team can respond to the play and focus their observations and comments. The team can now look to see whether the play's moments serve the chicken's journey and conflict: an inability to act; specifically, an inability to cross the road. The specificity of this question means that The Sentence is working to focus the moments and scenes so that they respond directly to the chicken's inability to cross the road. If the play's moments do not support the personal search for action, perhaps they support the journey of a chicken's life? Again, this question stems directly from The Sentence, which ensures that the scenes and moments tie into the dramatic action while embracing other life challenges the chicken experiences with her friends on the farm. Actors can make choices that connect to this major through-line and add color and depth to this vision, and so can designers and directors. Active dramaturgs can use the specific obstacles that prevent the chicken from crossing the road to help the writer use form and time to enrich the story and establish a unique dramatic world. In addition, this version of the sentence does not telegraph the ending. The chicken may gather the strength

The Sentence
avoids giving
away the end but
does help the team
get there.

to cross the road by play's end either on its own or with the help of other animals or farmhands, or she may never succeed, but discover something else along the way. The insertion of "unable to cross the road" alerts everyone to the chicken's consistent, but perhaps not permanent, state of being.

The Search for Innovative Writing

Those who embrace the principles of active dramaturgy and active playwriting when developing or producing a new work must have a willingness to experiment, explore, and set high standards. Setting a high bar does not mean expecting perfection, but it does suggest an unwillingness to embrace mediocrity or what has been done before as it has been done before. Untold examples of new work modeling tried-and-true structures exist, and have garnered the writer (and artistic team) success at the expense of truly innovative work. Success, often defined in monetary terms, can mean spoon-feeding audiences what they think they want or repeating what is now well past its prime. The challenge with remaining ahead of the curve rather than producing the expected or the current fad is to identify the moment when the storytelling style shifts from new and avant-garde to predictable and hackneyed. There are times, however, when a new story works best if supported by a tried-and-true form or plot. When the ideas and character struggles are too challenging or explosive, and are then coupled with an explosive and daring form, the play's story and message may not reach any audience.

Active dramaturgs and those who use dramaturgical principles work daily to develop an audience's sensibilities so that the audience remains adventurous and open to new theatrical styles, but also appreciative of strong, old fashioned storytelling structures that facilitate bold new ideas. Active dramaturgs ferret out innovation to ensure creative, artistic, and yes, financial satisfaction for all. The challenge is to champion innovation in whatever shape it takes so that audiences and artists embrace it fully and so the final result leads to good fortune for all—however one may define fortune. The challenge for active playwrights is to push new forms when appropriate and to embrace traditional forms when the narrative proves too explosive.

The question is, how does the writer use a formula to tell a story? Is formula used as a default to simplify the process, or to frame challenging ideas so that they are easier to grasp? As ironic as it may seem, at some point every storytelling form becomes formulaic for one simple (if not sobering) reason: formulas can and do work.

It's true.

Law and Order's nineteen-year run (in spite of multiple casts) is a testament to the fact that formulas work. Even though you can set your clock to the entrance and exits of the cops, attorneys, the obligatory twist, last minute collaboration, and final confrontation, the stories hold the viewer's attention. Even in reruns, the ripped-from-the-headlines story almost always seems new or timely. Why are the repeats

so successful and engaging? Because the writers focus on the facts and rarely embellish the storytelling with extraneous character details. The catch with *Law and Order* is that these are not facts recounted baldly—these are facts supported by the essential details that round out the who, what, when, where, and sometimes why. Essential details avoid rigid interpretation; instead they embellish a fact by grounding it.

Excellent writing for the stage does much the same thing—it provides audiences and creative teams the facts or essentials needed to define the story's truth. Such writing leaves room for performers to build nuanced characters that speak to every generation regardless of when or where the play is set. Too often, however, writers choose or are urged to elevate their story with details or flowery additions rather than the specifics that pierce the story's heart.

As noted in *The Art of Active Dramaturgy*, the more general you are when you begin the more general the work remains; the more specific or detail oriented you are, the more universal or timeless the work becomes.

As noted in *The Art of Active Dramaturgy*, the more general you are when you begin the more general the work remains; the more specific or detail oriented you are, the more universal or timeless the work becomes.

Writing or Discussing an Idea versus Writing or Discussing the Truth of the Idea

When developing work, many dramaturgs often give notes, but use vague language. The questions either lack strength or the openness needed to fuel creative thought that moves artists toward clarity. The following questions will not help most writers focus on generating essential facts:

"We need to know more about the character, how is she bad; how does she love?"

"We need more humor in the second act or what we're calling the second act."

"What can we have to better understand this world and these people?"

Whether offered as responses to dramas, comedies, or plays about people of color, the aforementioned comments give the appearance of collaborators communicating, in truth, these questions lead to artists talking around the issues and each other.

Discussions where artists talk about characters lead to discussions that circumvent identifying the critical points or the play's facts rather than how to use those facts to propel the action forward. An active dramaturg either uses open questions to generate a discussion that unearths ways to move the play forward or pinpoints where facts serve as exposition only so that these facts might inspire action in addition to setting the scene.

Poor adjustments and questions lead writers to write to the idea and not what's needed to craft an active, forward-thinking adjustment. When writing the idea

(as with performing or directing the idea), one engages in the general outline or impression of what embodies an emotion, thought, or personality. When developing a play, everyone seeks to have the rewrites focused on writing the truth of the idea.

To write the truth of the idea means to identify and articulate the unique aspects for that world, character, or moment. To write the truth requires a commitment to rigorous detail, rich prose that activates situations and characters and propels them to do something specific and exciting. For example, a character isn't just rushed; a character is late to pick up a child from daycare. Or, a character isn't just hungry; a character has picked up his favorite barbeque after a long day of traveling in the car, and the temptation to sneak a bit is too great. The joys and concerns such specific distinctions bring will pervade many lines of dialogue and moments of performance.

This attention to detail or commitment to truth may lead to the decision to fashion a new form for the story, or place a new story within an old form. If the choices are active or leave room for active interpretation on stage, the prose will avoid sounding leaden or weighing the scene down; the writing will be on the verge of innovative.

Many who read manuscripts—original works or adaptations or translations—look for plays by those who write truths rather than the *ideas* of truths. Yes, an ability to use language, time, metaphor, and imagery in unexpected ways remains paramount, but in the end, a story that evokes new understanding and relationship to the world through laughter, tears, heady ideas, or a combination of all three attracts more attention. So, if the process of rewriting suggests that the story is so explosive an audience and cast need it shrouded in a more recognizable form or formula, that's fine. If the character's story comes across more clearly and reaches more people, then excellent. Take time to ensure that the unique insights remain lucid and exciting.

Simpler Not More Complex

When executing rewrites or incorporating change, many mistakenly opt for more over less; not more specifics or substance, just more—details, words, ideas. Active dramaturgs and active playwrights look to enhance a project's effectiveness by honing in on what accomplishes most, works best, and retains the voice of the character and the play without overwhelming the script. Any artist can add detail to a scene, but the strongest artists with the clearest vision, pinpoint the crucial moments that need specificity and use the fewest crucial elements to elevate moments of the play to greatness.

Balancing Simplicity with Original Intent (How to not lose voice and its elements when rewriting for simplicity)

Focusing on The Sentence helps active writers retain a hold on the play's story, especially when a number of people are involved in the development process. Without a

clear understanding of the play's drive or its journey, the goal can remain a mystery throughout much of the process. Also, without The Sentence to frame the conversations, the writer runs the risk of leaving the development process either resentful or despondent because the play the writer set out to write has been lost. Even a play that appears clear, focused, and in need of only a few trims and a tweak or two, can disappear during a development process if the writer does not articulate and embrace The Sentence.

Honoring The Sentence helps every artist retain a connection to the play's original intent—even when The Sentence changes drastically and the play along with it. The Sentence ensures that everyone can articulate the play's goal and the question the writer explores when sitting down to write. Even if the creative team fails to agree with the direction the play takes after identifying and satisfying The Sentence, acknowledging it serves the active writer's process and vision. The Sentence helps the active writer hold onto the play and make temporary or permanent adjustments—and discuss them clearly in terms of this objective goal. Should the process become difficult, The Sentence may help the team frame and separate emotional responses from those of storytelling requirements and from truths needed to support the vision.

Such an approach results in story changes that are precise, focused, and simple. There is little need to pad the dialogue with explanations—unless that's how the character speaks—because the reason *why* behind the change is clear. It may seem as if the additions or changes will be overly simplistic and curt. Not true. The Sentence helps the writer remain connected to the first inspiration for writing and, in turn, the sound of each character's voice. The shifts in story enhance, clarify, and even elevate language so that stiff characters sound natural and natural characters have dialogue that dances across the page and in the air.

When inexperienced artistic teams assemble, four of the most common ersatz processes are: the love fest, the intellectually engaging process, the running-in-place process, and the absent writer process.

Ersatz Process #1: The Love Fest Of course a genuinely successful process can also exist as a love fest; where the collaborators truly enjoy one another, laugh, and pose provocative questions, but even when they hit roadblocks, the writer emerges with a strong draft, a strong vision of the play, and an understanding of the play's Sentence. More often than not, however, artists engaged in an ersatz process masked as a love fest, experience a process effusive with false praise, comments, and discussions about the play—in other words, conversations that skirt the issues—but at no time does anyone focus on the play's critical elements in a way that the writer or the artistic team can use to sharpen the play's dramatic action. Sometimes, active conversations do occur, but the writer has difficulty using the information to evolve the play. This doesn't mean the process was fruitless or that the conversations

Rewriting is difficult. Many enjoy the process of building a landscape where nothing existed, but few enjoy living within the boundaries and adding colors within the lines.

were entirely lacking, simply that the playwright doesn't yet fully see how the play works or may not be able to execute rewrites. Many enjoy the process of building a landscape where nothing existed, but few enjoy living within those boundaries and adding color within the lines.

Ersatz Process #2: The Intellectually Engaging Process Effective artistic teams can and do have intellectually stimulating conversations peppered with dramatic theory, philosophy and philosophical quotes, and explorations of how the audience should respond or *feel* at any given point, to glean a vibrant, active script by the workshop's end. Ineffective philosophical conversations, however, remain focused on how the group or individuals in the group feel about the idea or how an experience impacts life without any attempt to transform these observations and thoughts into active or dramatic expressions that move the story along. Using theory or philosophical ideas as a lens can help magnify an issue and (often) its root cause; active dramaturgs, however, work to identify how the root cause fuels the drama and facilitates conversations that explore this vibrant and theatrical side of the idea.

Ersatz Process #3: The Running-in-Place Process Some processes appear on track either from the get-go or once the team establishes a language and a bond. During such workshops, the director, playwright, or dramaturg does what the project requires, but contributes little that will have a lasting impact on the creative process or the play. When the playwright adopts this stance, an active Sentence for the play may appear and evolve suggesting a deepening connection with the play and the development process. Rewrites that support The Sentence and address the creative team and actors' questions may even arrive in time for rehearsal. In this process, however, the writer makes superficial adjustments that move the play slightly closer to a stronger version, but never truly grows. Once the workshop ends, the writer deletes all adjustments and ignores or derides all questions, sometimes publicly.

Identifying the running-in-place process during the workshop may prove difficult, for the play appears to grow just enough. Active dramaturgs listen and look out for playwrights who step away from the process by over involving the dramaturg or director in the rewriting and reviewing process. Yes, creative bonds should be honored, but when these connections encourage a writer to cede control of the play, the theatrical development process ceases to exist. The active dramaturg also looks out for the factions that sometimes form leaving the play to suffer because conversations focus on personal rather than critical and objective responses among the creative team, which leads to comments and questions that fail to strengthen or clarify the work.

Another hallmark of the running-in-place process: a lot of in-workshop exploration occurs, but the team fails to commit to any discoveries. Again, identifying this behavior during the process can prove difficult. However, when the playwright repeatedly avoids building upon the discoveries made in the workshop, the active dramaturg must question whether the creative team misunderstands the writer's

vision. If, after achieving some clarity with the vision, the playwright continues to ignore the comments everyone seems to agree upon, the writer either has no desire to develop the play or has difficulty with rewrites. This situation can often arise during a workshop for the play written years before or has been workshopped numerous times. A writer who willingly reveals the play's development status allows the rest of the creative team to approach the work in a way that benefits everyone and uses talents well.

All workshops include a level of exploration that provides the team with information to mull over that often manifests itself in two or three drafts later. Learning and running in place are different. Learning suggests growth over time, and running in place, the exact opposite. The only sure way to differentiate between the two is to track the artists and the work over time.

Ersatz Process #4: The Absent Writer As odd as it may sound, some workshops do not include the writer. Granted, this rarely happens, but it can. There is no question a process that chooses to not include a living writer is suspicious. Sometimes, however, writers do not participate due to unforeseen work conflicts, family emergencies, and travel delays. When the writer cannot participate in person or via video call, the process ceases to be a developmental workshop and morphs into a standard rehearsal of a fixed-text play. The dramaturg may write notes and pose questions, and a line or two may be cut, but on the whole, the fixed-text production dramaturg draws upon a different skill set. Also, because the writer isn't present and often misses the presentation, the writer learns nothing about how the play works.

The active playwright enters the process with goals to achieve and questions to explore during the workshop.

A Common Thread

A preference for talking *about* an issue runs throughout each of these ersatz processes. To talk about an idea is to focus on an idea's results or its final impact, but not the effect throughout. To talk *about* something is to repeatedly focus on one's emotional response to individual points or aspects (positive or negative) and to ignore the critical elements and how they inform the story, action, and plot. Active explorations of ideas by probing deep into *how* an idea influences thought, the actions it provokes, and the actions an emotional impact provokes leads to useful conversations within a workshop and a rehearsal process.

Setting the Frame for the Play Development Process

To facilitate an active and successful process, the active dramaturg seeks to engage the active playwright and use the active writer's expressed needs and questions to frame the process. In addition, the active dramaturg takes any revelations following

the initial readings of the manuscript, reflects on the critical elements, and connects them to the writer's expressed vision or need. When questions stemming from the critical elements fail to connect to the writer's need, the active dramaturg sets the questions aside temporarily or until a connection may be made, or it becomes clear that the play's direction has changed and the question's relevance disappeared. The foundation of the game plan consists of three components—innovative writing, a writer's passion for innovative writing, and the writer's ability to distill the play's action into a single, active sentence. (For examples regarding how to use the sentence to shape the process and character exploration see Appendix.)

Final Thoughts

The Sentence serves as the foundation of the active dramaturg's play-development game plan. The Sentence defines the process by articulating and reflecting the play's objective and the play's vision. Using The Sentence ensures that the workshop remains under the active writer's purview, because no one other than the writer creates The Sentence. As simple as The Sentence is, it is a difficult concept to master because it morphs throughout the workshop. Also, because The Sentence can and does evolve throughout the writing and rewriting process, some erroneously believe the play shifts endlessly without direction. In fact, because a strong, active, sentence provides a full picture of the play's journey and the world the characters inhabit, the play becomes clearer rather than diffuse. As the play's ideas transform the work isn't diminished. The better The Sentence, the greater and stronger the writer's connection to the play. The Sentence facilitates a collaboration where everyone is working on and discussing the same project.

Chapter 2: Building the Game Plan

As much as Sherlock Holmes models some ideal dramaturgical behaviors—asking open, unanticipated, game-changing questions based on observing that which others take for granted or ignore—he is a loner. He works out the answers to problems in his flat or while on an excursion. Yes, Watson helps, but often without knowingly contributing to the solution. Holmes is not a great collaborator.

Active dramaturgs must be great collaborators.

Active dramaturgs must engage with others *and* remain somewhat on the sidelines, for the dramaturg does not actively write the play nor solve the play's challenges—the active playwright does. And yet, the active dramaturg must, like Holmes, lead the search for answers, and also like Holmes, the active dramaturg has a game plan or strategy guiding the process. A game plan provides focus for the collaboration and any creative or critical comments a collaborator makes.

Creating a Game Plan

The game plan does not fuel one (or a number of) collaborator's agendas; rather, the game plan serves as the frame for much of the workshop and pursues the play's agenda.

When an active playwright articulates the vision for the play's story and action, it becomes easier for collaborators to support what the writer intends through the game plan. Without grounding the workshop in the active playwright's vision, the process becomes diffuse and supports the play each collaborator *imagines*. Yes, differing points of view provoke the discussion needed to inspire creativity and discovery; however, not knowing a vision prevents the team from growing the active writer's play and often leads to discussions that confuse and alienate the writer, as well as weaken the play. Creating a game plan grounded in The Sentence gives everyone a way to approach either the collaboration or the discussion and helps each artist maintain flexibility when considering what responses to offer and how these comments best dovetail with what others have to offer. A game plan helps the active dramaturg articulate and share professional observations and find common ground between and among the comments offered by other members of the play development team. Please note that finding common ground doesn't necessarily mean universal agreement; it means recognizing what works best for the play and finding an appropriate language for those comments.

What Is a Game Plan?

A game plan exists as more than a goal or desire for a particular outcome for the workshop. A game plan identifies areas or questions to explore with an awareness

of how these might impact more than one area of the play or production. A flexible and broad game plan can respond to and incorporate discoveries made during the process as well as the game plans other artists bring to the process. For example, the director may seek to better understand the play's physical world.

The Need for a Game Plan

For a dramaturg, or anyone using dramaturgical skills, to enter the development process with the assumption that the completion of ideas A, B, and C will occur in a limited number of days will produce nothing but frustration—for everyone involved. Certainly once the writer establishes the goals and priorities for the project it may be possible to anticipate that an exploration of A, B, and C ideas will occur, but it's unclear as to in what order and to what extent. A game plan allows for an organized approach to exploring and reconsidering aspects of the text in any order and, to some extent, within any time frame.

The Game Plan Defined

When building the game plan the active dramaturg does more than create a list of points for discussion. The active dramaturg works to isolate the significant elements needed to help address the creative puzzle and the possible paths to the solution. Even if the solution itself remains unknown, the idea of what the team seeks to achieve outlines the possible solution and fuels its active search. For the game plan to work well, the active dramaturg, and those using dramaturgical skills, determines the various critical elements that work well in the play and those that work less well. However, to have an effective, empowering conversation, the active dramaturg works to connect these observations to the active writer's Sentence. Because The Sentence expresses the writer's goal, passion, and inspiration for writing (and rewriting), then the more ideas, comments, and observations connected to this single idea makes the rethinking and rewriting process easier.

What might this look like?

A Game Plan in Action

Consider the following: Perhaps a writer has seen an article in the newspaper that details an unusual and particularly heinous crime. Instead of penning an episode of *Law and Order*, what grabs the writer's attention is the victim's understanding of what's happening around the incident, not the event itself. Perhaps the core of the writer's Sentence charts the victim's understanding and eventual forgiveness of the aggressor. The Sentence reveals the victim's overall progression moving from confusion to understanding to forgiveness. Certainly other emotional epiphanies present themselves throughout the play—anger, hatred, unwillingness to forgive,

desire to escape or shut down entirely—but these revelations occur in the story and to what degree the character experiences them remains for the writer and character(s) to decide.

The basic nodal points to the story's progression—confusion, understanding, and forgiveness—shapes the game plan. Rather than exploring how the character responds and reacts to the legal process alone (or at all), the developmental conversations might involve the thematic idea of forgiveness—what it looks like and what propels victims toward this goal. The conflict may then lie within how the victim debates and/or considers forgiveness and who is worthy of receiving it.

The active dramaturg's resulting observations then fuel open questions and a general discussion that helps the active writer see a new way into the story and the areas to clarify or reshape. More clearly defining the twists and turns in realizing forgiveness in the world this play defines will change the play, The Sentence, and its overall impact on the game plan as the workshop evolves.

Using the critical elements to shape the game plan helps as well. For example, time may temper or inflame the victim's passion for forgiveness and affect the imagery and metaphor used while navigating the various phases of forgiveness (or anger). Considering possible thematic through-lines will help provide boundaries for the conversation, and those defined parameters may help the conversation flow effortlessly. An example would be creating a game plan that points to how language may or may not divulge the victim's state of mind and eventually impacts how the character's journey progresses, as well as how the dialogue unfolds.

Rather than beginning by pointing to specific moments, it is possible to build a game plan that inspires a creative conversation and embraces any comments from the creative team. However, at some point the active dramaturg must focus on specific moments to develop, clarify, or strengthen.

The Game Plan and Moments of Zen

Moments of Zen are those moments in the play that work extremely well and tangibly support The Sentence or the ideas that the play advocates. The moments of Zen provide the writer an example of what works—and how it works—so that the writer can return to and use it when exploring and rewriting the script.

The possible solution for a vague character may be to clarify what motivates the character. If the active dramaturg has prepared the game plan well, regardless of where or how the conversation with an active playwright starts, at some point the conversation will touch on the topics or points the active dramaturg has identified and prepared during the reflection process. What defines the solution and the path the writer takes will remain open. The fluidity of the game plan will allow the writer or creative team to establish a language and mechanism that works for this play and the story it chooses to tell.

Moments that diverge from the moment of Zen may work for actors on a basic dramatic level, but do so without creating greater clarity in story or character, excitement or forward moment to the play's dramatic tension, action story or character development.

The Game Plan and Meditation Moments

Meditation moments are those parts of the script that stump everyone. These moments may need to be eliminated, rewritten, or the surrounding moments sculpted. Meditation moments refer to areas in the play significant enough to the story that they warrant attention. If a majority of the play constitutes meditation moments, The Sentence may be wrong or the play itself may not be ready for the development process. Too often plays come to development before they, or the writer, are ready for the necessary work, which can lead to untold workshops, great frustrations, and no productions.

Using the Moments of Zen or Meditation to Inform a Game Plan

Taking time to identify how the critical elements inform the moments of Zen and meditation moments will help establish a game plan. Isolating what causes certain moments to engage, grab, excite, or confuse will enable the active dramaturg to begin articulating what leads this play to stand out as inventive as an original story or an adaptation of one ages old.

When Sarah Ruhl's *Eurydice* first premiered, it included a character who was subsequently cut for the New York premiere. The grandmother, afflicted by both the forgetfulness Hades imposes and a tinge of Alzheimer's from her earthly life, played a significant role in the premiere production. Her presence clearly moved the play from a story about fathers and daughters to one of children parenting parents. The latter, a decidedly more universal story, allowed the play a greater resonance. What's more, the grandmother's moments of dancing slowly to music only she hears, were silent monologues voicing the joys of a corporeal youth long since past, which lives eternally within every person.

Now, she no longer appears in the play.

One reason may be that the playwright no longer wanted her in the story. Another reason may be the expense and difficulty associated with hiring an actor who appears infrequently and utters not one word of dialogue. It may be that the dramaturg did not or was not given the chance to articulate the character's significance. In truth, the active dramaturg may not have prevailed either, and, frankly, individual victory isn't the goal. However, identifying *why* elements work well and the implications removing or reshaping key elements will have on the story is the active dramaturg's responsibility. In the end, the writer chooses the path; all the active dramaturg can do—is required to do—is point out the possibilities and the possible ramifications for choosing one path over another.

Perhaps such creative conversations will result in locating additional moments that resonate with the moments of Zen. Or, such creative conversations allow the team to give homage to excellent writing before eliminating it entirely because the discussion reveals that either this scene, character, or moment does not belong in this particular play no matter how sublime.

Imagine Caryl Churchill's *Far Away* included more specific details than it does. Imagine Churchill had submitted a manuscript that clearly identified the political party Joan's uncle belonged to. Or, that Churchill had made it clear that thirteen years had passed between the opening scene and the first scene at the millinery factory. Imagine that the causes that the other side espouses were defined, articulated, and perhaps even championed by Joan. Suddenly the play becomes less of a timeless treatise on the sameness of war and more of a political tract tied to a particular era and specific skirmish. A theatre with an allegiance to a strong political agenda might receive this manuscript well, but what would the life of the play be? Also, the play would appear dated almost as soon as the first rehearsal began.

Had a draft come in with the specifics articulated, a mediation moment could lead to the following questions: How does identifying time limit or expand the story? How does identifying the political causes limit or expand the story? How does defining the war limit or expand the story?

No doubt Churchill makes the difficult decision to leave everything purposefully undefined, but note that *undefined* does not mean vague. In *Far Away*, Churchill grounds the moments needed to make the points about war and its consistent qualities such as the murder or slaughter of individuals. Whether presented in the opening scene referring to the people in the barn/garage or those lined up in hats, no one character can defend the activity, suggesting that the heinous acts aren't as just as everyone believes them to be. Loosening the definitions within the play gives voice to other more serious truths about war and political aggression; that the causes, opinions, and allies change as often as the definitions of right or wrong. Truth is slippery.

In the end, a meditation moment may also signify moments that work fine but limit the play's impact and possibilities. Paying attention to The Sentence will help determine when the writer seeks to create a play as timeless as *Far Away* or as era specific as Lynn Nottage's *Ruined*.

When crafting questions, consider the goal. When an exploration or conversation is the goal, including *how*, *what*, *when*, or *what* transforms the question from closed to open.

Understanding the Time Frame for the Workshop

This rather obvious but often overlooked fact—the length of the workshop—determines the game plan in numerous ways. If the workshop lasts three days, rarely will a major rewrite of the entire play take place. Few people can stay awake for seventy-two hours straight or juggle the various comments and then set them

to paper in ways that remain true to the characters, the play, and the play's story. Even fewer can rewrite or write during rehearsal while listening to actors read the words aloud sometimes for the very first time. Knowing what other collaborators must do to support the public or private presentation determines how much time the writer has for script development.

The Length of the Workshop

Workshops vary in time, but generally follow a three-day, seven-day, or two-week or longer format.

In essence, a three-day workshop leaves one night and perhaps a few hours during the second day for the writer to address issues with little time to devote to major writing or form questions/issues. The remaining time tends to belong to the director and actors as they address how to present the play to the audience. Three-day workshops tend to culminate in public presentations to either the theatre's subscribers or an invited audience.

The five- to seven-day workshop generally provides a writer with three days or evenings to devote to rewriting and the final two for preparing the presentation. These longer workshops can end with private or invitation-only readings. Of course, the option for a more public presentation exists.

The two-week or longer workshop or residency provides the writer with the greatest amount of time to devote to writing, discovery, and rewrites. For these longer workshops, the rehearsal period includes ten or more days or evenings and a number of full eight-hour rehearsals. Without careful planning, this luxurious amount of time can stymie a writer and the creative team. The active dramaturg plays a key role in managing the time, which does not mean doling out assignments, but rather the active dramaturg identifies ways to use time well by working with the writer to prioritize concerns. Many of these lengthy workshops culminate in private readings where other creative teams may attend as well as key personnel from the theatrical community.

For the active dramaturg, to aid in setting priorities means to identify whether the critical comments (identified following reflecting on the private readings) might result in major changes or minor adjustments and the length of workshop can dictate how much work will occur and which changes to explore first. For example, small tweaks may seem easy, but actually waste time because when the writer tackles the larger issues many of the small tweaks shift yet again. In helping to set priorities, the active dramaturg also prepares the group for what may not change during the workshop. Preparing the actors for the possible shift in tone or character, helps the team during the process. Addressing such tonal shifts in the pre-presentation speech to the audience, allows actors to work less hard to make connections that do not exist and the audience needn't wonder why the play shifts so severely. The active dramaturg sets parameters so that the active writer experiences a greater sense of freedom to explore and not feel compelled to come up with a solution that addresses a single need rather than satisfies the play's needs.

Most workshops exist as opportunities for writers to deepen their relationship to the play with the help of a creative team. Only a few workshops have the goal

of completing a new version of the play in time for the final reading; these tend to be pre-production workshops, and in these cases the play has often had other workshops or needs little development.

Regardless of the workshop's length, many active dramaturgs and those using dramaturgical skills often try to offer responses that will fuel the writer's creative process long after the workshop ends. However, everyone must be clear (and few are) which questions could impact, rather than overwhelm, the current workshop and which to address at a later time.

Experience writing plays or participating in development processes doesn't determine the number of rewrites or edits produced during a workshop. Quite simply, the time available, one's ability to understand the questions asked and to then imagine the answers, makes all changes possible. However, the workshop's brief duration can spur some playwrights on and result in an incredibly fruitful residency while causing others to freeze. The imagined or real pressure to create within a group and on the spot can stymie the best. The active dramaturg works to support the writer, creative team, and the workshop process by identifying the areas to explore and develop, and balancing those with a realistic vision of the time available. If the director has a clearer sense of what textual adjustments may come, the approach to actors will differ. If the producer has a clearer sense of how the story may change, the external pressure will lessen. If the writer has a clearer sense that everyone appreciates the challenge the time frame presents, more solutions will be found during the workshop even if the necessary dialogue comes weeks later.

Putting the Elements of a Game Plan in Place

The active dramaturg's game plan grounds itself in the observations made following reading the play and reflecting on the critical elements. As the active dramaturg considers how to shape the game plan, the knowledge that it will and should change as soon as the active writer articulates The Sentence can make the effort taken to create the first game plan seem like an exercise in futility. In fact, although a few specifics in the game plan may change, the information used to build it remains crucial and vital regardless of the shifts taken when responding to and realizing the game plan the active writer (and director) put forth.

Build a game plan by identifying these areas before meeting with the writer and/or the creative team. Prioritize which area or two will produce the greatest change to clarify or activate the story and begin there. Connect as many (or all) observations following the reflection period to these key ideas. Yes, assemble these ideas before hearing the writer articulate The Sentence. When meeting with the writer and learning The Sentence, the active dramaturg then adjusts the areas to develop, but the preparatory thinking helps to focus the active dramaturg's thought process during the conversation. If the writer cannot contribute ideas, articulate The Sentence, or identify a passion for the work, the active dramaturg begins by helping the writer identify answers to the following questions ensuring that the writer will move from a passive writer to active.

les at the core of the game plan are preparation and flexible thought.

the play.

ct on the play using the critical elements.

3. Identify strong themes.
4. Identify moments of the play that relate to and support the themes.
5. Identify moments of Zen.
6. Identify moments of meditation.
7. Prepare open questions.
8. Prepare closed questions.
9. Prepare to listen and adjust.
10. Employ flexible thought.

Perhaps Begin with a Few Closed Questions

No doubt, open questions remain the active dramaturg's single most effective tool, but a few closed questions are crucial when beginning a process or development conversation.

This is especially true when collaborating with an active writer for the first time or with a writer who may be less familiar with the development process or the organization's unique style of development. It seems ironic to suggest beginning with closed questions, but sometimes the answers establish the much-needed boundaries for a fruitful creative conversation.

Helpful Closed Question #1: Where are you in the writing/development process for this play? To know whether this draft is fresh off the printer, draft ten, or the product of five workshops, helps the active dramaturg frame the discussion. For fresh or perhaps even incomplete work, the game plan needs to shift toward more open questions that guides a conversation toward discoveries regarding the play's facts, world, or rules. If the writer considers the work well on its way, the conversation will probably move toward honing ideas and include a more critical discussion of the play's facts and rules using the critical elements.

If this creative conversation precedes the first reading and workshop, the length of the residency will help determine the game plan.

In the end, the active dramaturg looks to understand the length of time the writer has spent engaging with the ideas. A qualitative evaluation such as finished or almost finished, serves the process less than understanding the active writer's relationship to the material. Passion for the subject matters a lot, but a strong, nuanced connection will ensure the work will grow when passion wanes, which it sometimes will.

Listen for phrases or images the writer repeats. Probe these poetic and repeated phrases for definition or clarity. Doing so will build a creative vocabulary for the process and provide details that enrich the play's dialogue and world.

Listening well to the writer's commitment to the process of writing will reveal what questions the writer grapples with and how fully the writer explores those questions. Listening slows the active dramaturg down—which is ideal—and brings the active dramaturg more in line with the writer's creative process. To be ahead of the writer's process is akin to the audience that is ahead of the play's story. If the dramaturg and writer proceed at different speeds, the writer tends to struggle with the dramaturg or director throughout the conversation rather than focus on the play, and the collaborators risk bringing about a lopsided creative conversation.

When the dramaturg stays ahead of the writer by presenting conclusions, listening and creating doesn't occur. The dramaturg who develops tasks for the writer to execute or presents solutions that work in the abstract serves neither the play as written nor the writer. In addition, when the dramaturg and writer proceed at different paces the workshop transforms into a playwriting class. An active dramaturg does not teach a playwright how to write. In a workshop, ideas should unfold organically according to the creative conversation. The active dramaturg uses the discoveries made during the reflection process to shape the discussions or clarify questions to signal possible paths that lead to active solutions.

What did you hear?
What did you expect to hear? What do you think about or feel about what you saw or heard? What questions arise?

Helpful Closed Question #2: What is the best single sentence to describe the play's story, action, and plot? If the writer believes the play is further along than the creative team, it's important to begin where the writer is and immediately identify The Sentence for the play. Regardless of how difficult or easy the writer finds it to articulate The Sentence, the play's through-line will provide the frame for all the work to come. In this instance, the writer will fashion a sentence that tells the creative team that they misunderstood the play—as a group—or that what the writer wants to write and what's on the page does not align. Either way, the work needed for this workshop will become clear; identify which story the writer wishes to tell—the story coming across on the page or the story articulated in The Sentence.

Helpful Closed Question #3: What ignites your passion for this story each time you pick up a pen or sit down at the computer? This question usually leads directly to a conversation that defines The Sentence. Often before a writer succinctly articulates what shapes and propels the play's themes, the writer can identify what sparked the creative journey. The roots for the inspiration will inform all subsequent creative discussions and in a manner or language that the writer can relate. This conversation about passion—dominated and directed by the writer—introduces the elements that, along with The Sentence, will ground the game plan, and at some point the active dramaturg will find a way to connect most, if not all, of the comments following the reflection process to this exchange. Using

the writer's language, words, or passions will make it possible for the collaboration to follow the writer's vision and avoid moving ahead of the writer.

Ideas That Sound Distinct but Are Actually One in the Same

When an active dramaturg begins to build a game plan, numerous observations, questions, and ideas may come to mind while reflecting on the play and when listening to the active writer discuss the play. The active dramaturg works to separate the received information into a set of categories noting which are similar and which herald creative challenges. This task helps avoid overwhelming the other artists with a lot of notes and fractured ideas, and makes it possible for the active dramaturg to identify when others raise similar ideas or observations even when worded differently. Inevitably, those seemingly different and disparate ideas will rise to the surface and distract the entire creative team unless the active dramaturg helps to corral them. The active dramaturg does the same with the ideas and questions that function as yet another hurdle to be cleared and those that correspond to a previously identified obstacle. Lessening the magnitude of rewriting remains the active dramaturg's chief responsibility when crafting the dramaturgical game plan.

Identifying Sacred Cows

At some point in the creative process, artists identify their sacred cows—the things they absolutely want to see make it into the project (or wish to banish forever). For example, an active writer may want to preserve a character who speaks only two lines; or, a writer may never want to divide a two-act play into two distinct one acts. The active dramaturg works to represent the play's sacred cows and listens for the writer's must-haves. The ability to identify and define these must-haves makes it possible to hear when other members of the creative team propose game plans or critiques that ignore or conflict with the sacred cows. This happens more than one might imagine. When the team fails to acknowledge sacred cows, the conflict that arises appears to come from nowhere and artists seem to be intractable, irrational, or difficult collaborators. Sharing sacred cows doesn't mean that no one discusses or debates these ideas or why they are so important, but acknowledging them does impact how the conversation flows. When the discussion shifts from what I want versus what you want to *what does the play need*, the collaboration improves and an emotional argument transforms into a creative argument.

Because an active dramaturg assists in shaping and articulating ideas the workshop will focus on, the dramaturg may not always believe he or she brings sacred cows to the table. The sole sacred cow should be to represent what best serves the play. Sometimes this means honoring the writer's must-haves, sometimes not. When the active dramaturg believes the writer's must-haves conflict with the play's wants, a clear and non-confrontational conversation can unfold if the writer fully shares the sacred cows and the reasons behind them.

Embracing the Game Plans of Others

Every artist will enter the conversation with a game plan—their ideas for shaping the artistic conversation. Some artists will enter the conversation with an agenda—a rigid set of expectations and tasks that must be accomplished at the expense of discovering new topics for discussion or review. Artists with agendas make for challenging collaborators. Agenda-driven artists prepare to hear problems and solutions in a particular language and look for solutions to be made in a similarly prescribed manner. Also, agenda-driven artists see time lines rather than time frames. Artists who use time lines (which are necessary at some point) believe that a task will occur at a specific time and end at a specific time. Artists who use time frames have a sense of what to accomplish, but have not determined how the group will realize the solution or by an exact line order. The caveat is that as the workshop ends or the production's premiere approaches, deadlines must be set. Keep in mind that these are production-induced deadlines.

There Is No I in Team

Because a game plan operates under the assumption of flexibility and a desire to arrive at a solution best suited to the play, the active writer or the group will find that using the game plan to organize thoughts makes it easier to embrace other's ideas. A key reason for the increased ease, is that game plans often encourage artists to articulate observations and facts of the play through objective language rooted in the critical elements rather than I-statements.

I-statements such as—I am somewhat unclear or I wonder what would happen if—begin to move the creative conversation away from the artistic team or the writer's direction and to the person making the I-statement. Of course, some 'I-statements' are needed and welcome throughout the process. Articulating what worked well for you, resonated emotionally with you, or captured your imagination strengthens the bond between and among collaborators. However, when exploring the work—to determine what themes to explore or change or which sections to build upon or de-emphasize—grounding comments with as much objective language as possible helps everyone remain engaged and motivated. Such objectivity also allows for and acknowledges the play's voice and vision.

A Crucial Element of the Game Plan: Listening

Throughout the creative conversation, the active dramaturg listens to everyone's comments—especially the writer's—in order to adjust which critical element and observation/reflection to lead with as well as what the focus of the play (or character or scene) truly wishes to be. Listening well is the foundation of flexible thinking, which is crucial for the game plan to be fluid and to serve the creative conversation well. Listening well also leads to uncovering the writer's relationship to and passion for the story.

Two Kinds of Listening: Hearing What You Want versus Hearing What Is Said

When collaborators—and this includes the writer—listen for comments or questions that only reinforce what they believe the play deals with, the play's development either stalls or proceeds quite slowly. The dramaturg who listens with this selectivity works to bring a new dramatic work in line with preexisting plays, films, and writings. What makes working with a living playwright or new play exciting, is that the artist brings a new perspective or vision to the art and the writing expresses that vision uniquely—the essence of innovative writing. The dramaturg who listens for what he or she knows or wants may unintentionally bring banality to the work rather than innovation.

The active dramaturg listens for the comments and ideas that support the play's vision and those that challenge expectation to support original and unique dramatic writing. When the playwright or active playwright begins to articulate a vision or responds to questions and comments, the active dramaturg hears what's repeated, what isn't said, the fears, and the outlandish. The active dramaturg works to support these concerns or cleave them apart in hopes of mining richer material. The active writer may struggle, but always engages fully with the rigors associated with this challenging approach but artistically rewarding process.

How to Listen Actively

Listen for ideas that repeat with the same language or new language, such repetitions reveal either great affinity for an idea, or if little else can be added to them, demonstrates the limits of the writer's vision or where the story ends. It may be possible for the active dramaturg to help expand the repeated points by posing open questions that lead the writer to new, exciting discoveries.

Listen for stumbling blocks. Repeated ideas may reveal a stumbling block as a moment in the conversation when the writer simply stops talking about a specific aspect, point, or event in the play. Brave writers will simply admit where they are stuck and whether they are ready for help or if they need to leave that area alone while other questions are explored and answered. The active dramaturg takes note and listens for clues as to how to be of most help when asked; listening for the moments of passion and deciphering ways to connect them to the bewildering moment.

Listening for ideas that do not enter the conversation requires great talent. To hear what isn't said moves well beyond preparation and research and understanding the critical elements. It's the result of using current events, cultural and ethnic experience, esoteric knowledge, NPR reports, or anything else to trigger the recognition that something critical has been overlooked. The active dramaturg who begins focusing on what isn't said and why, can help identify ways to move the already distinctive play to become even more so. The tricky point here is to not overstep and begin writing the play, but to provide an additional context or a rationale for looking into another source for insight or inspiration.

Truly taking the time to listen will do more for the creative process than hours of excellently researched notes or apt use of the critical elements. To listen and become a flexible thinker who can support the work and help the process move forward and remain moving forward is key.

Listen for the aha moment. The discovery may have come while the dramaturg or other member of the creative team offered comments or as the writer thought out loud. When the writer has a true epiphany it's crucial that the active dramaturg—or any member of the creative team—stop talking. The temptation is to continue to refine the thought for the writer.

Resist this temptation.

Why?

Because until the writer articulates the revelation it's possible someone will restate the trigger and not the realization and force the discovery to grow outside the writer's vision. Also, the idea of the creative conversation and the game plan is to help the writer make the discovery *and* identify a possible solution.

So, let the writer have the floor and run with the idea.

Then begin the connecting process all over again—unless the writer is ready to end the conversation. Just be sure to hold onto the aha moment as well. In future conversations this may serve as an excellent window to discussing other meditation moments or moments of Zen. What's more, the aha moment introduces a new language for the writer, one that the creative team should take advantage of.

Flexible Thinking

Many mistake flexible thinking as preparing to consider all options. To do so would stall the process and not demonstrate flexible thinking. Flexible thinking does consider options, but simultaneously seeks to create a path for creativity and action. In actuality, flexible thinking quite simply means to prepare to listen to what's been stated and what's been left out, and then consider ways to either expand these ideas and comments or connect these ideas to observations raised by any member of the creative team to The Sentence or another crucial critical element.

When thinking with flexibility, the active dramaturg considers the possible impact each idea or choice may have on various aspects: first, on the current moment, scene, or additional critical elements and character in question; second, on the upcoming moments, scenes, or additional critical elements and characters to be encountered; third, on previous moments, scenes, or additional critical elements and characters encountered. Does the new idea allow the deck to shuffle into place with greater ease or does it require additional changes? If so, where are those areas and what impact will aligning them with the new idea have on the three areas mentioned above? As with many elements of the theatre, the aforementioned thoughts represent simple ideas that remain difficult to practice. The challenge lies in two areas—thinking while listening and embracing thoughts best for the play but not any particular member of the creative team other than the writer.

The active dramaturg places the following at the fore for each process: How to think flexibly during a conversation? How to remove the desire to be correct and therefore limited to only one way to realize an answer to a question? How to emulate a practice that helps others think more openly, but still moves the project forward to take a risk and move a plan forward?

To Think While Listening

To actively listen means to do more than hear what the speaker says. Active listeners process information by considering options and the impact of what's said as well as developing questions to respond to the information. Classroom lectures demand active listening, because students not only hear new information but pose questions in response to what preceded and occurred on the day's lecture. The comment of, "Good question," often follows the rarely posed question that displays a student's attempt to take the new information forward; either knowingly or not, the student sets up the next topic and helps the class flow organically. The challenge of such thinking is to continue to listen while engaging in the task at hand without imposing a result.

The ultimate goal when listening is to ensure the active writer knows he or she has' been heard and that the comments have been heard in relation to the play's needs.

Often the thoughts needed to form the question require such multi-faceted concentration, that at times crucial information may be tuned out. When collaborating on a creative project, the challenge is magnified because the focus needed to generate and embellish new ideas leads the listener to tune out while thinking, and the active dramaturg faces an additional challenge, for without care the options considered and embraced (or appear to be embraced) may address only one artist's needs—the active dramaturg's.

Taking an idea in every possible direction equals brainstorming. At times, flooding the conversation with myriad thoughts that inspire exciting, unusual, often irrelevant, and ultimately unsuccessful ideas that distract and diffuse the story, is necessary. Brainstorming sometimes clears the cobwebs. Active dramaturgs listen throughout this creative session and focus on the strongest line (or lines) that grow or expand The Sentence and the writer's passion while connecting to and enhancing the critical element the game plan highlights. Therefore, an active dramaturg takes care when listening in order to focus one part of the mind on the conversation and the other on how to use the game plan to support paths toward solutions the active playwright seeks.

Although that idea sounds difficult, perhaps even impossible, it isn't. Everyone considers more than one idea while listening; the challenge is to not become distracted by the possibilities a good idea inspires so that the thoughts assist rather than impede progress.

Without some element of rigor to the thinking, the active dramaturg runs the risk of simply brainstorming, which at the wrong point in the process leads to confusion

among the team and can cause the writer's energy for writing to flag. Using the game plan can help. The game plan's key features—reflections on themes and aspects of the critical elements that support those themes—provides safety lines or boundaries for creative thoughts. Using an observation or reflection to connect the new thoughts will always remind the active dramaturg what fueled the inspiration and how it connects to The Sentence, the writer's new idea, or any other creative team's provocative question. When an idea lives outside these boundaries, it may represent more of a new idea that redirects the creative process rather than deepens and focuses it.

Balancing Comments

The other challenge to thinking while listening comes when balancing the various comments from the creative team, especially when the ideas do not coincide with the play's needs or wants. As others offer critical comments, the active dramaturg must differentiate between those ideas that serve the individual artist's needs at the exclusion of the play's or the writer's, or those that serve a specific artist while simultaneously serving the play's needs. The active dramaturg's goal is to help identify ideas that serve the play and the active writer first.

Sometimes it is obvious when a particular artist's ideas neither align with the play's nor the writer's vision. For example, imagine a female playwright crafts a play around women only and they discuss men (favorably and not so favorably) and a male director (or producer) continues to ask why the men remain absent from the text. At first and second blush, this predicament seems an obvious case of an artist not seeing himself represented and wants and needs to have a character on stage who can help him enter and live in the world. These are not reasons to add a male character to the play or to change the dialogue. At third blush, these comments suggest another more interesting dramatic question: Whose vision of the male character can the audience trust?

The question of truth within the world impacts the vibrancy of the characters on stage and the audience's ability or inability to connect to the world on stage. The active dramaturg works to rearticulate the concern or question in a manner so that its impact on the play is clear to all. Too often creative conversations derail because personal opinions rather than critical comments influence the discussion and lead to unnecessary and unhelpful changes. In this scenario, adding a male character to the cast would violate the writer's vision, but identifying ways to include a male voice or point of view through the female characters may improve the play's balance. For example, a character may regularly share her father's wise words or find a letter that brings an unfiltered male voice into the play.

Sometimes the creative conflict emanates from the writer's decision to knowingly write a moment that is impossible to stage or design. Many active writers intentionally write an unstageable moment in hopes of pushing the play's theatrical vision. Sometimes this imaginative moment emanates from something far simpler than a difficult moment to stage, but requires a complex design. Sometimes the challenge stems from safety concerns. Safety concerns obviously take priority.

When a writer imagines an unstageable moment, the idea is to challenge the collaborators not harm them. That said, a safety concern leads to a reimagining of how to stage a moment so that everyone is safe and the play's needs served well.

When the design is difficult (safe, but difficult to build or position in the theatre) or impacts the budget, the active dramaturg faces a unique challenge when lobbying for the effect. Because the artistic director and producer and production manager often participate in this conversation, the active dramaturg's role and responsibility changes from advocate for what works in the interest of the story to one who points to comments that propose temporary changes to the play that accommodate the theatre's limitations versus permanent changes to the play. If a theatre doesn't have the funds needed to execute an effect or design element safely, everyone needs to work to make adjustments accordingly. Even when the design team has a viable and safe option that the theatre can support, the possibility of not wanting to meet the creative challenge may arise. If a more exciting design option arises, wonderful. If, however, the playwright is asked to change or rewrite the moment, the active dramaturg works to identify the root of concern, the reason or reasons for the requested change. The active dramaturg also works with the active writer to articulate these reasons and support the writer and the play.

Here the challenge of thinking while listening is that the active dramaturg considers how to serve every need and begins to function more like a mediator than a creative consultant and facilitator, for the play and the active playwright, respectively. If the design element stalls progress, it will quash any forward motion for the play and, perhaps, any goodwill the collaborators have enjoyed. It is crucial for the active dramaturg to identify what lies at the heart of the concern—safety, budget, fear of executing an effect poorly, or some other concern outside the play or playwright's purview—and then the active dramaturg must address the concerns with the appropriate people. In the end, the writer shouldn't be asked to change the artistic vision because other artists fear the challenge.

When the Idea of the Play Is Too Small

Sometimes writers identify an exciting topic or idea, but in the end it is only the idea that fascinates; the idea does not possess the breadth needed to support an entire play. Yes, a play could be as short as one second, but if that's the case, what other one-second plays combine to make a full theatrical experience?

If, while listening to the writer discuss the play's intentions and after reflecting upon the critical elements, it becomes apparent that the play's idea is too small to sustain the scope, vision, and dramatic action the writer articulates, the active dramaturg begins to look for ways to expand *The Sentence* by connecting it to other topics, themes or questions the writer raised when discussing the initial idea. The tendency to expand a limited idea for the sake of expanding should be avoided. If a tendency to expand a limited idea for the sake of expanding should be avoided. If a play is short or an idea too small to sustain, it's fine to abandon the idea either permanently or until a later time. Another, larger, thematically richer idea may be present in the play or discussions. If so, the active dramaturg looks to engage the active

writer to consider this larger idea's importance and the possibility of refocusing the play. It is also incumbent upon an active dramaturg to propose options such as making the piece a one-act or suggesting the playwright write a companion piece. This second piece may appear as a way to expand the initial play, but indeed it is not; it is a way to expand the time spent in the theatre. Yes, this second (or third) piece may comment on or build upon the plot, characters, or themes of the initial piece, but if the new work avoids deepening the initial work in any way, that's fine, too.

When the Idea for the Play Is Too Large

When a writer chooses to explore an expansive theme or idea, like war, a health scourge, or family feuds, the story can sometimes overwhelm the writer and lead the play to grow without limits. This untamed growth isn't the same as developing a play of unusual length (four-plus hours). Untamed growth means just that, story lines that sprawl and work to include every nuance and variation that can be successfully argued as necessary but ultimately overwhelm *The Sentence*, the play, and the writer's true intent.

Angels in America began as a play with an extremely large idea: AIDS and America's silence. The play was so sweeping and all-inclusive that it was initially nearly double its current length, if not longer. Aside from dividing the initial work into two plays, then dramaturg Oscar Eustis also worked to facilitate the identification of a central dramatic story: what hiding any part of our true self does to us and the people (institutions) we love. With a more focused vision it is possible to create a number of poignant and affecting scenes dealing with American institutions that were actively ignoring not AIDS per se but a community of people who contribute (positively or negatively) to the success of our nation.

When the Ideas Suggested Take the Play Far Afield

Sometimes an idea presented is as wrong as wrong can be. Take, for example, an all-female play written by a female that may include discussions of one or many male characters and a collaborator insists on adding a male character. Or, imagine the opposite: a male world written by a male writer and women are discussed throughout. The inclusion of a female character might, once again be completely wrong. And yes, a male can write an all-female play and a female an all-male play, but the idea remains the same: the world on stage focuses on one gender and adding a member of the opposite sex because it may help members of the audience (or members of the creative team) better relate to the world demonstrates a wrong idea that if employed can and will take a play far afield. The reason or need for adding the character has nothing to do with the play's needs, only the needs of a small group of artists who erroneously believe the audience must see themselves somewhere on stage to engage with the story.

Many August Wilson plays, most with successful and lucrative Broadway runs, do not include Caucasian characters (or those of other ethnicities) to put non-African

Americans in the audience at ease. And yet, many a playwright of color must field suggestions to include references that Caucasian members of the theatre-going audience might understand or provide ways for these patrons to more easily connect with the story. How often do producers, theatres, or collaborators ask Caucasian writers to add references that would help people of color enter the dramatic world with ease? The expectation is that people of color will learn to see beyond color and ethnicity, but the same does not hold true for Caucasian audiences. The active dramaturg recognizes that this inequity exists and works with the active playwright to resist this outdated rationale.

Rarely will anyone articulate the real reason for making a suggestion that takes a play off track such as the example mentioned above. Instead a rationale such as needing to hear this character's perspective because so many discuss him (or her) might be offered. In the end, however, such offerings present smoke screens for personal discomfort and needs. If the red-herring argument gains traction, and the writer appears overwhelmed, an active dramaturg can help refocus the conversation in two ways: first, to identify the flaws in the argument; and second, to identify and articulate the larger concern and lead an exploration that may address those concerns without disturbing the writer's original intent and the play's needs.

Identifying the Flaws in the Argument No question a great deal of tact is required if one plans to identify the flaws in the aforementioned argument of demystifying characters to appeal to audiences. When teams have collaborated often or a newly assembled team has a strong rapport, less tact may be required. Either way, this choice holds many dangers. No one wants to hear that the impetus for a suggestion rests exclusively in a personal need. In fact, taking this path inevitably leads to strong arguments, feelings of ill will, and may result in the active dramaturg losing a place at the creative table. Even if the writer (and director) agrees with the dramaturg, the risks associated with this choice may outweigh the benefits making it a last (last) resort, which is not to suggest the active dramaturg should avoid the conversation.

Seeking to Identify and Articulate the Larger Concern Taking the time, and it requires less than imagined, to explore the challenging comment not only averts an explosion around the table but may uncover ways to strengthen the play and its story. And please note, this applies to an oft-repeated comment or one that seems to have taken hold, and it clearly should not have.

For the example above, the active dramaturg looks to identify what questions adding a member of the opposite sex would answer. Posing the question simply—if a male (female) character were added, what might we learn? This question can lead to a focused discussion and expand simply to include each character or thematic idea by extending the question to, “might we learn about X?” Beginning generally and then moving toward specific explorations of various areas within the play, will allow the suggestion to be explored by the person or persons who suggested it. Either the idea will disappear as connections become extremely muddy and everyone clearly

sees that this idea distracts rather than clarifies the play, or the conversation will begin to reveal an area of genuine concern and ways the current cast of characters can address the problem. The solution may remain unclear, but a tangible, text-based reason for the stumbling block emerges.

For example, the answer to the question, “What will we learn?” may reveal a desire to better understand the nature of the relationship between the male and the female characters. If the play enriches the female character but her perception of her interactions with a male (as described above) remains vague, and the ability to identify a truth for performance diminished, the writer needs to clarify the woman's connection to the new, male, relationship. In the end the writer may not necessarily add an additional character to improve the other characters' dialogue to convey deeper thinking regarding the influence males have on the female characters within the play.

The difficult shift for most during a creative conversation when grappling with an idea that exists well outside the play's world, is to help others see the value of the thought that inspired the idea. It may take time to separate the insight from the original conversation, but the active dramaturg should not shy away from the challenge. Although identifying the root reason behind a suggestion may not be long to discern, conveying the importance of what inspired it—if and only if the thoughts lie outside personal taste—probably will.

Sometimes a suggestion is so right everyone stops and just knows it's the direction the piece should expand even if the idea leads the work in a wholly new direction. This is when the active dramaturg can be most effective. Here the active dramaturg can underscore and articulate how and where the play already supports the idea and where the new shifts may work best. Ultimately, however, the active dramaturg works to corral the ideas and the changes it requires in a way that synthesizes and simplifies the effort needed so that the task of rewriting remains exciting and avoids appearing burdensome and difficult. An effective active dramaturg simply and clearly identifies three of the play's major thematic ideas that will make this major shift in creative thinking appear as simple as cutting a stage direction and changing a typo.

So then what is the game plan?

A game plan is simply an approach that allows the active dramaturg to use questions that arise after reflecting on the critical elements to attain a clear response from the active playwright's Sentence for the play.

KEY TO A GAME PLAN

1. Discover the play's story.
2. Identify the play's Sentence.
3. Tune the play's voice so that the moments and characters exist in the same world.

Final Thoughts

It's possible to misunderstand new-play dramaturgy and walk away thinking it is a process defined by do this and then do that; pose a question and then listen to others think aloud. However, just as an actor's process is more than memorizing lines

play development is similarly more complex and involved. The active dramaturg listens for ways to connect observations to the writer's passions or concerns and for patterns to emerge. The active dramaturg works to shine a light on possible solutions by using the writer's language to further define the world.

Because the active dramaturg and the creative team cannot craft a new written version—only the playwright can—they come to the workshop with open questions and reflections to fuel the creative process. As the writer shares a vision and responds to questions posed, the active dramaturg arranges the information in ways that support the writer's vision. The vagueries that arise (regardless of how the active dramaturg assembles observations and reflections) in light of new juxtapositions the writer's vision suggests adds to the game plan as well.

Game plans improve the active dramaturg's ability to respond to the writer's needs and vision while balancing the play's questions and needs. The game plan serves as the ever fixed mark for the dramaturg.

Ways to accomplish tasks (helping artists clear the time away and seeing the tasks as small, but having great impact on many parts) comprise the game plan that the active dramaturg develops in order to facilitate and support flexible thinking.

In the end, the game plan consists of the thoughts and the process that will frame the development process in ways that encourage the best use of time and resources (other collaborators) to explore the writer's vision and the play's needs.

PART II: Active Dramaturgy, Active Playwriting, and the Workshop

Other Scholarly Sources

"After Chekhov: The Three Sisters of Beth Henley, Wendy Wasserstein, Timberlake Wertenbaker, and Blake Morrison," Verna A. Foster

Exploration of four adaptations and how they handle the educated women characters through a modern feminist lens. Discusses Chekhovian mood, concept of "Moscow" in each adaptation, and explores each adaptations complicity with source text.

"Adapting Chekhovian Mood," Tatiana Smorodinskaya

Discusses film adaptations of Chekhov compared to theatrical adaptations with a focus on the "Chekhovian" mood.

"Adapting Chekhov: A Primer for Dramaturgs," Valleri J. Robinson

A pedagogical overview of teaching dramaturgy and adaptation of Chekhov to students, with an emphasis on the adaptations of Chekhov's short stories in the *Orchards* collection of plays.

A Theory of Adaptation, Linda Hutcheon

How/What/when/Where/Why of adaptations including exploration of concepts of forms, contexts, audiences (aware and unaware of source), and process. "What is involved in adapting can be a process of appropriation, of taking possession of another's story, and filtering it, in a sense, through one's own sensibility, interests, and talents. Therefore, adapters are first interpreters and then creators" (18).

"Robert Strurua's *Three Sisters*," Nick Worrall

Description of a postmodern adaptation with detailed production notes: "characters are painfully aware of their own absurdity... Tragic one minute and comic the next, these actors do not so much perform Chekhov as express his very essence" (80).

"Chekhov's Stories and the Plays," Donald Rayfield

Exploration and comparison of plays and how they echo themes and characters in his short stories: "Chekhov's plays can best be understood through short stories whose characters, situations, techniques, and even phrases they recycle" (204).

"The Stage Representation of Chekhov's Women," Cynthia Marsh

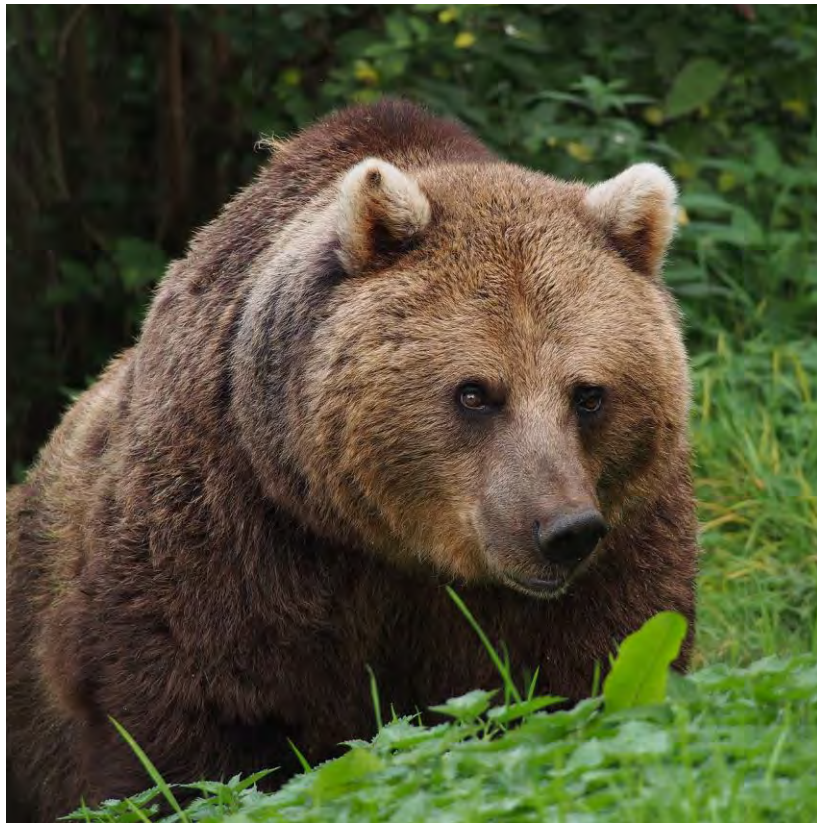
Survey of classification and analysis of Chekhov's women characters.



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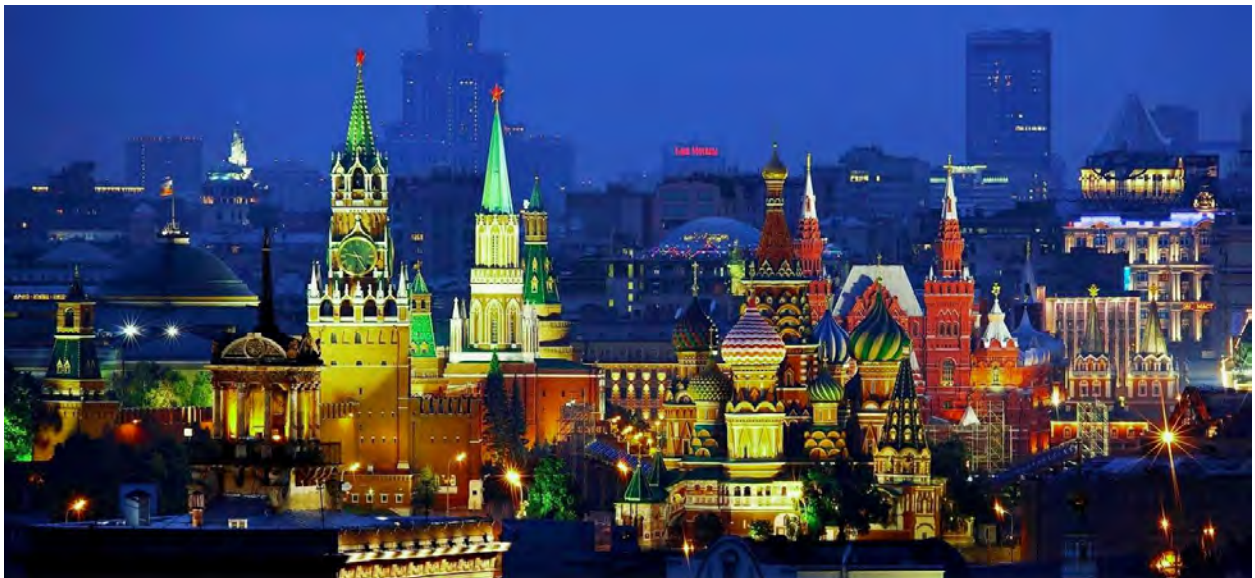


<http://www.terriwindling.com/blog/bears-bear-lore/>





<http://russiatrek.org/blog/nature/tranquil-rural-landscapes-of-provincial-russia/>



<http://moscowrussian.com/tag/moscow-skyline/>



<https://www.shutterstock.com/video/clip-8077897-stock-footage-russia-moscow-skyscrapers-of-the-modern-moscow-city-international-business-and-finance.html>



https://www.google.com/search?q=russian+forest&rlz=1C1JZAP_enUS708US708&source=lnms&tbn=isch&sa=X&ved=0ahUKEwiz3cyQsJfXAhVO5mMKHXFJCpcQ_AUICigB&biw=1707&bih=844&dpr=1.13#imgrc=sybTH7RmhEZRGM:



Köppen climate types of Russia



Köppen climate type

BSk (Cold semi-arid)	Dsd (Very cold-winter dry-summer subarctic)	Dfa (Hot-summer humid continental)
Cfa (Humid subtropical)	Dwa (Hot-summer humid continental)	Dfb (Warm-summer humid continental)
Cfb (Oceanic)	Dwb (Warm-summer humid continental)	Dfc (Subarctic)
Cfc (Subpolar oceanic)	Dwc (Dry-winter subarctic)	Dfd (Very-cold subarctic)
Dsc (Dry-summer subarctic)	Dwd (Very-cold dry-winter subarctic)	ET (Tundra)
		EF (Ice-cap)

*Isotherm used to separate temperate (C) and continental (D) climates is -3°C
 Data source: Climate types calculated from data from WorldClim.org

http://www.wikiwand.com/en/Geography_of_Russia



<http://www.theartsdesk.com/visual-arts/theartsdesk-moscow-isaac-levitan-tretyakov-gallery>



<https://wall.alphacoders.com/big.php?i=299545>

